

THE HARASHIMA OBITUARY

SANTTU PESONEN



THE HARASHIMA OBITUARY

The Harashima Obituary

Copyright © 2026 Santtu Pesonen

All rights reserved.

This is a work of fiction. Names, characters, businesses, places, events and incidents are either the products of the author's imagination or used in a fictitious manner. Any resemblance to actual persons, living or dead, or actual events is purely coincidental.

THE HARASHIMA OBITUARY

SANTTU PESONEN

1

Maria Crahan arrived at her workplace, a DanariTek cybernetic implant factory, to the sight of a police hovercar parked up front and the sounds of an approaching ambulance, its sirens piercing the air and turning the otherwise serene morning atmosphere into something else entirely. It was rare to see the police and medical crew here at the same time, so she couldn't help but wonder what had happened here to warrant their simultaneous presence. Had someone been attacked? Killed? Was there a riot breaking out? Were people injured? She ran every possible scenario in her mind before covering her ears – the blaring of the ambulance sirens was starting to hurt them – and running inside.

And when she made it indoors, the image given to her by the brewing chaos was none the clearer. People – her coworkers – ran around and screamed in panic. The noise in the lounge was deafening. Maria kept her ears covered as she proceeded further inward, eventually deciding to stop one of her coworkers to ask what was going on.

The person she stopped was Deren Falk, cybersurgeon, son of Steve Falk – also a DanariTek cybersurgeon – and her mentor back when she'd just been hired. “What the hell

happened here?!” she yelled to Deren, barely able to hear herself from the commotion.

“Enez was stabbed,” Deren yelled a panicked response. “Police came to interrogate her about something, she walked out to Steve stabbing her, and now Steve has a bullet in his head.”

“Steve?!” Maria hollered in disbelief. Steve had always seemed a decent guy to her, not mentally unstable in any way. Certainly not enough to just stab a coworker unprompted. She thought she had known him long enough to form a thorough image of him, but as it now turned out... “Why did he attack Enez?”

“Fuck if I know. I never thought I’d see him doing that to anyone, let alone here.” And Maria had every reason to believe Deren’s assessment – after all, he was Steve’s son. He if anyone knew his father better than anyone else at the factory.

Maria pulled Deren in for a hug as a way to offer her condolences. Steve might have committed a horrendous breaking of character in her mind, but that didn’t change her feeling the need to comfort a coworker – a friend – after losing his only living parent. “I’ll be okay,” Deren assured Maria in a half-whisper.

“I know. You’re strong,” Maria replied. “What about Enez? She okay?”

“She’s alive.”

“I heard the ambulance arriving just now. Was it you who alerted it?”

“No, I think the police officers did.”

Maria merely nodded in response. Enez would be fine in the medics’ care. In a way, Maria felt bad for her – Enez wasn’t one for making friends in the workplace, so nobody dared to approach her, but her coworkers still cared about her. Well, some of them cared. And Maria was one of them, that much she could admit.

She wanted to run to Enez and look over her while they waited for the medics to come in, but she trusted the police would do so in her stead. Besides, she had another objective in mind, and for that, she needed to get to her office. In that moment, a commanding baritone voice echoed through the chaotic lounge: “Calm down and make way, people! We have medics coming in.”

Maria threw her gaze to the direction the voice had come from for a moment, then quickly turned back to Deren. “I gotta get to my office. Talk to you later, yeah?”

“Yeah. Absolutely.”

“Sorry about Steve. Again.”

“Thanks. I’ll manage, though.”

Maria gave Deren a parting pat on the shoulder and started making a dash for her office, but not before stopping at the open doorway where Steve Falk lay with a bullet in his head. Looking at his lifeless body, slowly bleeding out onto the plastic flooring, made her want to puke, but she managed to hold it back somehow. “Rest in peace, Steve,” she whispered to the body, almost forgetting herself there until one of the police

officers gave her a commanding pat on the shoulder and said to her: “Move along. Let the medics in.” A command that some people were still taking their time obeying.

Maria, on the other hand, was nothing if not obedient. “Right. Sorry,” she muttered carefully in response and continued strolling towards her office with a casualness that betrayed her true feelings about what she’d seen and heard happen here today. Her only hope was that this wouldn’t become a common occurrence.

She made it to the door of her office, digging up her employee badge and tapping it against the scanner. The scanner beeped, the door slid open, and the office welcomed her with a calming odor courtesy of the lilacs she’d bought on her vacation in Central Europe. The flower shop she had stumbled upon was one of the few that still had real flowers – most sold synthetic flowers because real ones were rare to find these days, and the price definitely reflected that. The lilacs sat in a very plain but functional vase on Maria’s desk, right next to her holocomp. She closed her eyes as she entered the office and took a deep whiff of the floral aroma, then let out a relaxed exhale and sat down at her desk.

First order of business: see if there’s any mention of Yoshiro Busujima’s murder on the Net. Maria had been on a call with a police officer earlier in the morning where she’d been informed that her father had been killed. On prison ground the day he was supposed to walk out, no less. How had that been possible? The prisons of Neo-Tokyo were supposed to be some

of the most secure in the world. She danced her fingers across the holographic keyboard of the computer as she typed in her Net search query: “Yoshiro Busujima murder”. No results. Evidently the news hadn’t reached the press yet, or if it had, they’d deemed it wasn’t worth reporting on. After all, Yoshiro was a nobody compared to another figure that had died recently – Yosuke Harashima, coincidentally the CEO of the company Maria worked for, among many others. She’d heard the news on her way to work. Officially, his cause of death was undisclosed, but police involvement suggested a murder. Maybe that was why they had come here to interrogate Enez.

But why Enez specifically? What did she have to do with Harashima’s death? Maria didn’t pretend to know the first thing about it, but she was worried about Enez either way. She hoped she wouldn’t get into trouble.

“Now you show up,” came an irritated voice from Maria’s doorway. She looked up from her holocomp and was greeted by the sight of her boss, Martin Stokes. An unpleasant man in every way possible, but Maria didn’t dare say that to his face, lest she get fired.

“Sorry I missed the party,” Maria replied sarcastically. “Anything you want me for?”

“Not right now. Just wanted to say hi. Keep your comm line open, though.”

“Will do,” Maria replied with a raised thumb.

Upon hearing Maria’s affirmative, Martin walked off without another word, leaving her to her own devices. When

she was sure no one else was coming in to interrupt her, she punched in another Net search query: “Yosuke Harashima death”. The news was all over the Net. A million news articles, posts of varying length thanking him for what he gave to the world, an equal number of posts effectively saying “good riddance”... and somehow only a single mention of an investigation looking into his death. If the information reached one news network, one would think it’d reach all the rest. But that wasn’t the case here. It was as if the police didn’t want the larger public to know about the investigation. Maria couldn’t help but wonder why.

Either way, Harashima wasn’t her primary concern. It was her father, Yoshiro Busujima. She wanted to know who had killed him, why, how. And if no one else was going to look into it, she’d have to do it herself.

2

Josh Heynes and Jenn Walters walked through the double doors that constituted the main entrance to the Office of Legal and Military Operations, the headquarters of the Neo-Tokyo police force among other things, wordlessly and side by side like they had so many times over the years. The way they performed their entrance felt like a carefully choreographed routine at this point. Every muscle movement, every breath, every little noise down to the millisecond, including the mechanical whine of the doors as they parted to let them in.

A casual observer might have mistaken them for a couple that also happened to be colleagues, but that couldn't be further from the truth. Nevermind the 15-year age gap – that wasn't the big issue anyway – the real obstacle was the fact that Josh was married. And he preferred to stay faithful. If they were both single, there was a chance they'd be romantically involved at this point. But they knew not to tread where they shouldn't.

“So what do you make of Miss Harady's testimony?” Josh inquired of Jenn as the two of them walked down the hallway towards the main elevator.

“Which part of it?” Jenn asked in response.

“The last part. Right before she got stabbed.”

Jenn sighed heavily before replying, weighing what she'd heard internally. "Mixed feelings. If what she said about Harashima is true, then everything we've known about him was nothing but a carefully crafted illusion. A facade to hide his true nature from the world." She paused for another sigh, then continued: "I'm concerned about her safety as well going forward. There's no telling if she's going to be attacked again and, if she is, where and by whom."

"I'm with you there," Josh muttered heavily. "We should put her under the witness protection program. She's an important piece of the puzzle with the dirt she has on Harashima."

"Yeah," came a sharp but concerned reply from Jenn. In that moment, they came up to the main elevator, and Jenn hovered her hand over the Call button. They waited for the elevator to reach the ground floor and entered it, and Josh hit the button for the 21st floor, where the police force's offices were situated.

"Remember," Jenn said to Josh in her 'friendly reminder' voice as they began ascending, "lead the meeting in Jangl. Just for Shinji's sake." A necessary reminder, given that consideration for his non-English-speaking colleagues was a skill Josh had to admit he was still brushing up on, even after ten years of working with Shinji.

"I know," Josh replied with a mix of thankfulness and frustration at Jenn stating the obvious.

Barely half a minute passed between the elevator beginning its ascent and the pair reaching their floor. They exited

into the main hall of the police offices and began their trek towards the one where the rest of Josh's team was already waiting, agreeing to speak to each other no more. Not without the full team present and accounted for.

They entered a medium-sized conference room way in the back, greeted by the sight of three other police officers that had been assigned to the Harashima case. Shinji Furuki, Devin Nichols and Goro Satou. Out of the five of them, Shinji was the only one that didn't speak English, so Josh would have to carry out the meeting in Jangl – a creole that mixed English and Japanese, with hints of Chinese. For Shinji's sake, as Jenn had said.

"Alright, crew," he addressed the room as he closed the door. Josh had been in the police force the longest out of everyone in the room, so he'd naturally been assigned as the lead investigator on the Harashima case and held the kind of authority the rest of the officers didn't. They saluted him accordingly, Jenn included. Having received the team's greetings, Josh continued: "Got some more pieces to the Harashima puzzle. Bust out your notepads."

Nobody made a move. They didn't have to. Josh's order in the moment was purely metaphorical.

"Officer Walters," he addressed Jenn and guided her to paste the new information they had onto the holographic whiteboard, breaking from the Jangl for that single line. He figured Shinji wouldn't be offended over him switching to English for so much. He took a quick look at Shinji and scanned

his facial expression just to make sure. No visible offense taken on Shinji's part, far as he could tell.

Jenn performed a series of motions in front of the whiteboard, and mere seconds later, a couple more images and some more text – mostly from Enez Harady's testimony file – had appeared on it.

"Latest addition," Josh addressed the room while pointing to the image of Miss Harady, "Enez Harady. Cybernetics engineer at DanariTek. Assigned chief of the team that produced Harashima's cybernetic penis. Got stabbed by a co-worker right as she walked out."

"Fatally?" inquired Devin.

"Not very," Jenn replied. "Likelihood of survival is 92% according to the medics."

"So what's the rest of her deal?" Shinji then asked.

Josh proceeded to explain, a subtle sense of concern coloring his tone: "She's got dirt on Harashima. Very serious allegations that would destroy everything the guy built. Got good reason to suspect that's why she got stabbed too. Assailant likely eavesdropped and wanted to silence her, prevent her info from going public."

"So put her under witness protection?" asked Goro. "Is that the plan?"

"Yeah," Jenn shot a sharp reply. "She's already too important to the case to lose."

"And the other new face?" came a follow-up inquiry from Shinji. Josh had somehow already forgotten there was

another new face – he had to turn his eyes to the whiteboard for a second to remind himself. When it came to him, he turned his gaze back to the others and continued: “Steve Falk. The stabber.”

“Could we bring him in for questioning?” Devin asked.

Josh inhaled a little deeper and sharper, slightly startled by Devin’s inquiry. “He’s, uhh... unavailable for testimony,” he confessed.

“Overly itchy trigger finger again?” came an accusatory inquiry from Goro. Josh merely nodded in response, a tangible sense of regret to the motion. The rest of the room sighed collectively.

“We’re going to have to report you to the CEO at this rate, Josh,” Shinji said to Josh like a disappointed father. “Has your eyesight gotten so bad that you can no longer tell the difference between a head and a knee?” He wanted to sound sarcastic, but Josh had eliminated enough key pieces to prior investigations that he no longer had the energy to muster the tone. Had made enough of these mistakes for the other officers to suspect that they hadn’t been entirely accidental for a while. But Josh was impulsive – arguably a little too much so to be a police officer. He just wasn’t willing to admit that to himself.

“Let’s keep my eyesight out of this meeting, alright?” Josh hollered an irritated response, then continued in an attempt to steer the conversation back to the development of the investigation: “Anyway. New priority is to get Miss Harady into the witness protection program ASAP. We’ll continue investigating

once we know she's safe." With a nod and a subtle wave of his hand, he then muttered: "Dismissed."

And thus, the meeting came to a close, and the other officers left the conference room.

Except for Jenn. She stood beside Josh for a moment longer, waited for the others to leave, and when the two of them were alone again, she laid a gentle hand on Josh's shoulder and said to him: "Don't let Shinji get under your skin. I know it hurts, but he just cares about you. Like we all do."

Josh sighed repentantly. He knew Jenn was right. He knew Shinji was just making sure he wouldn't repeat his past mistakes. And yet he had, too many times to count. Can't teach an old dog new tricks, he supposed.

"Thanks, Jenn," he muttered and clasped a hand over hers, reinforcing his gratefulness for her support. A moment later, both of their hands fell off his shoulder in a synchronized motion.

"Want me to go check on our stabbing victim?" Jenn then asked Josh.

"Sure," Josh replied neutrally, neither ordering nor stopping her. "If you need me, I'll be in my office."

"Roger," Jenn muttered affirmatively and walked out of the conference room, with Josh following and heading towards his own office not long afterwards.

3

Jenn walked through the labyrinthine corridors of the infirmary floor with a hop to her step that betrayed her concern for the latest witness in the Harashima case. There was no knowing the level of risk Miss Harady had put herself in by telling the police what she knew about Yosuke Harashima. If a coworker had stabbed her right as she walked out of the interrogation in an attempt to silence her, what was the likelihood of it happening again? Jenn wasn't sure, but she prayed it would end up being an isolated incident. That the only person that wanted her dead had been eliminated, courtesy of Josh's overly itchy trigger finger.

She continued forward, greeting staff as she passed them by, and eventually came up to the reception desk. "Hi," she hollered to the young man behind the counter, who responded with equal cheer. "Came by to check on Enez Harady. Which room is she in?"

"That'd be room 265," the man replied. His voice was oddly soothing. Looked handsome as well, Jenn thought to herself. She didn't come by here often, so she was only so familiar with most of the building's medical staff. She wondered if this dashing gentleman was one of the medics or only worked re-

ception – it wasn't unusual for some medics to occasionally have to work reception, that much she did know.

"265?" she repeated, and the man gave her a confirmatory nod. "Great. Thanks," she thanked the man and turned towards the hallway where room 265 would be.

On her way, she saw a figure in the distance that she didn't expect to run into on the infirmary floor, walking towards her. The figure spoke first as he recognized her. "Ah. Hi, Jenn."

"Hey, Koji."

Koji Hodo, another police officer. Second longest-serving in the Neo-Tokyo force right after Josh. "Didn't expect to see you here," Jenn hollered to Koji in a surprised tone.

"Just taking a little walk," Koji replied. "Felt like I couldn't breathe up there. Air's so much better on this floor. Good for the joints, you know."

"Yeah. Proper air conditioning works wonders, eh?"

"It really does." Koji threw his arms skyward in a stretching motion so as to demonstrate. "So anyway, what are you doing down here?"

"Checking in on a witness. Got stabbed, should be down here somewhere."

"The DanariTek girl?"

"Yeah. How'd you know?"

"Shinji filled me in on her. I know I'm not assigned to the Harashima case, but I was curious."

"Uh-huh." It wasn't uncommon for the police to casually talk about ongoing cases, even when two officers were assigned

to completely different ones, but she'd always figured Shinji was the type to *not* partake in such conversation. It wasn't against protocol, though, so she didn't care. Much.

"Anyway, catch you later," she said in farewell to Koji and continued her trek towards room 265.

"Sure," Koji hollered in response behind her. "See ya."

A stinging sensation woke Enez up from her slumber. She wasn't sure how long she'd been out for, nor where she was now. Not the DanariTek facility, that much she *was* sure of. No room in there looked as sterile as this one. Or had beds, let alone ones that felt this uncomfortable. If she didn't know any better, she would have come to the conclusion that she was in a torture chamber just based off that impression.

The color scheme of her surroundings told her that she'd been wheeled to an infirmary of some kind. Then she remembered the stinging sensation that'd jolted her awake, remembered something thin and sharp embedding into her stomach, remembered passing out with it still inserted.

She looked down to where the "weapon" had been and found that it'd been removed and replaced with bandages. Then, a voice echoed from her right side: "Welcome back."

Looking to the direction of the voice, Enez was greeted by an oddly familiar face, though one she'd only seen once prior. It took her a few seconds to place it – it was one of the

police officers that'd come by DanariTek to interrogate her. The one that'd called the medics to her rescue. Enez's expression remained a stony mask of indifference as she stared at the woman.

"Jenn Walters," she reintroduced herself. "Wanted to come by and check in on you. Feeling okay?"

Enez tried to produce a "Yeah" in response, but her throat was so dry it turned her attempt to speak into a raspy cough. Jenn grabbed a glass of water from a nearby desk and handed it to her, then assisted her in sitting up so she could actually gulp it down.

Enez emptied the glass in one swift motion and, feeling reinvigorated and like she could speak again, said afterwards: "Thanks. I needed that."

"Least I can do," Jenn replied with a smile.

"You called the medics, right?"

"That I did. Couldn't just leave you to bleed to death after what you told us."

The interrogation. It was coming back to Enez. What she told the cops... about Harashima. "What I..." she began in a raspy half-whisper, looking down at herself again. The memories of the events that had landed her here were flooding back to her. She turned her gaze back to Jenn and asked her, as if to confirm her own theory: "Did I spill too much?"

"What do you mean?" Jenn asked in response.

"About Harashima," Enez clarified. "That's why I got stabbed, right? Because I know stuff that'd bring his whole

empire down.” She placed a hand over her face in something akin to embarrassment, laying back down on the bed, uncomfortable as its AluPlast surface felt, and cursed herself: “God, I’m fucking stupid. I should’ve just kept my mouth shut. Now all of my coworkers want me silenced. *Dead.*”

“Hey,” Jenn interjected in an attempt to soothe Enez, placing a hand on her shoulder. “You did what felt right at the time. That’s the important thing.” She let out a concerned but somehow reassuring sigh before continuing. “As for your coworkers, I can’t assure you one way or the other, but we’ll protect you. With how much you know, you’re too important to the case to lose.”

“I know that’s supposed to put me at ease, but it’s kinda doing the opposite,” Enez admitted, only marginally calmer.

Jenn smiled in amusement and let out an accompanying sharp exhale through her nose, then asked Enez: “So what *would* put you at ease?”

Enez shifted on the bed slightly, trying to assume a position that would make her feel more comfortable. More relaxed. “A motherly hug, kiss on the cheek, bedtime story... and a shot of the shittiest whiskey you have.”

Jenn chuckled. “Can’t bring alcohol to the workplace, I’m afraid,” she said with a hint of regret. “Not a mother either, but a hug I can do.”

Enez turned a slightly inquisitive gaze to Jenn, scanning her expression for the smallest hint of humor. She didn’t find any. Jenn was serious in her offer. “That’ll have to do, I guess,”

Enez responded with a subtle sarcastic flair.

Jenn helped her up again and wrapped her arms around her in the most comforting hug she had ever felt, and Enez responded to the hug with equal affection.

A lonely tear rolled down Enez's cheek as the ladies released their grips from each other. She looked down as she said with a grateful melodiousness: "Didn't realize how much I actually needed that."

"Glad I could help," Jenn replied affectionately. Then she continued with a more pragmatic tone: "And like I said, you'll be safe with us. We'll put you into our witness protection program. That way, you'll at least be less likely to get in harm's way."

"Less likely?" Enez repeated inquisitively.

"That's an unfortunate part of this line of work. No guarantees."

"Well, 'less likely' is better than 'sure to be dead within the week'," Enez admitted, her voice still a little shaky from the earlier wave of emotion. "How soon can you get me in?"

"Take your time recovering first, then we'll talk about it. You're still—"

"Time is no longer a luxury I can afford," Enez half-yelled, becoming more agitated by the spoken word. "There's a fucking stabwound in my stomach. I'm lucky none of my vital organs were hit, but what if it happens again? The likelihood of the next hit being fatal has already increased tenfold. You're stupid if you think I'm waiting until I get better to fight for my

own survival, no offense.”

Jenn stared into her eyes. She hoped the officer would see the determination, the truth behind every word she’d spoken. She let out a long, contemplative exhale through her nose, then answered Enez calmly: “Okay. I’ll talk to my colleagues ASAP. With enough luck, we can get you into the program by tomorrow.”

“Much appreciated,” Enez replied, a lot more calmly after Jenn’s assurances.

“You should still rest, though,” Jenn suggested. “Don’t want to risk reopening the wound. It could do that if you move too much.”

“I know. Doctor said the same thing.”

“Good,” Jenn replied, confident that Enez was smart enough to listen to the medical staff here. “I’ll leave you in your doctor’s care from here. See you again when I get the witness protection sorted out.”

“Yeah.”

“Alright. Rest well.”

“Yes, mum,” Enez hollered a sarcastic response to Jenn, who was already halfway to the infirmary room door. She lifted an arm and waved it, not sure if Jenn was there to see it, and shouted an unusually affectionate “Bye”.

Jenn seemed a good cop to Enez. Not at all like what she thought to be the average type: cold, stoic, no empathy whatsoever, gun in hand 24/7 in case some slash-happy psycho got a little too close. No, Jenn was the complete opposite of that. And

Enez was delighted to know that cops like her existed. She hadn't been sure if they did up until now.

Anyway, time to rest up. For only God – if he existed – knew what was ahead of Enez.

4

The door to Josh's office opened with an electrical whirr that sounded like it could have come from a synthesizer. Almost unconsciously, he hummed along to it, reminding himself of the note his wife had told him it was with her perfect pitch. Roughly an F, slightly flat. He wondered if it was her before lifting his gaze off his desk and to the door – it was roughly the time for her weekly check-in.

To his disappointment, he saw Jenn instead.

“Did I forget to knock?” she asked apologetically from the open doorway.

“Come on in,” Josh replied and wagged his fingers in a welcoming motion, forgiving her for the intrusion.

Jenn nodded gratefully and walked past the threshold into Josh's office. The door slid shut automatically behind her. “I take it you talked to Miss Harady?” Josh inquired while Jenn took a seat on the other side of his desk.

“Yep. And you won't believe what she said.”

“Try me.” Josh did his best not to come across as challenging with his tone.

“Well, for one, she's afraid that *all* of her coworkers want to silence her. I don't buy it, for what it's worth.” Neither

did Josh. He nodded in agreement and let Jenn go on. “But here’s the kicker: she wants to get in the witness protection program *now*. Can’t wait till she’s recovered.”

Josh crossed his hands on his desk and propped his chin on them before saying his piece. “I don’t blame her. Wasn’t planning on waiting anyway.”

“Is that to say you’re already on it?”

“Not just yet. But I *will* talk to the witness protection team today. Just need to give her file a once-over to make sure nothing crucial is missing.”

“She did give us a pretty thorough testimony. Do you really need to do that?”

“I do. It’s called following protocol.”

Jenn sighed, more so in amusement at Josh’s punctuality than frustration at the delay. “I know. I’m just worried about Miss Harady. She’s scared for her life, you know.”

“So am I, make no mistake. But standard procedure is standard procedure.”

The sigh Jenn produced in response to *that* statement sounded a lot more frustrated. Less so at Josh and more at what the standard procedure amounted to. She prepared to get up and leave, leaning over the desk and muttering with a sense of playful authority, despite Josh technically being her superior: “Today. Alright?”

“I’m a man of my word, Jenn.”

Jenn nodded in a manner that conveyed both agreement and gratefulness. She knew that when Josh said he was a man of

his word, he meant it. He would talk to the witness protection team today. She straightened herself and turned on her heels, hollering from the doorway when she was a foot away from it: “Want me to keep the door open for Momoko?”

“She on her way?”

“Yeah. Ran into her in the elevator on my way back.”

“Sure.”

Jenn smiled and nodded, swiping her fingers across the Hold button on the doorbell so the door would stay open for Momoko.

Twenty minutes into her lunch break, Maria still hadn’t touched her food. She’d only been staring at it, as if trying to find some answers in it, occasionally pinching some noodles between her chopsticks and letting them fall back down into the container. Normally, she’d be munching on her lunch like a hungry cheetah that just got its jaws on a deer’s rump, but something had made her lose her appetite. And she knew what it was – she just didn’t want to remind herself of it.

“What’s wrong, Maria?” came the concerned voice of a coworker on the other side of the dining room table.

Finally, she snapped back to reality and looked up. It was Deren.

Maria let out a heavy sigh. The memory of their conversation in the morning’s chaos hit her like a truck. “Well...” she

began with a slight hesitance to her tone. But she knew she could trust Deren. “I guess speaking of dead parents...”

“Your dad?”

“Yeah.”

Deren exhaled heavily, loading all of the sympathy he could muster into the action. “Sorry for your loss. Guess we’re in the same boat today, huh?”

“Mhm. In more ways than one.”

“What do you mean?” A mix of shock and intrigue wrote itself onto Deren’s face.

“My dad was also killed. Stabwound through the heart. Not something a cop with an itchy trigger finger would do, granted. I’ve already started looking into it.”

“Holy shit,” Deren half-whispered in surprise. “That’s gotta hurt something extra. Anything on the Net about it?”

“Nope. It’s all Harashima in there. Guessing the news day wasn’t slow enough for the press to report on it. Gotta do my own investigative work.”

“Sure you wanna go down that path? Wouldn’t it be easier to just go straight to the police?”

“I do plan to,” Maria muttered in a conspiratorial tone and paused dramatically before continuing: “Eventually.”

“Eventually?” Deren repeated.

“It’s complicated, alright? I was on a call with an officer this morning. That’s how I got the info. Sadly they don’t know much more than I do, and I promised I’d help. And that’s gonna entail getting my own hands dirty.”

Deren let out a concerned sigh before replying. "Suit yourself. Just don't get 'em too dirty."

"I'll do my best. Don't worry about me, okay?" A futile request, Maria knew, given how close she and Deren had grown. She appreciated his concern, though.

"Can't promise," Deren muttered, trying to sound as humorous as he could given the context of the conversation. Which was to say not very.

"Love you too," Maria shot back with significantly more humor and gave Deren a caring pat on the shoulder. In that same moment, she started to feel her appetite returning. She glanced at the giant holographic clock on the dining room wall and concluded that she didn't have time to finish her lunch here. She'd have to eat on the way back to her office.

She got up and announced to Deren: "I'm going back to my office. Have a great rest of your day."

"You too," said Deren as Maria put one foot in front of the other, the heaviness in her motions conveying determination and fear in equal amounts. There was no knowing the depth of the shit she was getting herself in. But she *needed* to look into her father's death. Preferably without police interference, at least for now.

Something quite curious caught Josh's eye as he perused Enez Harady's file, munching on the protein bar Momoko had

brought him. Nothing had stuck out in her testimony – it was consistent with the info she’d given in the interrogation at the DanariTek facility. No, the part that stuck out to him was in her criminal record.

Two accounts of stabbing with intention to kill, both from about two years ago, back when she worked as a prostitute at an unnamed private establishment. Shadow work, maybe? But that wasn’t the part Josh cared about. His eyes hovered over the name of the victim.

He punched in Jenn’s ID number on his wrist comm and waited for her to pick up. A holographic projection of her torso produced itself in front of him when she did. “Yeah?” she hol-lered in a cheerful tone, evidently hoping for some good news. Too bad Josh was about to give the opposite kind.

“Witness protection is gonna have to wait,” he muttered regretfully. “Some more questioning of our stabbing victim is in order first.”

“What? Why?” Jenn stuttered in disbelief.

“Found something interesting in her criminal record. Two accounts of stabbing from two years back, with intention to kill. Guess the name of the victim.”

“You don’t mean—”

“I wish I didn’t.” Josh paused for a second, making the upcoming reveal perhaps unintentionally dramatic. “But yeah. She’s got a murder attempt on Harashima.”

5

“Something wrong?”

Devin’s inquiry as he was about to pass by Jenn almost didn’t reach her ears from the emotional jolt she’d just been hit with, her arm still frozen in call position. She responded to him with significant delay, like a website on dial-up a century and a half before. “Yeah. *Very* wrong.”

“Go on.” The concern in Devin’s tone was tangible.

“It’s Miss Harady. Turns out she isn’t as clean as we thought she was. Tried to kill Harashima two years ago.”

A similar look of shock to what Jenn had had mere seconds ago spread across Devin’s face. He raised a hand to his chin and turned his gaze to the floor as he muttered: “Fuck.” Then, turning back to Jenn, he stated what didn’t need stating, but somehow he felt the need to anyway: “So that eliminates her chances at witness protection.”

“Yeah. And I’m the one who has to tell her she’s now a suspect.” The heaviness of Jenn’s voice spelled regret in giant scarlet letters in the air between the two.

“Doesn’t have to be you,” Devin offered.

“I know,” Jenn replied gratefully with a sigh. “But I’d still rather be the one to deliver the news. She’s already got

chemistry with me. And I especially don't trust Josh to be as gentle." Which was by no means a jab against Josh – he was simply a lot more pragmatic by nature than Jenn. And she wasn't sure that'd go over well with Enez.

Devin simply looked into Jenn's eyes for a moment before muttering: "You do you."

"I knew you'd understand." Jenn punctuated the statement with a collegial pat on Devin's shoulder. "But I won't stop you from tagging along if you want to. Could use the emotional support."

"Happy to oblige. We moving?"

"Yeah. Thing's just gonna gnaw on my conscience if we delay." And with that, Jenn and Devin turned towards the main elevator. Destination: infirmary floor, room 265.

Enez woke up to the sound of the door to her cozy little cubicle opening. She didn't even realize she'd fallen asleep again – must've *really* needed that rest the doctor and Officer Walters had told her to get. She produced an excited smile upon seeing the officer in question entering the room once more. Already her favorite police officer.

The smile didn't last long, turning into a frown when she saw another police officer on Jenn's tail. One she hadn't seen before.

"Who's this?" Enez asked Jenn demandingly.

Jenn introduced the other figure calmly: “This is Officer Nichols. Hope you don’t mind that I brought him along.”

“Actually I do,” Enez uttered sharply. The two officers looked at each other, exchanged a nod, and Officer Nichols backtracked to the other side of the door.

Enez’s mood brightened significantly with the knowledge that only Jenn was in the room with her. Pasting the earlier smile back onto her face, she hollered excitedly: “So?”

The sigh that came out of Officer Walters immediately told her the news wasn’t going to be good. Her smile faded again.

Jenn shot it at her with both barrels: “We can’t get you into witness protection. You’ve become a suspect in the case.”

“A *suspect*?!” Enez yelled in shock, scrambling to sit up on her bed. Defense mode activated. “But I was nowhere near The Falcon. I couldn’t—”

Jenn interrupted Enez, maintaining her calm demeanor: “At your previous workplace. Two years ago. You stabbed Harashima with intention to kill. Twice. Remember?”

Ah. So *that* was the deal. Well, if Enez couldn’t get into witness protection on account of a two-year-old stabbing incident, she still had to make her defense. “That was two fucking years ago. And you said you knew I wasn’t the murderer, didn’t you?”

“I did. But like it or not, you’re a piece of the puzzle now. And the dirt you have on Harashima won’t save you either. Not until we verify its legitimacy.”

“It’s *all true*, alright? Harashima was a monster. You don’t build an empire like his on a foundation of purity. I have the evidence, just ask me to bring it.”

Jenn paused, evidently torn on what kind of response she should formulate. The one she finally settled on came out as such: “What kind of evidence?”

Now the conversation was going in the direction Enez wanted it to. “Testimonies from my coworkers, secret recordings, a few old investigative journo pieces from the Dark Net that I saved.”

Jenn’s resolve was starting to crack. Enez could see it in her eyes. The two of them remained quiet for what felt like an eternity, the gray cloud of justice and professional integrity hanging heavy above them. Finally, Jenn muttered carefully: “I’ll think about it.”

“Works for me,” Enez replied, the remnants of her rage still coloring her voice. Jenn didn’t speak another word as she exited Enez’s “hotel” room.

Enez settled back on her bed and let out a breathy, exasperated “Fuck”.

Enez had given Jenn a lot to ponder. While she understood Enez’s animosity towards Harashima – provided she was telling the truth about him – she wasn’t entirely convinced stacking her evidence onto the cake would benefit the investigation. If any-

thing, it risked adding too much extra weight. The consequences of the allegations would be far-reaching if the tower crumbled. Harashima had been powerful while he was alive, and in some ways, he was still powerful after death. A lot was at risk. There were entire industries that relied on Harashima's reputation – industries where the allegations wouldn't be received well, even if they were proven true.

“How'd it go?” Devin asked Jenn as the door to Enez's room on the infirmary floor closed behind her.

“Could've gone better,” she confessed with a sigh that carried the weight of everything Enez had said with it. “There's a lot on the line. Enough to discuss over the round table.”

Devin nodded, not fully understanding the implications of everything but understanding enough. “Should I give Josh a call?”

“Nah, I'll do it,” Jenn replied authoritatively, already tapping on her wrist comm.

6

The Harashima quintuplet gathered in the same room they had only a few hours prior. Josh had gotten off a call with Jenn and taken it upon himself to alert the rest of the team into the office. It was unusual for them to gather like this more than once within the same day, but Jenn's update had contained enough new information to warrant an auxiliary meeting.

Josh took his usual place by the whiteboard while everyone else sat down on whatever chair looked available.

"Let's cut right to the chase," Josh announced. "We have some—"

The sound of a throat clear cut through the space. It was Shinji, reminding Josh of his presence.

Josh nodded apologetically, only half-realizing he'd opened in English, and switched to Jangl as he continued: "So, we – meaning Officer Walters and myself – have some more info on Miss Harady that felt rather pertinent to the case. Sorry to surprise you all with a second meeting today, but this really couldn't wait."

Turning his gaze to Jenn, he asked her: "Would you like to share your info first?"

"Nah, you go ahead," Jenn replied.

Josh nodded and proceeded to share his portion of the fresh intel. “I came across something in Miss Harady’s criminal record. Two incidents from two years ago, back during her prostitution stint, where she stabbed a client. With intention to kill. The victim...” Dramatic pause, paired with Josh’s finger pointing at another image on the whiteboard. “Our main guy, Yosuke Harashima.”

The two officers that didn’t already know about the turn of events paused their breathing for a second.

Josh continued: “Naturally, that means she’s become a suspect. And while we know she’s not our murderer, the bigger implication is that witness protection for her is out of the question.”

Goro interjected with a suggestion: “Unless we bend the rules.” Which Josh immediately dismissed with a sharp “No”.

Throwing his arms up in response, Goro commented further: “Just saying it’s an option.”

“Gotta admit, I’m not opposed to the idea,” came a comment from Devin. “It’s risky but doable. We’d just have to be stealthy about it.”

“And what if we get caught?” Josh fired back in his ‘I can’t believe we’re talking about this’ voice. “I’ve been in this force long enough to prefer not to get fired for breaking protocol.”

“Both completely valid perspectives,” Shinji interjected diplomatically. “But I’m on Josh’s side, so I vote no.” Then he turned his gaze to Jenn. “Deciding vote’s yours, Jenn.”

Jenn looked to Josh with a careful intensity she never had before, as if looking for approval – Josh could tell she was uncomfortable with the position Shinji had put her in. The glare Josh shot back at her conveyed something along the lines of “If you vote yes, I’m kicking you off the case”. Which Josh would have hated to have to do.

“In the interest of being a responsible police officer...” Jenn began. She didn’t have to finish. The rest of the team knew what she was going to vote. Devin and Goro sighed in disappointment.

“Well, with that decided,” Josh continued, satisfied with the outcome of the vote, “over to you, Officer Walters.”

Jenn nodded, sharing what she had learned: “On the topic of Miss Harady, she claims to have evidence against Hara-shima. Recordings, articles, spoken testimonies from her co-workers. But we all know the risks her info going public carries, and I for one feel like adding her evidence into the mix would add extra weight we don’t need. My question is, what do the rest of you think?”

“Definitely agree,” said Shinji without a shred of hesitation. “Protect public interest and all that. Besides, we’ve got enough on our hands as it is.”

“Can’t disagree... with the second half,” Devin replied.

“You saying you want the country to fall into a civil war?” Shinji asked Devin.

“Of course I don’t! I’m just thinking about it more from the perspective of justice. If Miss Harady truly has the evidence,

I'd say have her bring it. Sure, the risk on a public scale is high, but the way I see it, the truth about Harashima deserves to be known."

"Interesting perspective," Shinji admitted. "Valid, though."

Now it was Goro's turn to provide his thoughts: "I do see where Devin's coming from, but I also agree with Shinji. Protecting public interest is part of our job description when you think about it."

"I don't know if I agree entirely," Devin interjected.

Trying to keep the meeting from turning into an argument, Josh piped up at that point: "All good points, but I agree with Jenn and Shinji. Miss Harady's evidence would just be extra weight on the case. And we do have enough to work with."

"So we're really putting public interest before the truth?" Devin hollered, the disappointment in his voice thick enough to cut like bread.

"A truth," Josh replied sharply. And Devin knew he was right – nothing was objective as long as an investigation was ongoing. "Either way, it's four against one. Sorry."

"All good," Devin muttered with a sigh that conveyed the total opposite.

"So..." Josh hollered with the intention of moving the meeting towards its conclusion. "We keep Miss Harady on the suspect list, we protect public interest, we follow protocol, no one gets fired. Awesome."

“What about Miss Harady’s follow-up interrogation?” Jenn inquired, reminding Josh there was still one thing that hadn’t been discussed or decided upon.

He stalled for a second while he synchronized his memory with Jenn’s. “That can wait until tomorrow. Give her some time to sit with the knowledge that she’s a suspect.” Then he moved his hands behind his back and nodded subtly with his whole torso. “Thank you all for your time. And sorry again for the short notice. Dismissed.”

With that, the other officers got off their seats and started proceeding towards the exit. Josh stayed behind for no reason he could convince himself of.

He thought he caught the shape of someone leaving beyond the window on the other side, as if they’d been eavesdropping.

7

With her work done for the day – for what little Martin had actually given her – Maria exited the DanariTek building to the busy city streets. Pedestrians, people in hovercars, on hoverbikes, were moving in different directions, some returning to their homes after work, others just casually going somewhere. Maria was still deciding where she was going herself. Home would be the easy choice – the *normal* choice – but the abnormality of the last eight hours or so made her feel like she should make an exception today. But also, home was comforting. And comfort was something Maria definitely craved right now. Decisions, decisions...

Someone bumped into her as they walked by, making Maria realize she was standing right in the middle of the sidewalk. Instinctively, she took a few steps back. She thought she heard a disapproving grunt escape the figure as she did.

Then she finally made her decision.

She dug out her phone and started tapping on it, looking for a very specific name on her contact list. When she found it, she tapped the Call button and pressed the palm-sized monolith against her ear. First beep. Second beep. Third beep. Now was roughly the time Yuriko should pick up.

And she did. Her voice echoed with a mix of cheer and concern on the other end of the line. “Ahoy,” Yuriko hollered.

“Hi,” Maria replied affectionately. Then she let Yuriko in on her plan for the evening: “Up for a drink? Feel like I could use one myself. And your company.”

“Bad day at work?”

“Boring if anything. But there *is* something I want to talk over. Something best suited for discussing offline.”

“Sure, I’ll oblige. Just name the time and place.”

“Dan’s Dojo.” The dingiest, sleaziest, most depressingly decorated bar in all of Neo-Tokyo, with equally attractive average clientele – a joint perfectly befitting of Maria’s current mental state. “Thirty minutes.”

“I’ll be there in fifteen.”

“I’d expect nothing less from you.” Yuriko had always been a chronic early arriver. “See you there.” And with that, Maria hung up and set foot towards Dan’s Dojo, being extra conscious about the way she moved. *Look normal*, she told herself. *Can’t look suspicious. Just in case a police hovercar drives by.*

Twenty-nine minutes later, Maria stepped through the unusually manually operable door into Dan’s Dojo and scanned its interior for Yuriko. She found her sitting at a circular table in the back corner. The two exchanged a wave upon seeing each other, then

Maria pointed towards the counter, so as to telepathically tell Yuriko that she needed to order a drink before joining her. Yuriko nodded, as if saying “Take your time”.

Maria walked up to the counter and leaned over it, credchip already in hand, hollering to the bartender: “Pint of your cheapest beer, please.” The bartender obliged her wordlessly and efficiently, pouring her the drink, punching its price into the payment processor and hovering it over her credchip. And Maria was a measly one hundred credits poorer after the transaction.

Beer in hand, she walked over to Yuriko, who was already halfway down her own drink, and sat down opposite her.

“So, what’d you wanna talk about?” Yuriko inquired as Maria took her seat.

“Murder investigation stuff,” Maria replied honestly. She could practically feel the groan that escaped Yuriko taking physical form and becoming an angel on her shoulder.

“I thought I told you not to go down the revenge path,” Yuriko muttered, sounding like a disappointed mother.

“And I said I wasn’t. Don’t worry. I’m just trying to find out who murdered my dad.”

A sharp nose exhale came out of Yuriko, as if she wasn’t fully convinced. “If you say so.” She paused to ponder what to ask next, eventually deciding upon: “Don’t suppose you’ve made any tangible progress?”

“Actually yes, even if I only started today. Workday was uneventful, so I had a lot of time to peruse the Net. Harashima

has flooded the feeds with his own death, though, unsurprisingly. But I dove into the Dark Net and—”

“The *Dark Net*?! During office hours?” Yuriko’s sudden loudness was sure to attract unwanted attention – thankfully the Dojo was relatively empty at this hour. “Goddammit, Maria, what happened to your sense of responsibility?”

Not a totally unwarranted question, Maria had to admit. She was usually more responsible than to peruse the Dark Net during office hours. *Usually*. But circumstance had forced her hand. “I *had* to look in there, okay? The good side had nothing on Dad’s death.” Dramatic pause, coupled with a conspiratorial smirk. “And you won’t believe what I came across.”

“Hit me.”

Maria pulled out her phone and performed a series of finger motions, setting it down in front of Yuriko and letting her look at what she’d found for a moment.

When Yuriko turned her gaze back to Maria, her expression was riddled with confusion. “But what does *this* have to do with your dad’s murder?”

Maria leaned in secretively. “That cabin is the prison where he was held. Location’s supposed to be unknown except to law enforcement. But I managed to look up where it is. A deserted part of the country, an hour’s drive out of Central NT.”

“Wow,” sang an impressed Yuriko. “How’d you find all that info?”

“Didn’t have to look too hard, surprisingly. It’s as if someone in the police department had leaked it.”

In that same moment, Maria realized she had yet to take the first sip of her beer. She grabbed the glass and started gulping the drink down, immediately emptying a quarter of it.

“Surely the police would’ve already caught on and wiped the info, though?” Yuriko theorized.

“Maybe. But evidently, they’re not as efficient as we think they are.”

“Careful what you say about law enforcement in public,” Yuriko warned in a whisper. “If the wrong person hears you, that’s enough to get you arrested.”

“You’re right. My bad.”

“Anyway, that’s...” The last phoneme as Yuriko spoke turned into a long, whistle-like sigh. “Certainly something.” Then she turned a concerned gaze to Maria. “And that’s where you’re gonna start investigating?”

Maria produced a confirmatory nod. “If I want any clues about who killed Dad, I figure it’s the best place to start.”

Yuriko nodded back. “Anyone at work know about any of this?”

“No. And it’s honestly for the best that they don’t.”

“Can’t disagree there,” Yuriko muttered. A silent vow to keep Maria safe in her own way. She clasped a hand over Maria’s and continued, concern coloring her tone: “Just be careful out there, okay? I don’t know how I’d take the sight of you coming home in a body bag.” But Maria did. And sadly, she could offer no assurances. No promises she’d be fine.

Feeling a chill run down her spine, Maria leaned over

the table and wrapped an arm around Yuriko, uncertain of what the future held but wanting to tell her best friend she'd be okay without actually knowing if she would. Yuriko responded to the gesture with equal affection, oblivious to the fact that it also signified a final farewell in Maria's mind. Just in case.

The two remained entangled for minutes, sitting back down and finishing their beers in silence once they felt the moment had lasted long enough.

At some point, probably an hour later, Yuriko got up in preparation to leave and informed Maria: "Should be going home. Prepare mentally for tomorrow."

"Yeah. Thinking I'll be going soon as well."

"Wanna enjoy the atmosphere a little longer?"

Maria nodded. "And maybe a second beer."

"I don't blame you," Yuriko commented as she started walking towards the bar's front door. "See ya."

"Bye," Maria replied with a sense of finality she hoped Yuriko wouldn't catch.

She thought the alcohol would calm her nerves, but it felt like it'd done the opposite. Maria felt more anxious now than she had an hour ago. But she was surprised to still be composed enough to not shake like a tree during an earthquake. It wasn't that she particularly feared death, she was just unsure of the level of danger she was putting herself in. Perusing the Dark Net during office hours had put enough on the line if her co-workers – or worse yet, Martin – found out about it.

Her moment of anxiety was interrupted by a voice from

behind. “Friendly advice,” it sounded.

She threw her gaze backward, slightly startled.

An oddly familiar face greeted her. Though she’d only seen the face once, very briefly. But its features were defined enough to have left an impression. If only Maria could *place* where she’d seen it.

“Don’t go anywhere near that cabin,” the man behind her continued. “You’ll get yourself killed if you do. Don’t let your friend’s fears come true.”

Then he stood up and began walking towards the door, hands in the pockets of his trenchcoat, leaving Maria to struggle with the implications of his warning.

And when he had left the bar, only then did Maria remember where she’d seen him. And when.

It was one of the police officers who had been at Danari-Tek that morning.

8

Jenn was sitting in the lounge of the police department floor, sipping on her coffee, letting it do its job in sharpening her senses for the day ahead. The ever-gorgeous Neo-Tokyo sunrise filtered through the window and colored the interior a pleasant amber that did its own part in making her feel more awake. It was one of her favorite things about mornings at the Office of Legal and Military Operations. Casual pre-work conversation with her colleagues being a close second.

She was sat on a half-circle-shaped couch around a dull-looking metallic table that followed its contours, alongside the other members of Josh's team – excluding Josh himself. He'd never been one for casual banter over coffee. So much had become evident to Jenn when she offered to take Josh out back when she'd started working here. It was enough to tell her that the poor man put his work before everything else. Had he ever even taken a vacation? Not as far as Jenn recalled.

"Any predictions for how the case develops today?" came a question from Goro in Jangl, setting the topic of discussion for however long it'd take Josh to show up.

Jenn swallowed the drop of coffee that was currently in her mouth before presenting her own answer. "I wish I did. Lot

of different ways it *could* develop. Mostly I'm just looking forward to finding out more about how Miss Harady connects." In no small part because she felt bad for Enez. Poor girl had turned from a witness into a suspect not even overnight.

"Shame about her criminal record," Devin commented, mirroring Jenn's concern. "In her state, I would've preferred to get her into witness protection."

"Which would've been breaking protocol given her background," came a counterargument from Shinji.

"Yeah, but still," Devin sighed, sounding particularly defeated and deciding to drown his disappointment in a sip of his own black liquid.

Jenn budged in with a thought at that point: "Her testimony holds significant weight over the case either way. It almost doesn't matter whether she's a witness or a suspect. But I do wish she'd stayed the former."

"Because that'd place her in a better position given the nature of her evidence?" Shinji asked.

"Yeah. Exactly," Jenn confessed. A memory from yesterday came to her in that same moment. She leaned over towards Shinji and asked him: "Actually speaking of her, what did you tell Koji about her?"

"I didn't tell Koji about her," Shinji replied, looking at Jenn as if she'd accused him of an information leak.

Her expression of curiosity turned into one of confusion. "Then how did he know?" Admittedly a question she knew the answer to, but she felt it worth asking anyway.

Goro was the quickest to pipe in with a potential scenario: “Could’ve just looked at her file. After all, Koji’s one of our higher-ranking officers. Not like his access is limited to cases he’s handling himself.”

“That much is true,” Jenn muttered a grateful response for Goro’s reminder.

“Speaking of higher-ranking officers...” came an alert out of Devin. Jenn turned her gaze to the direction he was looking, greeted by the sight of Josh finally making his entrance. “Morning,” she hollered to him.

Running his gaze across the couch his crew was seated on, he merely stated: “That’s everyone already accounted for. Good.” A sign that work for the day was about to begin.

“Meeting time?” Jenn inquired.

“Meeting time,” Josh confirmed.

Josh watched his team slither into the conference room and take their seats as he stood by the whiteboard, their movements ever so routine-like, as if they were ballet dancers and Josh was their overly punctual instructor. Once they were all in place, Josh cleared his throat and opened the meeting. This time, remembering to open in Jangl. Jenn’s reminding was starting to work its magic.

“New piece to the puzzle. And this one is pretty big – you’ll see what I mean in a moment.” He did a series of swiping

and plucking motions with his fingers over his wrist comm and the whiteboard, pasting a new file onto the latter and then tapping on it. Sound – speech – started playing off it.

Two female voices, discussing a dead father, perusing the Dark Net during office hours, a big discovery... and a cabin, the location of which should be unknown to civilians.

A tangible sense of shock filled the room when the file stopped playing.

“Where did you come across that?” asked an exceptionally surprised Jenn.

“Conversation I overheard at Dan’s Dojo last night. I don’t think I need to tell y’all what this means for the case.”

A series of serious, understanding nods followed. “Internal parallel investigation,” said Shinji.

“Exactly,” Josh confirmed. “Find out who in the force leaked the location of the cabin. And, more importantly, wipe the info from the Net. Before anyone else gets their hands on it.”

The officers ran quick glances across each other, as if knowing it couldn’t possibly be anyone on the Harashima team but still ever so slightly suspicious of one another.

“What about the women?” came a question from Jenn. “Got ID’s on ‘em?”

“No. Figured it wasn’t that important. But we know one of them is Yoshiro Busujima’s daughter, so that gives us a lead if we need ID’s later. Either way, I don’t think they’re dangerous.”

“Not dangerous to the investigation, sure,” came a statement from Devin. “But dangerous to themselves. Or at least the daughter is.”

“So what’s the play?” Goro inquired. “Do we let her get to the cabin and snoop around in there? Maybe arrange her a cab ride?” The latter question was colored with heavy sarcasm. “Or do we stop her from skipping town?”

“I *was* going to suggest the latter,” Josh replied without hesitation. “Poor girl doesn’t realize the depth of the shit she’s getting herself in. We wouldn’t be responsible police officers if we let her get her own hands dirty.”

“You’re not wrong,” Jenn agreed. “I’m in favor of stopping her from leaving.”

Josh nodded, asking the room: “Objections?”

Nobody raised a hand. Josh took that as an unequivocal vote in favor of keeping the lady in the city.

“Next topic,” he said now that their plan regarding the mysterious “private investigator” had been settled on. “We still need a testimony out of Miss Harady regarding her murder attempt of Harashima.”

“Problem is,” Jenn interrupted, “I don’t think she’s willing to just dish it out in the same way she gave us her earlier testimony. Got that impression when I dropped by her room with Devin yesterday. And you’re not exactly a gentle soul either, no offense.”

“None taken,” Josh muttered in response, admitting as much to himself. “So what are you thinking?”

Having already formulated a plan – Josh could tell by the way she looked at him – Jenn gave it to him: “It’s going to have to be a one-on-one interrogation. And the crucial part is that it doesn’t *feel* like one. Disguise it as a casual conversation, lean into her vulnerability.”

“Got a person in mind?”

“Yeah.” And Josh knew exactly who she was going to name. “Myself.”

He could think of no one better to pull it off. “Be my guest,” he said with no further comment. Jenn merely nodded gratefully.

“Alright,” he muttered in the tone of voice that usually conveyed a meeting reaching its conclusion. “We know our next few courses of action. Keep up the great work, everyone. Dismissed.”

9

Back on the infirmary floor for what felt like the tenth time in the span of only two days, Jenn stood before the threshold into what was now effectively Enez's prison room, steeling her nerves for the conversation ahead. She wasn't sure how it'd go. The girl was sharp, that much had become evident to Jenn even during their limited prior interactions. She could very well be quick to catch on to Jenn's true intentions. *You can do this*, Jenn kept telling herself. *You're a professional. If she does catch on, you'll know how to handle it.*

Taking one last deep breath, she stepped beyond the fateful threshold.

A wide but careful smile on Enez's face greeted Jenn as she entered. "Hi again," Jenn chirped in greeting. "Hope you slept well."

"About as well as this table of torture let me," Enez replied humorously but with evident cheer. No immediate sign of suspicion from her. This was going to go well. "To what do I owe the pleasure?"

"Just checking in. I know I'm not your doctor, but I still care about you. And I want to make sure your recovery is as fast as it can be."

“Didn’t think caring about a suspect’s recovery would be part of the job description,” Enez muttered, sounding slightly accusatory. “I appreciate the concern, though.”

Okay, now... How to steer the conversation over to the murder attempt? Jenn stayed quiet for an awfully long time while she pondered her options. *Can’t be too obvious. She’ll catch on otherwise.*

“You know...” came the beginning of a thought from Enez. Maybe she wouldn’t have to guide the conversation. Maybe Enez was already headed where Jenn was hoping she was. “Our exchange from yesterday has been kinda lingering in my mind.”

“Yeah? How so?”

“The stabbings from two years back.”

That was Jenn’s cue to start recording. She hid her hands behind her back as she fiddled with her wrist comm. Muscle memory informed her where the Record button was. “Wanna talk about it?”

“Yeah. If you don’t mind hearing me out.”

“Of course not.”

Enez nodded gratefully and let out a sigh of repentance before reciting her account of the events. “There’s some pretty important background related to the incidents. A coworker I had at the time disappeared one day, roughly a year before. Seemed random at first. But that impression didn’t last long. Another went missing not long after. Cops raided the establishment, came investigating. I remember overhearing them interrogating

my boss. Turned out Harashima had been client to both of the missing girls. That's what tipped me off that there was more to him than meets the eye."

"Remember the names of the girls?"

"Yeah. Hisako Busujima and Nichiho Amano." The first name in particular caught Jenn's ear. Could she have been related to Yoshiro Busujima? Might be worth digging into.

"And then he became your client," Jenn speculated.

Enez shuddered. That told Jenn she was right. And that the memory was painful. "And then he became my client."

"What was he like back then?"

"Exact same as right before he died. Basic-ass billionaire with a superiority complex. Short-tempered, sexist, abusive. Both verbally and physically."

"So what led to the stabbing incidents?"

"I started carrying a knife to work. Just so I could defend myself in case he tried something. And boy, did he try." The way Enez elongated the "boy" told Jenn a lot. "The brothel had rules about how to treat the girls, and he just ignored every single one. It took my boss until the first stabbing to finally ban him."

"How'd it happen?"

"Bastard tried to hit me. Which, of course, was against the rules. I grabbed the knife, aimed for his leg... Missed and hit the side of his stomach instead. So the 'intention to kill' part is a bit of a misreport."

Jenn nodded. This was usable. "And the second stab-

bing?”

“Public run-in. I was on my way home from work, he walked by me, started following me. Realized in the moment that letting him know where I live would be too risky. So I took another route. Led him to an alley where he thought I was defenseless. Tried to assault me, but I took the knife out and he basically walked into it.”

“Must’ve been scary,” Jenn commented.

“In a way, it was,” Enez confessed. “Just happy to still be alive.”

Something wasn’t adding up to Jenn, though. For a moment, she debated between continuing the interrogation and concluding it here. Curiosity got the better of her eventually. “How did you end up working at one of his companies then? Can’t imagine he’d be inclined to hire someone who stabbed him.”

Something in Enez’s expression changed. She looked at Jenn more intensely. *Oh no. I took it too far.*

Jenn tensed up. Her cover was blown.

“You’ve been recording this,” came an accusation from Enez. “Haven’t you? You didn’t just come to check on me, you came to interrogate me.”

Feeling a burning sensation on the back of her neck, the only thing Jenn felt capable of producing in response was a sigh. A sigh that would confirm Enez’s suspicions and erode the trust that’d formed between the two.

“You fucking bitch,” Enez whispered angrily, glaring at

Jenn. Her voice raised steadily as she continued: “Thought you could play friends with me just to manipulate me into giving a testimony?!”

In that moment, Jenn had to admit to herself she was no longer in control. She thought she’d know how to handle the situation if Enez sniffed her out. But she didn’t. Pure instinct took over. “I understand you feel betrayed. But it’s all in the interest of advancing the investigation.”

“Fuck your investigation if this is how you’re gonna play me,” Enez grunted. “I thought I could trust you. Should’ve fucking known better. You’re just as bad as the rest of ‘em. Worse, even.”

Ouch. That hit Jenn right in the soul. “Please don’t misunderstand me,” she pleaded in an attempt to defend herself. *Good going, Jennifer. Real professional.* “I’m just doing my job. We can still help each other. We—”

“I have no interest in helping you anymore. Not if I can’t even be sure you *actually* care about me.” Enez waved a hand dismissively in Jenn’s direction and commanded her: “Please leave.”

“Enez, please, I—”

“I said *leave!*” Jenn could practically feel the rage seething in Enez’s voice digging into her skin like nails. It was no use trying to de-escalate. She hung her head down in regret and left the room, spending a few minutes regaining her composure before dialing Josh.

Josh got right to the point when he picked up. “Got her

testimony on record?”

“Yeah,” Jenn replied, shame still subtly audible in her voice. “But I fucked up. Blew my own cover. Didn’t stop when I should have.”

“You did your best,” Josh attempted to comfort Jenn. “Long as we have her account of the stabbings, we have everything we need.”

“I did get that much.”

“Then you got what we needed. That’s all that matters.” *Yeah... To the investigation.* But Jenn didn’t say it out loud. Instead, she simply nodded in feigned agreement.

A chuckle escaped Josh. The gaze of his holographic image in the air drifted somewhere to the side. He sounded impressed. Jenn certainly was, even if Enez’s deductive skills had cost her her trust. “Kid’s sharp,” Josh muttered a comment.

“Legally, a 23-year-old isn’t a kid,” Jenn corrected him. Drifting the conversation to legal terminology was a great way to get her mind off the failed interrogation, even if only temporarily. Josh turned his gaze back to Jenn and nodded, looking surprised by her response. “Point taken,” sounded his punctual, I-stand-corrected reply.

“Question is, what do we do with her now? Move her into prison or keep her in the infirmary until she recovers?”

“We’ll let her testimony decide that. If she has a strong enough defense, she’ll get away with a light sentence. And there is room for adjustment.”

Jenn nodded, feeling significantly calmer now that con-

versation was back to procedure. “I’ll send the file to you right away. I trust your judgment as to where to go from there.”

“Thanks. Later.” And Josh’s holographic face disintegrated, signifying the end of the call.

10

The following day at the DanariTek factory had passed by just as uneventfully as the last one for Maria. She hadn't dared take the risk of diving into the Dark Net during office hours again, but she wished she had. Sticking to the good side hadn't advanced her investigation into her father's death considerably. Harashima was still all over the feeds. But she knew that venturing into the Dark Net was risky, doubly so in the middle of a workday on the company's computers. Yesterday's dive had already put enough of a target on her back.

But she was determined to get to that cabin. To do some digging and see if she could find anything there that'd bring her closer to figuring out who had killed Yoshiro. And now, it was time to put said plan in motion.

The only thing she had to watch out for was the police. And that had become significantly harder overnight. There were at least twice as many police cars on the streets now as opposed to yesterday. Patrols were more frequent. But what had caused this increased level of police alertness?

Ignoring her anxiety, Maria raised a hand and waved it to stop a taxi that was just driving by. It stopped and its back door opened, welcoming her in.

“Where to?” the driver asked in Jangl as the door closed. Maria was too busy fiddling with her phone to take note of his facial features. The only thing she could reliably decipher was that he looked like a native Japanese.

“I’m trying to get to a cabin,” she replied while looking for its picture and coordinates on her phone, doing her best not to sound suspicious. She handed her phone to the driver when she found it. “Know the one?”

The man’s eyebrows shot skyward. His hand shook as she handed Maria’s phone back to her. “I can’t take you there. I have a wife. Kids. I’d rather not leave her to raise them as a single parent.” He knew what was at stake, she had to hand it to him. Poor man was scared for his life. Maria almost climbed out of the cab, but if she did, there was no knowing how soon she’d be able to get another one.

“Please, it’s urgent,” she pleaded. “I *really* need to get there. I’ll pay you extra.”

The driver was quiet for a long time while he contemplated Maria’s offer. Her anxiety increased steadily in the meantime. If they didn’t move soon, the police would surely catch and arrest her before she got as far as the next crossing. Finally, he asked: “How much?”

“Ten thousand.”

“Twenty.”

“Twelve.”

“Fifteen.”

“Deal.” Maria extended her arm, and the driver clasped

his hand in hers and shook it. His grip was unexpectedly firm for someone who was afraid of not going home to his family.

And then he finally started driving towards the cabin, with Maria sitting in the back, doing her best to keep her breathing steady.

Josh and his team were gathered in their usual meeting spot, getting ready for Josh to open their auxiliary meeting for the day. Progress on the Harashima case had felt particularly slow to him today. No one had procured any new information related to it. But then again, slow days like this one were more so the rule than the exception. And he certainly didn't blame anyone. He had to admit that there was a limit even to police efficiency.

"Alright," he grunted, trying not to let his frustration color his tone. He looked over to Goro and Devin, whom he had assigned as the investigators of the cabin leak, and asked them: "Progress on the cabin leak investigation?"

"Effectively none," Goro confessed. "But we did wipe it from the Dark Net."

"Well, that's something at least."

"One thing we do know so far," Devin piped in, "is that the nature of the leak narrows out the grunts." Lowest-ranking officers, effectively street cops. "It's almost inevitably someone higher up."

"Yeah," Josh muttered. "But who?"

“That’s what we’re trying to figure out.”

“Take your time.” Josh’s eyes darted to the whiteboard. The cabin leak investigation reminded him of something else in the moment. He turned his attention to Shinji and asked him: “Still no ID on the murderer?”

“Nope,” Shinji exclaimed with a sigh. “Been trying to look for the better part of a week and nothing’s turning up. It’s as if her record was wiped from the population database.”

“Wiped from the database?!” There were only a select few people with such access to the country’s population database. None in the police. Whoever had wiped the murderer’s record had to have done so deliberately. “That’s going to complicate things.” More than it needed to.

“Speaking of complicating things,” Jenn interjected, “we’re going to have to do a background investigation on Miss Harady.”

“Still not talking, is she?”

“No. She was pretty clear about having no interest in helping us further.”

“You did ask a perfectly reasonable question,” Josh said in an attempt to comfort Jenn. The way she hung her head down gave him the impression the reminder had the opposite effect. Nonetheless, he continued: “Her being hired at one of Hara-shima’s companies definitely doesn’t add up given their history. And if she’s not willing to talk, we have no choice but to look into how she achieved that ourselves.”

“Just don’t assign that task to me,” Jenn expressed an

immediate wish. And Josh understood why. “Noted,” he replied with a nod and continued: “Well, in lack of any substantial progress today, the best we can do is—”

His wrist comm chirped and interrupted him.

One of the street teams. He picked up and hollered in a slightly annoyed tone: “What is it?”

“Sorry to interrupt,” the officer on the other end said. The sense of urgency in his tone told Josh this was something important. “Got a visual on a cab with a suspicious passenger, headed south.” Busujima’s daughter trying to skip town, no doubt. “We’re already pursuing, but we’re going to need backup if we want to cut them off. Sending the details as we speak.”

“Roger. On our way.” Josh ended the call and addressed the room: “Goro, Shinji, you take one car. Jenn, you’re with me. Let’s move.”

The sudden blaring of a siren startled Maria. She released her grip from her knuckles and threw her head back. A police car right behind her. *Shit. They caught me.*

“Faster!” she hollered in panic as she turned her gaze back to the driver. Now she actually focused on him, glanced at him through the rearview mirror, took in his facial features. Definitely native Japanese, roughly in his mid-30s as far as Maria could tell. Still scared for his life.

And yet he obeyed her command.

The cab sped up, the driver weaving through traffic with a finesse that gave Maria the impression that this wasn't the first police chase he'd been involved in. He did his best to lose the police car tailing them, but his efforts quickly turned out to be futile. There it stayed, no matter how many sudden turns he made.

A bead of sweat trickled down Maria's forehead.

The sight of a second and third police car intercepted the view beyond the windshield. Stationary. Parked sideways. They'd cut her off. The driver hit the brakes as hard as he could, and Maria prayed – more for the driver's sake than her own – that the cab would stop before it collided with the police cars ahead.

It stopped an inch short.

The door to Maria's left opened, and she was greeted by the sight of a gun right in her face. She took a careful glance beyond with her hands already raised. It was the same police officer she'd now seen twice before. And he looked ready to shoot.

A feminine hand yanked his arm back before he could. Then another face appeared next to him. Another police officer, this one female, considerably younger but still mature. In more ways than one. The female officer yelled: "Plan wasn't to kill her, was it? Just keep her from leaving."

As if in some form of apology, the male officer stepped back, letting the woman handle the rest. "Please get out of the vehicle," she spoke, and Maria obeyed without so much as an

exhale. In fact, she didn't even realize up until now that she'd been holding her breath.

The officer spun her around, yanked her arms behind her back and slapped handcuffs around her wrists. Now Maria exhaled again. Her anxiety was in overdrive. "You're under arrest for planning to infiltrate a government facility," the officer told her, then proceeded to guide her into the police car.

Well, I tried.

As they began to drive away towards what was inevitably the police station, Maria started wondering how she could escape prison. In case that was where she was going.

She also remembered that she didn't pay the driver.

11

Once the police officers that had captured Maria arrived at the station with her in tow, she was led into a small room that reminded her of the office cubicles at DanariTek. Only the color scheme here was more vibrant. More uplifting, in a way. The male officer pushed her down onto the interrogation chair – he did his best to be gentle with his motions, though – and he and the other officer left her to her own devices, mumbling something at the doorway that she didn’t quite catch.

Then another officer entered and took a seat on the other side of the desk. Male, young, gentle eyes, strong jaw lined with slightly overgrown stubble. He looked at Maria quickly and then turned his gaze to something else – probably Maria’s ID file – exhaling through his nose audibly as he looked it over.

“So...” he began with a sharpness that almost startled Maria. Still not making direct eye contact. “Maria Crahan. 33 years old, tech and safety consultant at DanariTek, no known criminal record until now.” Now he turned his gaze to her, crossing his arms over the desk and leaning in before asking: “Care to explain what you were intending to do at a government facility?”

“I was planning to investigate,” Maria confessed imme-

diately. *They already caught me, might as well be honest.*

“Investigate what?”

Suddenly, the officer’s voice sounded oddly familiar. But Maria decided to ignore it for now. “My father’s death. He was killed in prison the day he was supposed to walk out. I was planning on going to the cabin to see if there’d be any clues there.”

“If there *were* any clues, I can assure you they’ve been cleaned up by now. So you weren’t gonna get anywhere.” He looked at her a little more intensely, but Maria stood her ground. “Anyway, how did you find the location of the cabin?”

“Dark Net.”

The officer nodded. Maria wasn’t quite sure what to make of the gesture. “Hm. Planning to infiltrate a government facility *and* perusing the Dark Net... Those two together are enough to put you in jail for a year.”

“I’m just trying to find out who murdered my dad, okay?”

“Can’t just leave it to the force, can you?”

“No, because I have a personal stake in this. He was my world next to my husband. I—”

Maria paused, mouth open. She lifted a finger. Now she placed the officer’s voice. “*You* were the one who called me. Told me he was killed.”

“Did I?”

“Yeah. Yoshiro Busujima. Remember?”

Evidently, the memory came to the officer in the same

moment. “Oh,” he breathed, turning his gaze elsewhere. “Right. Yeah, that was me.”

“Devin, right?”

“That’s Officer Nichols, if you don’t mind.” *Uh-huh. So we’re not on a first-name basis anymore. Okay.*

“Well, Officer Nichols,” Maria began teasingly, “was it you who also leaked the location of the cabin?”

“That’s a pretty serious accusation to make, Miss Crahan.” Devin’s eyebrows motioned quickly towards a corner in the ceiling, alerting Maria to the existence of a security camera. That told her enough.

She nodded in acknowledgement. “You’re right. Sorry.” *Don’t worry, I won’t rat you out.*

“Well,” Devin continued in a much more official tone of voice, “if you can promise not to repeat this infraction, I guess I can let you get away with a warning. But I’m gonna need you to keep your word, because the next time *will* land you in jail.”

“I promise it won’t happen again.”

Devin grabbed some sort of handheld apparatus and swung it across Maria’s face. The machine pondered for a moment, then beeped cheerfully as a green LED light blinked on it. Lie detector? “Alright, you’re good to go,” Devin said. “Thank you for your time.”

“Thank you, officer,” Maria replied as she stood up and left the room.

The other male officer entered as soon as she did. “Meet me in my office,” Maria heard him growl to Devin menacingly.

12

The next day arrived under largely usual circumstances at the police department, with the exception of Devin not entering the conference room with the rest of the Harashima investigation team. Josh wondered who out of the three remaining officers would be the first to inquire about his absence. His money was on Jenn. She had always been a bit of a worrier, especially when it came to team dynamics. Josh's only hope was that the inevitable question wouldn't turn into a conversation about moral codes and competing views of justice. There were things far more pertinent to the case that needed to be settled.

He watched his team take their seats and caught Jenn looking around the room, as if scanning for one particular face that she felt was missing. And then she asked the question Josh was not-so-eagerly waiting for: "What happened with Devin?"

"Devin is off the team for the time being," Josh replied earnestly. "He confessed to being responsible for the cabin leak."

A series of nods followed from the other officers. Josh couldn't quite decide what each nod conveyed individually. "Well," Shinji sighed the beginning of a comment, "I'd be lying if I said I was surprised."

“If nothing else, that settles the matter of the internal investigation,” responded Goro.

Josh could tell from the way Jenn looked at him that her concern was more personal. “Is he off the team permanently?” she asked.

“Maybe. Depends on how he conducts himself from here on out.” Then Josh cleared his throat, so as to convey that he hadn’t called the meeting to discuss Devin and his future in the team. “Anyway, over to you, Officer Walters.”

With a nod, Jenn stood up and walked over to the whiteboard, doing her usual finger dance in its vicinity and pasting the information she’d acquired from her latest conversation with Miss Harady. A transcription of the interrogation and two new files, one Jenn had decided to place right next to Yoshiro Busujima’s. Then she moved over to the other side of the whiteboard.

“Hisako Busujima and Nichiho Amano,” she began her recital while pointing at the fresh files on the whiteboard. “Both former coworkers of Miss Harady’s. Went missing about three years back. Harashima was a client to both of them, and Miss Harady suspects he’s the reason they disappeared.”

“Is that why she stabbed the guy?” Goro inquired. “Pay-back for the girls that went missing?”

“No. The stabbings were self-defense. That’s what she told me anyway.”

Shinji leaned forward in his seat and presented an observation: “You said Busujima was the other girl’s last name?”

“Yeah.”

“Do you suspect she was related to our other murder victim?”

“She was. Her record in the population database confirmed as much. Father and daughter.”

“How does this help the case, though?”

“I mean it’s evidence. Crucially, evidence against Harashima. The girls have legally been announced dead. And if he really did kill them as Miss Harady believes, that’s a piece of the puzzle we’d be stupid to ignore.”

Shinji brought a finger up to his chin and nodded. “Can’t disagree with that.” Referring in particular to the closing sentence of Jenn’s statement, Josh figured.

Goro piped in with a comment at that point: “So we have our first piece of evidence about Harashima’s supposed wrongdoings, but how far does that get us? Can we paint a picture about the killer’s potential motive?”

“I don’t think we can,” Josh responded. “But for what it’s worth, we have a start on that now too. Even if I personally don’t believe that the murderer offed Harashima as revenge.”

“Why’s that?” Jenn asked Josh, turning her gaze to him.

“Because looking at the files, I don’t see a connection between her and the two girls. I’m leaning towards a different theory.”

Jenn tilted her head and raised an eyebrow. “And what is that theory?”

“Nothing I can say with full confidence. I’m just in-

clined to think she wanted Harashima dead for a different reason. The two missing girls are more likely just collateral damage. Largely irrelevant unless their names pop up elsewhere later on.”

Jenn looked at the whiteboard with a slight squint in her eyes and a finger on her chin, nodding subtly. “Not a fan of how you refer to them as collateral damage, but you have a point.”

Then it was Shinji’s turn to speak again. “I notice parts of Miss Amano’s records are missing,” he pointed out.

Jenn looked at the whiteboard again with widened eyes, as if she hadn’t realized to review the file thoroughly before grabbing it. Josh followed suit. Shinji was right in a sense – a few parts of Miss Amano’s file appeared corrupted. How that had happened, Josh couldn’t help but wonder. The population database records were supposed to be tamperproof, but then again, someone had managed to wipe the murderer’s entire record from the system.

“Shit,” Jenn whispered.

“A corrupted population database record?” Goro exclaimed in equal shock. “That shouldn’t be possible.”

“Exception confirms the rule, doesn’t it?” Shinji commented in response. “That is interesting, though.”

“Any chance it’s just regular file corruption?” Jenn managed to ask.

“I don’t think that’s it,” Josh muttered in response. “The government’s servers are proofed against that. Someone is deliberately tampering with the files in there.” He grunted in frus-

tration and shook his head. "This case is getting too big."

"Tell me about it," Jenn replied, mirroring the tone of Josh's voice. "We're going to have to start outsourcing. Ask another team to go talk to the government's server maintainers. Workload's enough for a team of four as it is."

"Could be a team of five," Goro interjected with a hand in a position as if he was holding up an invisible platter.

Josh shot a pragmatic gaze at Goro and presented a response: "Even if I brought Devin back on the team, our manpower wouldn't be adequate to offset the workload. Besides, I kicked him off for a reason."

"Trust me, I get that. I'm just saying five is better than four."

"Goro's got a point," said Jenn. "I know you two don't see eye-to-eye on everything, and punishing him *was* the right call, but the more people we have on the team, the sooner we can solve the case. And Devin if anyone is conscientious. He'll make up for his mistake."

Josh had to admit they were both right. He nodded and let out a nasal sigh. But he didn't want to cave in just yet. He had a standard he'd set for himself ages ago and wanted to uphold. A thought came to him in that moment, so he let loose with it. "Tell you what. Devin can be on the team that handles the population database investigation. And if he pulls his weight there, he's back on our team."

The other officers in the room nodded. This wasn't the first time Josh and Devin had clashed, though it *was* the first

time it'd reached a point where Josh felt it necessary to put Devin into timeout. But they knew Josh could be fair. And he knew Devin would do his best to earn his place back in the Harashima team.

The door to the conference room opened suddenly. It was Koji. "Pardon the interruption," he said while waving a finger at Josh. "Josh, you're going to want to come take a look at this."

Josh followed Koji out of the conference room, nodding to his team apologetically as he exited. The two of them walked down the corridor for a few seconds, eventually greeted by the sight of Miss Harady accompanied by her nurse, the former pale and hyperventilating as if she'd seen a ghost, weak and ready to collapse had the nurse not been holding her.

"Sorry to bother you like this," the nurse said to Josh. "Miss Harady has something urgent to share with you. I tried to tell her we should just call you to drop by the infirmary, but she insisted on seeing you here."

"It's fine," Josh responded with a subtle nod. Then he turned his attention to Miss Harady and asked her: "What's on your mind, Miss Harady?"

The poor girl tilted her head to one side, revealing a mark on her neck that she didn't have the last time Josh had seen her. A mark that had appeared twice before, on the corpses of Yoshiro Busujima and Yosuke Harashima. A discrepancy in the pattern.

"I was told you'd know what this means," Miss Harady

said in a raspy, scared half-whisper while pointing to it.

Josh simply stared at the golden lip mark on Miss Harady's neck for a moment, almost failing to register that she said anything at all. But when he finally did register it, he gave her a confirmatory nod. "You okay to come to my office?" he asked.

"Yeah. Sure."

"Great." He turned his attention to the nurse and instructed her: "You can go ahead and escort her to my office. I'll be there in a minute."

"Thank you, sir," the nurse responded and started guiding Miss Harady to Josh's office. In the meantime, Josh backtracked to the conference room and hollered to his team from the doorway: "Meeting's over. Something urgent came up. Jenn, my office. Shinji and Goro, you get to assign tasks among yourselves."

The group produced a series of nods and left the room, Jenn behind Josh, Goro and Shinji headed elsewhere.

"What did *I* do wrong?" Jenn inquired sarcastically as they walked towards Josh's office.

Josh ignored her attempt at humor and addressed her with all the seriousness he could muster: "You're fine. I just figure this'll be of interest to you. You'll see what I mean."

13

“Will you be fine if I step back?” the nurse asked Enez as she seated her in front of Officer Heynes’s office desk.

“Yeah, I think so,” Enez replied with a subtle nod. “How far back, though?”

“I’ll still be on this side of the door. In case of a medical emergency.”

“Works for me.” Enez placed a hand on the nurse’s shoulder, unsure if the motion was entirely appropriate but feeling the need to express her gratitude in some way beyond saying “Thanks”. Which, granted, she did also do.

“Happy to help,” the nurse replied and proceeded to take her place at the back corner of the office. The door slid open in the same moment, greeting Enez with the sight of Officer Heynes entering.

What she didn’t expect was Officer Walters entering a mere two seconds later. *What’s the bitch doing here? I thought this’d be a one-on-one deal.* Had there been a smile on Enez’s face, it would have faded the instant she laid eyes on the traitor.

But she didn’t voice her disapproval just yet. She made a decision in the moment to torture them in her own way for a minute. To drive a point home. The officers took a seat each on

the opposite side of the desk, and Officer Heynes crossed his hands and leaned forward.

“Would you mind showing Officer Walters here what you showed me earlier?” he inquired. That Enez didn’t mind. She produced a subtle nod and turned her head to show whatever was of so much importance that another officer needed to see it. She wasn’t entirely sure herself what exactly was on her neck. There was a mirror in the infirmary room she could have used, but she hadn’t felt like looking at herself since the incident at DanariTek that’d brought her here.

Officer Walters’s eyes widened. “Oh fuck,” she whispered. “That’s—”

“Yep,” Officer Heynes muttered, interrupting her. “Our murderer is breaking the pattern.”

Murderer? Breaking the pattern? Was Enez supposed to die? And if so, why had whoever had placed the mark on her neck decided not to kill her? A wave of anxiety washed over her as she pondered these questions. Questions she’d likely never get an answer to.

“And you feel confident about that conclusion based on a sample size of three?” Officer Walters inquired with an intent stare in Officer Heynes’s direction.

“You got a better idea?” Heynes asked in response.

“Well, no,” Walters muttered with a shrug. “But are you sure Miss Harady having the mark means that she was meant to be a target?”

Heynes nodded. “Positive.”

“Well, I trust your judgment more than my own,” Walters surrendered.

Turning his attention back to Enez, Heynes then asked: “Now, Miss Harady... How did you receive that mark?”

Enez didn’t respond. She simply stared at Heynes, doing her best not to smirk. How long would it take him to catch on to what she was trying to say with her silence? She was eager to find out.

She counted a good twenty seconds before Heynes spoke again. “Miss Harady, please cooperate,” he muttered impatiently.

Enez’s way of responding to his plea was to nod in Walters’s direction, so as to silently say “I’ll talk when she leaves”. Heynes let out a sigh of frustration and gestured for Walters to leave the room. She didn’t seem to object, as if she knew this would be the outcome. Enez’s gaze followed Walters with unparalleled intent and glee. Once she was on the other side of the door, Enez returned her gaze to Heynes.

“Now can you answer the question?” he asked.

“Sure,” Enez chirped and proceeded to recount the events. “Sadly, I don’t have much in the way of a testimony. I was blacked out when it happened.”

“Blacked out?” Heynes repeated curiously. “Like in a coma?”

“That’s one way to put it. Though I’m pretty sure the bastard hacked my neural link. I remember something sharp going into my head just before blacking out, like a needle. Woke

up with a bitch of a headache and spent the next thirty minutes vomiting my guts out.”

Heynes nodded. He looked like he was contemplating the logistics of a neural link hack. Even Enez knew that wasn’t something that happened on the daily. Everything should technically be hackable, but neural links were secure enough that hacking one required some very sophisticated wizardry. And equally sophisticated equipment, the kind one would need to be at least a millionaire to afford.

“Do you at least remember when it happened?”

“Sometime last night.”

“Miss Harady’s neural logs show anything out of the ordinary?” Heynes asked the nurse in the back.

“I haven’t looked yet. Wasn’t aware her neural link *had* been hacked,” the nurse hollered back.

“You didn’t tell your nurse you were hacked?” Heynes growled at Enez.

She shrugged. “Didn’t seem important.”

“I do suggest you let her peruse your neural logs. It could give us a lead. At this point, every little bit helps.”

“Noted,” Enez replied with a nod.

“On that same note, where was your nurse at the time?”

“Somewhere else. Left the room just before the hacker attacked.” As if they had been waiting for the perfect moment to strike. Had been lurking in the shadows for some time. Enez was every bit as uncomfortable with the idea as Heynes looked to be.

“You said you were told I’d know what the mark means,” Heynes proceeded to inquire.

Enez nodded and explained: “Something I think the hacker said to me while they were working their magic. Like a lucid dream.”

“Don’t suppose you managed to get a good look at the assailant?”

“No. They came at me at an angle where they managed to stay hidden. No identifiable marks on the parts of their body I did see. Namely, the hands.”

“Either way, I have a pretty good idea as to who it was. And you having her mark adds another layer to the case.”

“Her?!” Enez repeated in shock. “Are you saying I was attacked by—”

She was interrupted by what felt like an electrical surge in her head. Her vision blurred. An attack of nausea struck her. She keeled over in her seat, feeling like she was going to faint but managing to keep herself conscious. “Fuck,” she grunted, one of her hands clasping the side of her head.

“What’s wrong?” Heynes asked, standing up.

“Just a neural glitch. It’ll pass shortly.”

The nurse rushed over. “Need me to do anything?” she asked Enez in a voice that conveyed more panic than her choice of occupation would have allowed her.

“Nah. Just gotta give it a few seconds.”

“Are you sure?”

Enez wanted to respond, but suddenly, she felt like her

lips wouldn't move no matter how much she willed them to. Like they were numb. The sensation slowly crept its way to the rest of her body, and in the seconds she convinced the effects of the glitch would subside, her world instead faded to black once more.

14

Good ol' infirmary room 265. Coming back here felt like some sort of punishment to Jenn at this point. But in a way, she felt it her duty to still keep an eye on Enez. She may have broken her trust, but that didn't mean Jenn had suddenly become less concerned over Enez. And the neural glitch she'd been hit with back in Josh's office was of concern to Jenn as much as everyone else in the room. She hoped Enez wouldn't hold the grudge for too long.

She cast her eyes over Enez's sleeping form, Josh on the other side of the bed, while the nurse danced her fingers across the keyboard of a holocomp, perusing Enez's neural logs. It didn't take long for the nurse to produce a raspy hum, one that carried intrigue and frustration in equal amounts, a sign that she had come across something. What that something was, Jenn was also curious to find out.

"What did you find?" Jenn asked the nurse while turning her head.

The nurse pointed at two peculiar error messages being displayed on the screen. Jenn leaned in closer, curiosity growing, almost laying her chin on the nurse's shoulder. A sense of disbelief came to her at first, but the more she looked at the

error messages, the more that disbelief turned into intrigue. Instead of clear error messages saying exactly what had gone wrong, the entries the nurse had dug up were long strings of zeroes. And the most curious thing of all was the timestamps – the first error was logged at the time the hacker attacked Enez, the other when the neural glitch happened.

And now the logs were effectively unreadable. As if they had been corrupted. Which did happen sometimes – the kinks of neural links were well-known, and the one company remaining in the cybernetics business was still working on ironing them out – but the likelihood of *these two exact entries* getting corrupted out of thousands was so low that there was no chance it was random. Like it usually was.

Josh joined Jenn and the nurse in pondering the corrupted neural logs a few seconds later. “Interesting discovery you made there,” he muttered a comment to the nurse.

“Believe me, I’m at least as intrigued as you are,” she responded.

“What are the chances the hack caused the neural glitch?” Jenn inquired.

“I’d say 99%,” the nurse said. “Granted, most neural glitches happen randomly, but I’m confident this one didn’t. The way I see it, the timestamps on the corrupted log entries are kind of a dead giveaway.”

“What about the corruption?” came a question from Josh. “Doesn’t seem random, does it?”

“That’s exactly what I’m saying.”

“One other thing,” Jenn said, taking note of something no one else had so far. “Look at the timestamps.”

Josh and the nurse obliged. Their eyes widened when they realized what Jenn had. The errors were logged *exactly* twelve hours apart, down to the millisecond. And to Jenn, that if anything was indisputable evidence that the hack *had* caused the neural glitch. And the corruption.

“I think you’re on the right track,” Josh said, addressing both the nurse and Jenn. “No chance the neural glitch wasn’t caused by the hack.”

Jenn turned her gaze to Josh. “Think it’s safe to let these stick around?”

“Something tells me it isn’t. Best to delete ‘em just in case.”

“To prevent another neural glitch from happening?”

“Yeah.” Then Josh asked the nurse: “Can you do that?”

“Long as I can dig out the ID’s, yeah. Should be doable.”

“Great. Keep us posted. Last thing I want is for Miss Harady to die of an especially violent glitch.”

The nurse nodded. “Likewise. I’ll get to it right away.”

Jenn and Josh produced grateful nods in unison and left the room, headed back to the police department floor.

“I’m thinking another visit to DanariTek is in order,” Josh sur-

mised as he and Jenn were walking down the hallway on the infirmary floor towards the main elevator.

“To get an expert’s opinion on what happened to Miss Harady?” Jenn guessed.

“Exactly. If anyone’s bound to have knowledge about the chances of something like this happening, it’s the people working the production line.”

Jenn nodded in agreement. “Want me to tag along?”

“Sure. You found the crucial detail. Can’t think of anyone else I’d rather go with. I gotta do something real quick before we leave, though.”

The two stepped into the elevator, rode it up to the police department floor and went their separate ways for the time being. Jenn told Josh she needed to pee. Josh went looking for Devin in the meantime.

“Hey, Koji,” he hollered to his fellow veteran officer, who happened to be walking down the hallway in the opposite direction at the same time. “Seen Devin?”

“Cafeteria,” Koji spoke a hurried response, throwing an arm up and pointing a finger behind him. Not that Josh needed directions to the cafeteria. He produced a thankful nod, unsure if Koji caught the motion in his peripheral vision, and continued on his way.

To his surprise and delight, Devin was the first thing he saw when he turned the corner to the cafeteria entrance. He was evidently just preparing to leave, having finished his lunch and standing up from his seat. Josh called his name and waved him

over, and Devin wasted no time obliging.

“What’s up?” Devin inquired once he was stood right in front of Josh. The look he gave him conveyed something that Josh didn’t quite take as forgiveness, even if they both knew Josh had simply followed protocol with the way he had decided to punish Devin.

“You’re going to see some government people,” Josh informed him. “Got a corrupted record in the population database. Your job is to go to the government’s server hall and talk to the guys running maintenance. Interrogate them about how it might have happened.”

“Can’t send anyone else?”

“No. Already got enough work for the four of us. Need to outsource.”

Devin nodded. “Who’s my partner for the job?”

“Haven’t assigned one. Take whoever you want with you.” Josh paused, remembering the one important thing he’d neglected to say so far. “And report your findings to me. Do this gig well and you’re back on the team.”

A subtle, grateful smile stretched across Devin’s face. “Roger,” he muttered with a playful salute. “When do you want me to go?”

“Soon as you can. You got any loose ends, take your time tying them up first.”

“Well, I don’t have much in the way of loose ends to tie up, so...” Devin turned his gaze back towards the cafeteria, as if scanning it for any colleagues that were about to leave and

didn't look busy. It didn't take long for one to walk by. "Hey, Kaz," Devin said to Kazuto Yamada in Jangl as he was about to exit the cafeteria, stopping him in his tracks. "You busy?"

"No," Kazuto replied. "Why?"

"Got a gig at the government server hall. You down to join me?"

"Sure. What sort of gig?"

"Going to interrogate the server maintainers. Apparently there's a corrupted record in the population database."

"A corrupted record?! How's that possible?"

"That's what we're supposed to find out. Good to go right away?"

"Yeah."

"Awesome. Let's move." And Devin and Kazuto set foot towards the garage.

In that same moment, Jenn rejoined Josh. "So, when are we leaving?" she asked.

"Give me one more minute," Josh replied. "Need a coffee for the road."

"I'm actually gonna grab one too, I think." With that, the two of them walked up to the coffee dispenser sitting in a nearby corner and took turns dispensing doses of the black poison into cardboard cups and covering their tops with plastic lids. The DanariTek factory was nearly an hour's drive away, so Josh felt the coffee necessary to keep him sharp for the trip. Then they too headed for the garage.

15

Devin and Kazuto arrived at the server hall just as a dark gray cloud drifted into view directly above them, looking like it threatened to start dropping rain. But maybe it would stay a threat. Devin hoped it would.

“Huh,” he muttered as he looked at the cloud. “Forecast didn’t say it’d rain today.”

“Chances are it won’t,” Kazuto commented while opening the door on the passenger’s side. “And even if it does, it’s a good thing our gear is waterproof.”

“True.” Devin opened the other door and stepped out of the car. “Alright, let’s go.”

No raindrops fell in the time it took them to walk from the car to the server hall entrance. It was covered by a little metallic slant of a roof, so they could wait out any rain under it and stay dry should it come to that. Even with the waterproof police attire, Devin hated standing in the rain while wearing it.

The entrance was locked by a keycard scanner, a system designed to keep anyone who wasn’t a government employee or a member of law enforcement out of the building. Devin tapped on his wrist comm to produce his holographic badge and show it to the scanner, to which it beeped happily and allowed the

door to slide open. Devin and Kazuto entered the hall, greeted by the sight of a young Japanese man with a buzz cut and a single vertical line on his chin constituting a beard. “Good day, gentlemen,” he welcomed the officers in Jangl. “How may I be of assistance?”

Devin proceeded to introduce himself and Kazuto while the two flashed their badges. “Devin Nichols, Neo-Tokyo police. And my colleague Kazuto Yamada.” Then he stated their business. “Got sent here on account of a corrupted database record. Figured you might be able to explain how that’s possible.”

The man’s eyes widened. Evidently he’d thought such a thing should be impossible if anything. He raised a finger to his chin, shaking his head subtly as he spoke. “I’m afraid I’m not. Our servers should be corruption-proof. If a record did somehow become corrupted, it should try to repair itself.”

“Well, one of the files that made it to us didn’t.”

“But how?” The sense of shock emanating from the man was unlike anything Devin had seen prior. It was equivalent to that of a child finding out that Santa isn’t real.

“I was hoping you’d be able to tell us.”

“Like I said, this... I...” The man stuttered for a good moment while he struggled with the realization that the servers weren’t as tamperproof as they were supposed to be. On some level, Devin felt bad for him. Eventually, he pleaded: “Show me the record. I have to check this.”

“See for yourself,” Devin said while tapping on his wrist comm and producing the file of Nichiho Amano. The man

waved him closer and guided him to connect his wrist comm to a terminal on the end of one of the server racks, which Devin had no trouble agreeing to. The man eyed the file Devin had dug out for a moment, growing no less surprised by the fact that a population database record had made it to the police in this state, then ran a pattern match for it against the file in the servers.

The terminal spat out a 100% match.

The man froze completely for a second. Even his breathing stopped. He was evidently wrestling with the revelation that there was indeed a corrupted file in the database, not to mention that it hadn't repaired itself like he'd said it should.

One of his coworkers shouted something in Japanese from the side. From the intonation, Devin figured it to translate to "What's wrong?" or something along the same lines.

The man hollered back a panicked response, followed by something that conveyed the coworker had been sent into equal shock. The conversation continued for a few more lines from both men, then the other joined the three of them at the terminal. Devin decided not to spend his brain power trying to decipher every word they hollered between one another. He'd ask Kazuto later if he felt curious enough.

The one thing he *could* reliably translate without consulting Kazuto was what the second man whispered after staring at the terminal screen for a moment. It meant "holy shit".

That comment was followed by another from the first man. In Japanese.

Devin was growing more aggravated by the minute for not understanding what the two were saying. “Same in Jangl, please?” he pleaded at that point.

“Yes, sorry,” the first man replied, switching language. “I was saying this implies deliberate tampering. There’s no way a file would get corrupted like this randomly.”

“Any idea who could have tampered with it?” Kazuto inquired.

“It’d have to be one of the employees here. They’re the only ones with read-write access.”

Devin turned his attention to Kazuto following that response. “Let’s gather everyone around. Interrogate them about this and see if anyone confesses.”

“On it,” Kazuto replied and began to turn around, barely missing getting hit in the head by a bullet from above.

The two officers quickly unholstered their guns and turned their gazes to where they’d heard the gunshot coming from, catching the faint shape of a figure up on a catwalk beginning to run away. “Freeze!” they shouted in unison in different languages, but the shooter seemed to have no intention of obeying.

Devin quickly signed a set of instructions to Kazuto, and the two of them dashed in opposite directions in the hopes of surrounding the assailant and preventing their escape. Kazuto ran to the far end of the hall while Devin took the nearest ladder up to the catwalk. He climbed it and just caught the figure turning a corner to the right as his head peeked out at the top. With a

swift motion, he pulled himself all the way up and ran after the figure, turning the same corner and coming into a room that looked like a combination of kitchen and office, with various electronic devices strewn about the tables therein and the stench of stale coffee filling it with its bitterness.

Importantly, it seemed like a dead end. The only way out next to the doorway that led to this room was a single window with a very complex-looking opening mechanism. The shooter had to be here somewhere. Maybe crouched behind a couch.

Devin kept the barrel of his gun pointed ahead. Kazuto joined him only a few seconds later. “He’s somewhere in here?” he asked as he stepped through the doorway.

“Has to be. Only other way out is the window.”

Another gunshot echoed from the left. A warning shot. Devin and Kazuto turned the barrels of their guns to the direction before their eyes. The shooter stood behind what looked like a kitchen counter, their gun pointed in the general direction of the officers. A young Japanese-looking man, barely in his 20s by Devin’s reckoning, with his head shaven bald and eyes that twinkled with fear more than hostility. Clothing that signified he was an employee at the server hall. No visible cybernetics.

Kazuto fired a shot at the young man’s shoulder, causing him to drop the weapon. “Mind telling us what gave you the idea to come to work carrying a weapon?” he growled interrogatively in Jangl.

“I’m guessing you’re the file tamperer?” Devin added his own inquiry.

“I’m not telling you guys shit,” the man muttered, doing his best to sound defiant despite knowing he’d already lost.

“Don’t need to,” Devin replied, keeping his gun pointed at him. “We could just arrest you. Got enough grounds to suspect you’re our culprit.”

The man laughed. “You just don’t get it, do you?”

“What don’t we get?”

He crouched down, picked up the gun with his other hand, pressed it against his head...

“Shit,” Devin whispered.

Then the man pulled the trigger.

Devin and Kazuto simply stood there, watching the man’s body fall to the floor, blood and pieces of his brain crawling down the wall. “Well,” Kazuto commented, “that’s one way to avoid going to jail.”

The two men from earlier appeared at the doorway, no doubt alerted to the room by the sound of gunfire. “What happened here?” one of them inquired.

“We caught the shooter,” Devin explained. “One of your coworkers. Took his own life.”

“Who?”

Devin gestured for the gentlemen to hold their position as he moved behind the counter, crouching down and standing back up a few seconds later with his ID projected on his wrist comm. “Daisuke Ito,” he recited. “Was apparently celebrating his twentieth today.” Then he sighed repentantly and looked back to the fresh corpse, cursing the timing of the incident.

“Hell of a birthday gift.”

The server hall workers nodded mournfully. “Shame,” said the one that hadn’t spoken yet. “He was a bright kid.”

“Our morgue crew will be here to pick up the body within the hour,” Kazuto informed the men. They nodded and bowed, then Devin and Kazuto returned to their car.

Devin dialed Josh as soon as they made it back.

“How’d it go?” Josh inquired when he picked up, as to-the-point as ever.

“Could’ve gone better,” Devin replied with a mournful tone. “We ran into a shooter. Young native guy, barely in his 20s. Was probably behind the corrupted record.”

“So the file was deliberately tampered with?”

“Yeah. Guys we talked to confirmed as much. Only hands capable of modifying the files are those of the server hall employees.”

“What about the shooter? Got anything out of him?”

“No. He took his own life before we had the chance.”

Josh’s hologram nodded, a tangible heaviness to the motion that carried as much regret as Devin did. *Yeah. I hate it too, man.*

“Great work,” Josh said after a moment of silence. “Send me the shooter’s ID. Even if he’s unavailable for testimony, we can still get something to work with.”

“On it,” Devin replied while tapping on his wrist comm, already complying to Josh’s request. Then he asked: “How are things on your end?” A question Josh technically didn’t have to

answer, but Devin was curious what he was doing.

“Jenn and I are on our way to DanariTek to ask about neural glitches. Still on our way. We’ll see you back at the station.”

“Yeah. See ya.” Then Devin hit the End Call button.

16

The rain clouds reached Josh and Jenn at the DanariTek facility the second they arrived, beginning to pour down a torrent of water just as Josh parked the car and shut off its engine. He grunted. At least it was a short walk from the car to the main entrance, but he still cursed the fact that he hadn't prepared for this sort of weather today. "Rain wasn't in the forecast for today," he commented.

"It'll probably pass quick," Jenn predicted. "Either way, I'm not sitting here waiting." She opened the door.

"Yeah. Business is business." Josh followed suit, and the two of them stepped out. The rain was heavy enough to soak Josh's trenchcoat in the few seconds it took them to walk up to the main entrance. A series of radiators, alerted to their presence by some scanners Josh couldn't immediately see, turned on and dried off their clothing as they entered.

"Afternoon," said a young-looking Asian woman behind the reception desk in Jangl. Josh didn't think she was quite native – the nuances of her particular facial features more gave him the impression of her being of Chinese descent. Her accent didn't carry the characteristic rhythm of Jangl-speaking Japanese people either. "How can I help you?"

“Josh Heynes, Neo-Tokyo police,” Josh introduced himself, then extended an arm to his side where Jenn was standing and introduced her: “Jenn Walters.” He moved on to state their business: “Who at your company knows the most about neural glitches? We’d like to talk to them.”

The receptionist nodded and performed a series of motions on something hidden from the view of the officers. Likely a telecomm device of some sort. Josh listened intently to the side of the conversation he could hear as the woman spoke, translating the Jangl in his head. “Hi, it’s Ling from reception. I have some police officers here wanting to talk to someone who knows about neural glitches. Know anyone? Is he free at the moment? Okay, great. I’ll tell them to meet him in his office. Thanks. Bye.”

“Who are we meeting?” Jenn inquired as the receptionist ended the call.

“Deren Falk,” she responded. “He’s one of the cyber-surgeons in the neural link development division. One of our most well-studied, knows a lot about the risks involved. He’s free for the next fifteen minutes or so. You’ll find him in his office. Second floor, section C.”

“Thank you,” said Josh and set one foot in front of the other, leading the way towards Deren Falk’s office.

Deren Falk... The name haunted Josh suddenly. And he knew why. Related to Steve Falk, though Josh didn’t know which one was the father and which one the son. What he did know was that Steve had also been a cybersurgeon employed by

DanariTek, until Josh shot him in the head only a few days ago. No matter how much he thought about it, Josh couldn't think of a single justification for eliminating a witness beyond an impulse he knew he should be able to control. He hoped Deren would cooperate despite one of the officers coming to meet him being the one who shot someone close to him. Or, better yet, that he wouldn't recognize Josh.

"Thinking about Steve?" Jenn asked him as they ascended a staircase to the second floor.

"Yeah," Josh mumbled regretfully.

Jenn gave him a pat on the shoulder. "Regret is the thing that counts. Let's just hope Deren cooperates."

They came up to his office door a couple of minutes later. Jenn rang the doorbell, and the door slid open. Deren wasn't exactly cheerful in his demeanor, but he welcomed the officers into his office with the kind of careful affability carried by someone who had dealt with law enforcement before and knew the drill. "Officers," he muttered and extended an arm. Josh and Jenn took turns shaking it.

Josh looked for the flash of recognition in Deren's eyes but didn't catch it.

"So," Deren began as the three of them took their seats at his office desk, "I was told you came here to inquire about neural glitches."

"That is correct," Josh replied. "Specifically, we'd like to know what the chances of very specific corruption in the neural logs are."

Deren's brow furrowed. "How specific?" came a clarifying question from him.

"Two neural log entries timed exactly twelve hours apart getting corrupted specific," said Jenn.

Deren brought a finger up to his chin. His gaze drifted off to the side. "I wanna say it's not entirely unlikely, but the chances of corruption *that* specific border on the infinitesimal. Less than .001%."

"What if the corruption was caused by a neural link hack?" Josh asked.

"Well, that would increase the likelihood considerably. But corrupting one specific neural log entry is involved enough, let alone several."

Jenn's turn. "How involved? What does the process look like?"

"I can't describe it in detail because I frankly don't know, but it involves going through multiple levels of security. There's a reason we design our neural links to encrypt the logs as hard as we do. Even when an entry gets corrupted, it's usually after at least a year of digital decay. My best guess as to how a specific entry can get corrupted is a virus that screws with the encryption of the log while it's being written."

"How hard would it be to develop such a virus?"

"Very. Our encryption algorithm is the best-kept secret in the business. Our own AI has been working on cracking it for thirty years and it's still not even close. The only way someone would know how to get through it is if they were one of the

develop—”

Deren froze, realization dawning on him like a sunrise in the Caribbean. Josh caught on immediately.

“Fuck,” Deren grunted. “The algorithm’s been leaked.” He dug out his phone and started tapping on it, shaking with panic. “I gotta call my boss. Let him know about this.”

“Put him on speaker if you can,” Josh requested.

“Sure.”

Deren’s phone beeped once, twice, three times, then an agitated, mosquito-like voice sounded from the other end. “Yeah?”

“Hey, boss,” Deren said, trying and failing to contain himself, then continued: “I just realized something big while talking to the cops here. I think our encryption algorithm has been leaked.”

“...Fuck. You sure?”

“Positive. How else do you figure someone would be able to corrupt specific neural log entries?”

“Why are you asking me? You’re the expert in that field.”

“I’m just saying neural log corruption is usually random. And the layers we put into our encryption are supposed to be impenetrable. But the cops are saying they’ve come across specific entries being corrupted. And the way I see it, that can only mean one thing.”

Silence permeated the space for a moment as Deren’s boss pondered the implications. “Okay, yeah. I see what you

mean. This calls for an internal investigation. The cops still there with you?”

Josh piped in: “If you’re thinking about hiring us specifically for the job, I’m afraid we’re preoccupied. What we *can* do is relay your request to another team and have them work with you.”

“Whatever works,” the DanariTek boss commented, sounding very frustrated. “I just want it underway as soon as possible.”

“As do we. Another officer will get in touch with you soon.”

“Yeah. Thanks.” And the man hung up.

Josh and Jenn got up and thanked Deren for his time, leaving the building and getting back into their car. The rain had passed while they were inside.

“This starting to feel like an organized criminal operation to you too?” Jenn aired a thought as they climbed in the car.

Josh nodded in agreement. “This is no longer a simple murder case. Someone wanted to sabotage Harashima from within. And we have a solid candidate back in the infirmary.”

For a moment, Jenn looked at him like she wanted to protest, but she eventually nodded, as if conceding that he had a point.

17

Jenn parked her car – the one she used for getting to and from work – in the parking lot on the backside of the Office of Legal and Military Operations, the one meant for employees to park their own vehicles, while the morning sun crept up in the horizon. It was a beautiful vintage car, to the extent that a car from the early 21st century could be considered vintage, handed down to her in accordance to her father's will when he died the year before. A lot of repairs had to be made to the car to make it last this long, including a full replacement of its internals to make it run on something that was actually obtainable in this day and age. And, more importantly, renewable. Earth's oil reserves had run dry sometime during the Fourth World War – a time Jenn was happy to have missed on account of her not having been born yet – and that had necessitated some fundamental changes in several systems that kept the world running. Yet car engines had been among the least significant.

She thought about Harashima as she walked through the building's back entrance and took an elevator up to the police department floor. The man and his companies had played a significant role in how technology had evolved over the past forty years or so. Especially in the field of cybernetics. Prior to Hara-

shima publishing his dissertation on the effects of cybernetic implants on the human brain, the few companies producing cybernetics at the time had been battling with some issues that they hadn't quite been able to figure out. Issues that had caused the implants to cause mental health issues in their bearers or, worse yet, spontaneously kill them. Harashima's research being published was a lightbulb moment in the industry.

And then the man founded his first company. With his reputation as a genius and every cybernetics student wanting to work for him, the company got ahead of the competition very quickly. Within only two years, his company had generated enough revenue for Harashima to buy out one of the competing companies and merge it into his. The same fate befell the rest in the span of a year. And now, only one company in the field of cybernetics remained in the entire world – DanariTek.

But Harashima wasn't satisfied with only one monopoly. He wanted more. He tackled several other fields with his corporate endeavors during his lifetime – telecommunications, surveillance technology, even banking and law – but his attempts at monopolizing every other industry were shut down swiftly when the people in charge caught on to his tactics. There *were* companies founded by him that still existed in fields beyond cybernetics, but they had largely remained relatively small players in the grand scheme of things.

Jenn headed for the cafeteria and found her colleagues in the Harashima team gathered at their usual spot. Devin had rejoined them as well. "Welcome back, Devin," she chirped to

him as she walked past them.

He might have thanked her – she didn't slow down enough to catch it if he did. Right now, shaking the morning caffeine monkey off her back was a priority.

She joined the rest of them at the table once she had a cup of the sweet toxin in her hand. "No sign of Josh yet?" she inquired as she sat down.

"Nah," said Goro. "Late enough that it's only a matter of time, though."

"Yeah. Josh is nothing if not consistent."

"Curious to see how the case develops today," Devin commented. "Especially after yesterday."

His tone told Jenn he was thinking about the man that'd attacked them at the server hall. And then shot himself. She nodded subtly, then said to Devin: "Wasn't your fault the guy shot himself. Don't beat yourself up."

"I know," Devin replied with a sigh. "Just a shame we couldn't interrogate him. Best thing we have on him is a strong suspicion."

"Even a suspicion is better than nothing," Shinji piped in. "But yeah, shame about the kid."

Jenn let out a half-chuckle.

"I know, a 20-year-old isn't legally a kid," Shinji said in response to what he figured the gesture meant. And his interpretation was correct.

"It's all good," Jenn shot back. "But it is too bad we lost a witness. Even if we *can* safely assume he was behind the cor-

rupted file.” She sipped her coffee.

Then Josh appeared. “Alright, team,” he addressed the table while their eyes turned in his direction. “Let’s get this show on the road.”

The morning’s meeting largely amounted to sharing yesterday’s developments with the entire team. Josh felt like it was starting to chug along again, even if it was spreading beyond the scope of what a team of five could realistically handle. He settled into staring at the whiteboard after the rest of the team left the conference room, letting his eyes wander over every puzzle piece that was presently on it.

Harashima. Busujima. His two daughters. Enez Harady. Steve Falk. The murderer. The kid at the server hall. The evidence about the last piece wasn’t conclusive – with him being dead, the chances were low it would ever be – but Josh couldn’t help but agree that Daisuke Ito was likely behind the corruption in Nichiho Amano’s file.

But why her file specifically? And why had nobody else’s population record been tampered with? Had Mister Ito worked alone or had someone else orchestrated it? Had he been no more than a pawn in a bigger game?

Josh was confident the answer to the last question was an uncontestable “yes”. The coincidences were too numerous to be coincidences. Miss Harady’s history with Harashima, the

corrupted population database record, Mister Ito's intervention at the server hall, the golden lip marks that had been found on both Busujima and Harashima's bodies...

After venturing across the whole whiteboard, his eyes settled on the image of Enez Harady. He was sure she was involved on a deeper level than what their prior knowledge about her had led them to believe. But what Josh couldn't quite convince himself of was the idea that she had orchestrated the leak of DanariTek's encryption algorithm. She didn't even work in the neural link development division. Nevertheless, they would need to do a thorough investigation of her background. To Josh's surprise, Jenn had volunteered to handle it.

The aforementioned slumped back into the otherwise empty conference room, her motions heavy and her gaze glued to the floor.

Josh turned around and asked Jenn: "Wasn't willing to talk, was she?"

Jenn gave her answer in the form of a shaking of her head and a sigh. "Told me to fuck off as soon as she saw me."

Josh produced a sigh of his own.

Then Jenn finally lifted her gaze. She looked at him with the kind of intensity she only used when she questioned his judgment. "You don't seriously think Enez is behind the algorithm leak?"

"Well, I do and I don't. Wish I could give a more definitive answer than that. My only reasoning for the suspicion is that she works at DanariTek."

“Well, yeah, but not the neural link development division of it. What are the chances she’d even get her hands on it? I’m sure the company has a set of internal non-disclosure regulations.”

“Even if they do, she could’ve gotten around ‘em.”

“How? DanariTek doesn’t let its employees just sneak around between divisions. Not without proper clearance.”

“Maybe she got improper clearance.”

Jenn looked off to the side. Raised a finger to her chin. Contemplated. Then eventually muttered: “Right. The one thing I didn’t consider.” She returned her gaze to Josh and continued: “Either way, I still don’t think she was behind the leak.”

“Can you substantiate your claim or is that just a gut feeling?”

Jenn’s expression shifted slightly. She looked offended. “It’s way more than a gut feeling. No offense, Josh, but you underestimate my ability to read people. And I can pretty confidently say she’s not the type.”

“What type?”

“To leak sensitive information at the risk of getting fired. She’s smarter than that.”

Josh shrugged. “If you say so.”

“What? Ran out of arguments?” Jenn inquired with the kind of friendly sarcasm she only had with Josh. He didn’t respond.

The two stayed quiet for a moment. When she figured the silence had lasted long enough, Jenn asked: “So, should we

get started? Dive into the population database and do some perusing?”

“You can go ahead without me,” Josh said. “I wanna look into something else real quick.”

“Alright, but don’t keep me waiting too long,” Jenn told Josh while marching toward the door of the conference room. A follow-up statement from the other side: “I’ll call you over if you haven’t joined me in an hour.”

18

In the early hours of the night, with the lights and billboards of Neo-Tokyo painting the city with splashes of neon against an otherwise dark gray backdrop, Maria and Yuriko sat down at the same table in Dan's Dojo they had the other day, each holding a pint of the cheapest beer the bar had on offer. Maria had felt it necessary to update her best friend on the progress of her murder investigation despite the relative lack of it, and Dan's Dojo felt like the perfect place to do so. Less so because its decrepitude mirrored her mental state this time around and more so for some kind of continuity that she couldn't quite put her finger on. She hoped there were no police officers around to eavesdrop on them this time.

"So the cop that interrogated you at the station..." Yuriko began an inquiry as they sat down. Maria had already filled her in on some of the events while they were ordering their drinks. "How did you know it was the same guy that gave you the call about your dad having been killed?"

"It was the voice," Maria explained. "Though it did take me a while to connect the dots."

"Uh-huh." Yuriko paused to sip her beer, then shifted the conversation to Maria's failed cabin excursion. "Interesting

choice to try and hail a cab to the cabin.”

“Well, there’s no public transit going that way like ever, so I didn’t have a whole lot of options. And you would’ve refused to drive me.” Then Maria gulped down a dose of her own drink.

“Yeah, but I’m still offended that you didn’t even ask.”

“Sorry in that case,” Maria replied with a humorous smirk. Yuriko responded by producing a similar smile and leaning back in her seat.

“Anyway,” Yuriko said after a few seconds of silence, “if the police hadn’t caught you, what did you hope to find?”

Maria sighed. “Not sure, honestly. Devin told me—”

“Devin?” Yuriko raised an eyebrow.

It occurred to Maria that she hadn’t told her the interrogating officer’s name. “The officer that interrogated me,” she clarified.

“Right.” Evidently Yuriko was struggling with how Maria knew his first name but didn’t interrupt further for now. “Go on.”

“So he told me that I wasn’t gonna find any clues related to Dad’s death at the cabin. That it’s been cleaned up. But even if it is, I still wanna see it with my own eyes.” She sipped her beer again.

“You’re dead-set on getting there, aren’t you?” Maria wasn’t quite sure if Yuriko’s tone conveyed worry or admiration at her persistence.

“Yeah.” *Even if it lands me in jail.*

Her nerves spiked at the thought. She took another sip in an attempt to calm herself down.

“How’re you gonna do that, though? You’re surely on a watchlist. And I can’t imagine the cops are gonna be as generous if they catch you trying to leave again.”

Maria hunched over slightly, looking off to the side in contemplation. “That’s a good question. Can’t possibly rely on a cab ride working again.” A thought occurred to her. She looked back to Yuriko.

Yuriko’s eyes widened. She raised her hands in the air and shook her head while hollering: “Nuh-uh. Girl, no. I’m not partaking in this.”

In all fairness, Maria knew that was going to be Yuriko’s answer. And she also knew pleading was useless with her. In a sign of immediate surrender, Maria shrugged and muttered: “I thought so.”

Then her phone beeped in her pocket, catching her off-guard. Yuriko was usually the only person that’d text her at this hour, but why would she when she was no more than two feet away? Maria dug her phone out and glanced at the notification on the screen for what felt like hours, her eyes widening at a steady pace.

It was a text from an anonymous sender, simply saying: “Eastside underpass, 11pm. Come alone.”

Maria tried to come to a conclusion about the implications of the request but abandoned that train of thought within the minute. She looked around frantically, trying her best to de-

termine if the sender was someone at the bar. That was the only way she figured the timing of the text could have been this perfect, if someone was eavesdropping on her and Yuriko. But no patron gave her the impression of having been the sender.

“What is it?” she heard Yuriko inquire but found herself unable to formulate a response.

She looked up the location of the eastside underpass. A twenty-minute car ride away. She looked at the time. 10.36pm. If she left now and caught a free cab in three minutes, she’d make it in time. She had to admit she was curious to find out exactly what the mysterious message meant.

“I gotta go,” she informed Yuriko and got up.

“Why? What’s going on?”

“I’ll tell you when I find out,” Maria hollered from the door and dashed out to the street.

Maria stepped out of the cab she had hailed exactly where the mysterious message had told her to appear. She scanned her immediate surroundings for another person in the underpass. No one. Instead, she saw another car, alarm bells going off in her head as soon as she laid her eyes on it. Even in the near-total absence of light, partially owing to the overcast night sky, she could tell it was a police car.

She froze. Had she walked into a trap? Was she going to actually get arrested this time? But she hadn’t even done any-

thing wrong. Not since her previous run-in with law enforcement.

A figure stepped out of the vehicle. Approached her. Its features became clearer with every step. A man. Looked young, no older than 35. His jaw was lined with slightly overgrown stubble. The closer he got to Maria, the more familiar he looked. And when he was right up in her face, she almost squealed. Probably would have if she didn't clasp a hand over her mouth.

It was Devin. No, Officer Nichols.

"No one followed you, I assume?" he asked as his way of greeting Maria.

Maria let her hand fall off her face and replied while glancing around, as if to make sure: "Not as far as I could tell." Then she turned her focus back to Devin. "What do you want?"

"To help you. Take you to the cabin."

Maria's eyebrows shot skyward. "Take me to...?" She stuttered. The rest of her shocked inquiry turned into something else halfway. "Why?"

"I already answered that question."

"Is that allowed? For the police to act as a taxi service?"

"It is." Devin paused. "With some caveats."

"Uh-huh. And what are those caveats?"

"First, I had to fake a charge to get a warrant. Second..." One of Devin's hands came forward from behind his back, a pair of handcuffs dangling from it. He almost looked sorry as he produced them. "Hope you don't mind."

"Buy me dinner first, then we'll talk."

Devin looked wholly unamused by the comment. “Look, there’s only one way we’re getting in. And it’s if this looks like a real arrest.”

Maria sighed. “Alright. You’re the boss.”

Devin nodded. “Alright, turn around.”

Without another word, Maria obeyed. As one of the handcuffs clicked around her wrist, she asked: “Are your co-workers not gonna wonder what you’re doing?”

“That shouldn’t be a problem,” Devin replied as the other cuff clamped shut around her wrist. “Technically, I’m off the clock.” Then he opened the car’s backdoor and gently pushed Maria inside, followed by him taking the driver’s seat and starting the car.

Maria didn’t say anything for the first few minutes. Instead, she settled to look at the scenery from the sideview window as skyscrapers and billboards flew past them. A question was on her mind when she turned her attention back to Devin. “Can I ask you why you’re doing this?”

“Because I believe in a different version of justice.”

“Different as opposed to your colleagues?”

“Yeah.”

Maria nodded, turning her gaze off to the side, looking at nothing in particular. She was quiet for a moment before asking something different. “Would it be weird to say you remind me of my husband?”

The way Devin’s gaze shifted slightly in the rearview mirror told her his answer leaned towards “yes”. “How so?” he

asked with what sounded like genuine curiosity.

“You look sort of similar to him. And he also believed in a different version of justice. A trait that sometimes preceded his intelligence.”

“Is that a compliment or an insult?”

“I don’t know. Maybe a bit of both.” Maria’s response was accompanied by a smirk.

Silence followed for a few seconds. Then Devin changed the course of the conversation. “I notice you talk about your husband in the past tense.”

Maria’s smirk turned into a look of pained reminiscence. She produced a subtle nod, looking off to the side again. Devin’s eyes shone with sympathy in the rearview mirror. “Mind if I ask what happened?” he inquired.

“Maybe I do,” she muttered. “You know what they say.”

“What *do* they say?”

“Trust is a volatile currency.”

“You’re trusting me enough to take you to the cabin,” Devin pointed out.

Maria couldn’t argue with that. “Point taken,” she mumbled, grasping the knuckles of one hand with the other behind her back as she dug out the memory of the incident from the archives. “He died trying to stop a robbery two years back. We’d just had a date night and were on our way home. Just so happened to walk by an active crime scene. Bunch of goons were robbing a store, one was threatening the cashier with his gun out. He walked in, started to wrestle the guy at the register

and..." A pause. A tear escaped her eye. She shuddered. "And took a bullet to the head."

Devin nodded, a visible heaviness to the motion. "Sorry for your loss," he muttered.

"Thanks."

Devin's next question surprised Maria slightly. "Have you thought about dating anyone else since he died?"

"No, because to me, he's still here. Maybe not physically, but in spirit."

"Fair enough."

The two of them said nothing more for the remainder of the drive to the cabin.

19

Something resembling a park surrounded by a wall of oak trees, arranged in a perfect circle, was slowly creeping into view. Maria had lost track of time looking out the window of the police car in the neon-drenched twilight. Had almost forgotten she *was* in a police car. If not for the fact that she was handcuffed in the backseat, this would have felt like a casual late night drive, like the road trips she'd gone on with Yuriko back when the two of them were young and reckless. Well, younger and more reckless.

"We're close," Devin informed from the driver's seat. Maria instinctively straightened herself and turned her head forward. Then Devin gave her a set of instructions: "You're gonna be staying here overnight. Hope that's enough time for you to do your thing. But be subtle about it. The guards are qualified to shoot you if they think you're doing anything suspicious."

Maria wanted to reply with a sarcastic comment about subtlety being her second name but decided to simply nod instead. "How many guards are there?" she inquired, not expecting an answer.

"About twenty. One half on patrol inside, the other on the outer perimeter."

“Yet with so many guards, how does a murderer just walk in?” Maria’s tone was every bit as inquisitive as she could muster – not that she expected Devin to be able to give a definitive answer, but even some speculation was better than nothing.

To her dismay, all Devin gave her in response was a shrug. “I’d like to say the cabin is impenetrable, but the way your father was killed proves otherwise. But then again, there’s a way around everything.”

Maria stayed silent, nodding in agreement over the second half of Devin’s statement.

Devin drove up to a gate. A reinforced wall eight feet tall stretched around the perimeter, with a series of what looked like electric rods at the very top. And the trees were very close now. Their smell crept into the car as Devin opened the window to talk to the guard working gate control – these trees were real. Maria wondered how much planting them all around the cabin had cost.

“Evening,” the guard greeted Devin.

“Howdy,” Devin responded with an oddly cheerful cadence. Maria figured it to convey friendliness more than anything else.

“Bringing in a prisoner?” the guard asked, taking account of Maria’s presence. She kept her gaze glued to the back of Devin’s seat.

“Yep.”

“Case number?”

“DN-140072.”

The guard tapped on a holographic projection that suddenly appeared for a moment, then mumbled something to himself that Maria didn't quite catch. Probably just reading aloud. A few more seconds later, he looked to Devin again and said to him: "Alright, you're cleared for entry. Go ahead."

"Thank you." Devin rolled the window back up, the gate opened, and he drove what little distance remained, parking the car about twenty feet from the cabin terrace.

"So what kinds of criminals do you usually bring here?" Maria inquired as Devin opened her door and guided her to step out.

"Accidental criminals. Ones involved in indirectly causing deaths et cetera. Like your father was."

A memory of Yoshiro's arrest came to Maria. He'd called her just before being driven to the cabin the day he was arrested. For accidentally killing a child. The kid was trying to pickpocket him, he took notice and tried to push him away... with a little too much success. Poor kid stumbled right into the middle of the street and became a bloody decal against the front of a hoverbus that happened to drive by. The memory of the phone call played vividly in Maria's head, as if she was having it again with her father from beyond the grave. Yoshiro had ranted to Maria about how the law didn't understand the concept of an accident, but she disagreed. If it didn't, his fate would have been a lot worse from a judicial standpoint.

She wondered what kind of charge Devin had faked to get her here but decided not to ask about it.

“Couple important things,” Devin informed Maria while walking her to the terrace, then pointed to a device on a round, wooden table that looked like some sort of recorder. “You can use the recorder to document any ponderings about your quote-unquote crime while you’re here. We call it the repentance tape. If you do decide to use it, state your full name and number of day at the cabin before anything else. This here’s the Record button, next to it is the Stop button, and the Erase button deletes the last recording. But you can only use it once per day. Also, you can’t say anything that would incriminate another person. The recording runs its own AI and will destroy itself if you do.”

Maria nodded. “But that’s optional, right?”

“It’s optional, yeah.”

Then Devin opened the cabin door and gestured for Maria to enter, removing the handcuffs in the meantime.

She looked around the cabin interior in awe. This wasn’t a prison, this was a hotel. You had a comfortable bed, a kitchenette, a TV, a sanitation chamber... But maybe that was the point. Maybe the cabin was specifically engineered to feel like the total opposite of a prison. But then, why would anyone want to leave? She already didn’t. A whistle of amazement came out of her.

“Yeah,” Devin said in response to Maria’s wordless comment. “Doesn’t look like the kinda prison cell you’d expect, does it?”

“I mean I knew this place would be something else, but I

didn't expect *this*."

"Well, enjoy your jail time," Devin said, sounding like he was about to leave. "And again, please be careful. I'd hate to hear you got shot for being careless."

Maria turned a surprised gaze to Devin. "You won't be here to pick me up?" she asked, her tone slightly flirtatious.

"Someone will be. Can't promise it'll be me."

Maria let out a half-sarcastic snuffle. "Well, I guess you can't be my knight in shining armor all the time."

"This armor doesn't shine no matter how much you polish it," Devin replied while tugging on his bulletproof vest, finally sounding like he was catching on to Maria's sense of humor. "Anyway, good night."

Then he walked back to the car and drove off while Maria watched from the terrace.

Something about Devin made her feel something she hadn't since meeting her now-late husband. But she promptly pushed the feeling aside. She was here on a mission, and she felt like she'd betray not only herself but Devin if she neglected it.

She sat down on the edge of the bed and waited a few minutes before commencing her little clue-gathering operation. The first thing she did was prop her phone against the door – the sound of it falling over would alert her to a guard entering the cabin and tell her to stop in her tracks. Then she started scanning the surfaces of the cabin, including the floor, for anything suspicious. Anything that could work as a guidepost toward the

next lead in her investigation of Yoshiro's murder. She perused every inch of every surface, every cupboard, every shelf, every corner she could find, sitting back down on the bed and sighing in frustration an hour later.

Devin was right. The cabin had truly been scrubbed clean. There was nothing usable here.

She moved her phone from the door to the nightstand and laid down to sleep, not even bothering to close the curtains on any of the windows.

20

Josh had stared at the holographic whiteboard for what felt like an eternity, trying to figure out where one particular piece fit in the puzzle but coming to no conclusion. The view of the city beyond his office window was clad in the colors of the night, with all of his colleagues having deserted the building several hours ago. The only people entering and/or leaving the building at this point – besides himself – would be the poor souls condemned to work the night shift at the various facilities twenty floors down. And in maintenance.

He pulled up the file of Yoshiro Busujima once more, for what felt like the thousandth time, and gave it another read-through in the hopes of uncovering something. Even though previous repetitions of the action had yielded no progress. Busujima's murder was an enigma all things considered. It felt so random among everything else, but it was nonetheless connected when all of the evidence was weighed together. The same golden lip marks had been found on his neck as Harashima's – the killer's signature, had to be.

Then he panned to the holographic projection of the killer. The woman who had played escort to Harashima and slashed his throat open with his own cybernetic penis. Quite a

novel way to kill someone, he had to admit – then again, in lack of a traditional weapon, she’d had to improvise. But as much as he tried to think about it, Josh still didn’t know how the implant had been sharp enough to produce a wound that looked so much like an ordinary knife wound. If he wasn’t privy to how security in The Golden Falcon worked, he certainly could’ve mistaken it as such.

He bounced his eyes between Busujima’s file and the image of the woman for a few more minutes before sighing in frustration and finally deciding to call it a night.

He walked to the main elevator and pressed the Call button, waited for it to reach his floor, then stepped inside when the doors slid open. Once inside, he hit the button for the ground floor and assumed his usual ‘riding in the elevator’ position as the elevator began to descend.

The descent came to a sudden halt about halfway.

A slight wave of panic washed over Josh – in all his years of wandering around in the police headquarters, an elevator had never once broken down like this. Not while he was in one anyway. But he kept his cool. He just needed to call the maintenance guys and they’d get on fixing the elevator as soon as they could. He began to dial in the number on his wrist comm, but a voice from above interrupted him.

“I’d keep my finger off the dial if I were you.”

Josh looked to the direction where the voice had come from and was greeted by the sight of a silhouette in the vague shape of a woman. That was all the detail he was able to make

out from the dim lighting of the elevator shaft. “Who the fuck are you?” he shouted, half angry, half curious.

“You don’t need to know who I am,” the figure responded conspiratorially. “Yet.”

“Why shouldn’t I call for help?”

“Because you’re supposed to be plummeting to your death right about now,” came an unexpectedly honest response from the woman three feet above. “Wouldn’t want to tip off my boss that I didn’t complete the job. Besides, there’s no one down there to pick up.”

“You kill the maintenance guys?”

“Nah, just knocked ‘em unconscious.”

“And by whose orders are you to kill me?” A question Josh knew he wasn’t likely to get an answer to, but he figured he had nothing to lose by trying.

“Sure you want to know?” came a response from the woman. Something in the tone of her voice told Josh she knew something he didn’t – something crucial to the investigation. And damned if he was going to let the opportunity to get that intel slip. “Go on, spill,” he demanded.

“Can’t give you a name. Not without putting myself in danger. All I can say is there’s a black sheep in your ranks.”

Well, better than nothing, thought Josh. Though the idea of a criminal *in* the police force gave him pause. Then he remembered why he was trapped in the first place and proceeded to ask: “So if I’m supposed to be dying, why aren’t you cutting the cables?”

The figure above shifted slightly and sighed, the action seeming to carry with it a lifetime's worth of repentance, then spoke with equal earnestness: "Conscience came knocking... Plus I'm on your side, believe it or not. So I'd rather keep you alive."

"And let your boss down?" Josh inquired with a tone that conveyed an attempt at sarcasm. He immediately came to the conclusion that it wasn't his strong suit.

"Oh, I don't just plan on letting him down," the woman answered seriously, ignoring Josh's poor attempt at humor. "I plan on *taking* him down."

"Awfully bold to be confessing that right in front of an officer," Josh growled with an authoritative tone. "Could arrest you right now for planned murder."

"You *could*," the woman admitted. Then she squatted down and brought her face closer to Josh's, staring him down directly and letting him see her face a little better, although still not clearly, and continued: "But you won't."

"And why is that?"

"Because you need an inside informant. In other words, me." The woman tilted her head slightly, as if deliberately adjusting herself so Josh could make out more of her facial features. To his dismay, he couldn't. "Plus I'm already on my way to dismantling the gang from within. Once the leader is out of the picture, *then* you're free to arrest me. But until then, trust me, you need me out there."

Josh wasn't sure if he liked the terms he was presented

with. Agreeing to the deal would surely compromise the investigation. Especially considering this woman was a self-confessed criminal working in the exact circles that were under Josh's eye. But at the same time, she clearly knew something that could speed the case along. The implications of making the deal gnawed on his mind for a minute until he realized to ask: "What's in it for me? For *us*?"

"'Us' meaning your team?"

"Yeah."

"Not having to figure out who the black sheep is. You'll know when I'm done. What'll be left for you at that point is cleanup."

Now the deal was getting enticing, but Josh still hesitated. How would working *this* closely with one of the bad guys affect the investigation? At least the lady seemed honest. One last clarifying question: "And once the leader is down, you *will* agree to be arrested if I so choose?"

"Merc's honor." The woman placed a hand above her heart to signify undying honesty.

With that, Josh carefully extended an arm above and said: "Deal." The woman leaned forward a little further and her hand clasped into his, the two interlocking in a handshake. Now the light was good enough to get a clear view of her face, the elevator's interior lights providing adequate illumination.

It was Harashima's killer.

The color drained from Josh's face upon realizing he'd just made a deal with the devil. And the devil in this case was

the woman directly responsible for the murders. His arm stiffened. His body tensed up. The blood running in his veins felt like it was freezing over. “What’s wrong?” the woman asked. “Look like you’ve seen a ghost.”

Josh wanted to formulate some sort of response, but he was so petrified even his lips didn’t move.

It wasn’t until the murderer released her grip that he was able to relax. Even then, it was only enough to let his muscles move again. His arm swung downward with a heavy motion, almost slamming into the wall behind him like a wrecking ball.

He cleared his throat, partly in an attempt to calm himself down further, and asked: “Now then, mind rebooting the elevator?”

The woman shook her head and replied with a feigned sense of regret: “Not an expert on elevators, I’m afraid. All I know is how to hit the kill switch.”

“You’re not saying I’m stuck in here for the night?”

“I am saying you’re stuck in there for the night. Could keep you company, though.”

“No, thanks.” The earlier exchange was enough for Josh. He didn’t feel comfortable sharing an elevator with a murderer, especially not one whose hitlist he was on. Even if this particular murderer had defected. Something different crossed his mind right then. “Should call Momoko. Let her know I’m staying at the office overnight.”

“Your wife?”

“Yeah.”

“Don’t. Like I said, it’ll tip off my boss if you do. Don’t pick up either if she calls. We want him to think I completed the job. I’m on thin enough ice as it is.”

Josh sighed heavily. He wanted to act against the woman’s instructions, but he trusted she knew what she was doing. “Fine,” he muttered reluctantly.

“Appreciate your understanding,” the woman replied as she stood back up, evidently getting ready to leave. “See you from behind bars.” She shot a thin wire upward from a wrist-mounted device of some sort – electromagnetic grappling hook, the kind used by the maintenance workers – and zipped up with more speed than Josh figured the thing was designed to handle. Maybe her unit was modified, tailored to her specific needs, no doubt provided by whoever orchestrated the operations she was involved in.

But Josh didn’t want to think about her anymore tonight. Or anything else related to the case. Instead, he settled to take a seat on the elevator floor, waiting for sleep and, eventually, the next morning. Hopefully the elevator would be fixed by then.

21

A high-pitched, bell-like sound startled Josh awake mid-snore the next morning. He grunted and shifted slightly, straightening his aching back, disoriented and failing to remember where he had fallen asleep. That was until his eyes fluttered open.

It was the main elevator of the Office of Legal and Military Operations. Had he really fallen asleep *here*? What had happened to cause him to fall asleep somewhere that wasn't his own bed next to his wife?

The more conscious he became, the more he started to remember. The late night at the office. The elevator breaking down. The appearance of the mystery woman. The conversation. The deal he struck with her.

The deal? Did he really strike a deal with...?

Shit. I've compromised the investigation.

"Oh," echoed the surprised voice of a man beyond the elevator door. Josh looked to the direction of the voice, his vision still blurry. But it sharpened steadily as the figure continued. "Someone worked overtime."

In only a few more seconds, Josh's vision was sharp enough to determine that it was Koji. And even in his groggy state, Josh was able to decipher that there was something sinis-

ter in the way he looked at him. As if...

"Maintenance must've fallen asleep on the job," Josh grunted as he got on his feet. "Otherwise I wouldn't have spent the night here."

"Hm," Koji muttered as he entered the elevator. "You did call them, right?"

"Yeah, but they didn't pick up."

"That is most unusual. You'd think they would."

"Yeah..." Josh ran a careful gaze across Koji. "You'd think."

He didn't step out immediately when the two of them reached the police department floor. Instead, he let Koji go first. Mostly to see which way he was going. Based on that information, Josh would decide where he was going himself.

Koji took an immediate right turn, so Josh went left. It didn't take him long to run into Jenn.

"There you are," she chirped as he approached. "Spent the night in the elevator?"

"It broke down. Had no choice." A modified version of the truth, but given the nature of last night's encounter, Josh had to keep it secret.

"Maintenance didn't pick up either?"

"No. Probably fell asleep on the job."

"Huh." Jenn turned her gaze off to the side. "Weird." Back to Josh. "Anyway, glad you're okay. Was a little worried about you when Momoko called."

"She called you?"

“Yeah. Had tried to call you three times, but apparently you didn’t pick up. And you usually let her know if you’re staying at the office overnight, don’t you?”

Josh dug his phone out of his pocket and tapped on it, as if looking for evidence that would prove Jenn was telling the truth. And there it was. Three missed calls from Momoko. “Hm. Must’ve forgotten.” Then he shoved the phone back where he usually kept it.

Jenn’s expression changed. She didn’t look entirely convinced he’d simply forgotten to call Momoko. And in a way, she was right to not be convinced. If only Josh could tell her what had really happened.

Her expression switched back with the next blink. “Well, anyway,” she began her next thought, “when’s our meeting for the day commencing?”

“There won’t be a meeting today,” Josh blurted out an improvised response. The look of surprise Jenn gave him mirrored his own. But he picked up on his own train of thought: “Just continue working with what we currently have. Until something new shows up.”

“That’s... unusual of you,” Jenn commented. “But okay. I’ll relay the message to the rest of the team. If you want me to.”

“Please do,” Josh requested, surprising himself again. Had last night’s events really shaken him so much that he was willing to delegate such a simple task – one he could absolutely do himself – to another member of his team? Was he really that

afraid of having compromised the investigation? Jenn nodded and took a tentative first step towards wherever the rest of the team was, but Josh suddenly remembered something else and interrupted her. “Also...”

Jenn stopped and threw her head back, eyes locked to Josh’s. He leaned in and muttered to her, keeping his voice as low as possible: “Keep an eye on Koji. I think he’s hiding something.”

The expression Jenn responded to him with looked riddled with worry and intrigue in equal amounts. But she gave him a subtle nod before walking away. Maybe, just maybe, she understood that the stakes had gotten significantly higher. Or maybe she thought he was being paranoid. He wasn’t entirely sure himself which was the case.

Jenn reached the police department cafeteria, where Goro and Shinji were waiting, still weighing the implications of Josh’s warning about Koji. She had never written him off as suspicious in any regard. What had happened between him and Josh? What had happened to Josh last night? Had he really just forgotten to call Momoko or was he hiding something?

The guys were quick to take note of Josh’s absence. “Where’s Josh?” asked Shinji while Jenn took her seat at the cafeteria table.

“Somewhere,” Jenn replied, unsure where he was now

herself. Noting Devin's absence herself, she followed with an inquiry about his whereabouts.

"Headed to the cabin. Picking up a prisoner," Shinji said.

Jenn nodded, then stated her business: "Anyway, there's no meeting today. Josh wants us to just keep working with what we have for now."

"That's not very Josh," Goro commented. "Did he say why he decided so?"

"No. And that's exactly what's bothering me." Jenn turned her head back and looked to the hallway where he had run into Josh, airing a theory for his unusual behavior: "Something big happened last night. And he isn't telling us what."

"Should we ask him?" suggested Goro.

"Would he tell us what's going on if we did?" The crown of concern weighed heavy on Jenn's head.

"I don't think it's our place to probe either way," Shinji commented, ever the pragmatist. "Let him have a secret or two."

"In some way, it also *is* our place to probe."

"Whatever it is, I just hope it won't affect the investigation," Goro muttered.

"Yeah. So do I." Jenn's statement came out carried by a sigh. She continued with the other concern that was on her mind: "He's also suspicious of Koji. Can't imagine why."

"Koji?" Shinji exclaimed. "What kinds of suspicions would he have about a fellow police officer?"

"I'm sure he'll fill us in eventually," Goro commented.

“But yeah, I don’t know what he could possibly suspect Koji is up to.”

“What’s that about me?” echoed Koji’s voice as he just happened to be walking past.

“Nothing important,” Goro replied carefully.

“Fair enough,” Koji muttered and continued his trek to wherever he was headed. The trio watched him leave with an extra degree of intrigue, as if trying to decipher something that would justify Josh’s suspicions from the way he walked.

22

The light of the morning sun pierced through Maria's eyelids and slowly made her regain consciousness. She began to shift on the bed and let out short, plosive sighs, but her eyes remained closed. As they slowly fluttered open, the first thought that occurred to her was that the ceiling wasn't that of her apartment.

A slight sense of panic overtook her initially, but the more conscious she became and the more she looked at her surroundings, the more she realized where she was. Remembered how she'd ended up here. Why she was here.

The cabin. Where her father had been killed. Devin had taken her here the night before. She'd thoroughly scanned every inch of its interior in search for clues that might bring her closer to figuring out who her father's killer was. But her investigation turned out unsuccessful. An hour she had spent perusing the cabin – it was fairly small, about 270 square feet by Maria's reckoning – without finding anything useful. Or anything at all, for that matter. Not even a speck of dust that looked just suspicious enough to act as a potential lead.

The more she recalled the feeling of frustration she'd dozed off with, the more frustrated she was already beginning to

feel again. And she'd *just* woken up. She wasn't the type to admit defeat quite this quickly, but somehow she knew trying to look for clues out in the yard would prove equally unfruitful. So she decided to abandon the idea already.

Continuing the investigation outside also presented the risk of getting shot by a guard. A risk not worth taking, she figured, especially considering the risk she'd already taken last night. She counted herself lucky that the guards hadn't caught her in the act then. Maybe she'd accidentally picked the perfect moments to avoid whatever they had for eyes. Such incidental luck would be a lot harder to achieve out in the open.

She sat up on the bed, letting her feet dangle off its edge, and sighed heavily. What would she do now? How would she continue hunting down her father's killer when coming here had yielded no progress? This was the one place she was sure she'd find leads, if only there had been any. And the Net was no longer an option.

She pondered for at least five minutes, trying to come up with a contingency plan but growing more frustrated when she couldn't.

Wait... It was suddenly coming to her. Dad had a neural interface installed, right? I wonder if there'd be anything in there. Ugh, but what are the chances the cops will let me see his body even if they still have it?

Despite her uncertainty over whether asking them to let her see Yoshiro's neural logs would work, she decided it was worth a shot.

Then she heard a thud outside. A quick look outside the window showed her that a police hovercar had appeared, parked on the grass that seemed synthetic now that Maria looked at it in the sunlight. She got to her feet and dashed through the only door in the cabin out onto the terrace, simultaneously excited and nervous to see who had arrived.

The officer emerged from the car at the exact same moment Maria emerged from inside the cabin. She was relieved to see Devin approaching.

“Glad it’s you who came to pick me up,” she hollered to him, the sentiment coming out more genuine than sarcastic, much to her own surprise.

“Glad to be the one to pick you up,” he hollered back. Then came the fateful inquiry: “Found anything?”

Maria’s response came out carried by a sigh. “Fucking wish I had.” She paused for a moment before continuing, crossing her hands behind her back. “You were right. I was naive to think coming here would bring me closer to figuring out who killed Dad.”

Devin nodded. “That mean you’re done meddling?”

Maria raised an eyebrow. Did Devin confess to having brought her to the cabin just to teach her the lesson? Was that his motivation for “helping” her? The warm tingling in her chest turned colder. But the initial shock over the revelation slowly turned into a fierce, determined smirk. She muttered a response: “Oh, I’m far from done, officer.”

Now it was Devin’s turn to raise an eyebrow. Only his

look was less one of shock and more of intrigue. “Do I want to know what you’re planning next?”

Maria had no trouble whatsoever explaining her next steps. “You still have his body, right?”

Devin simply stared into Maria’s eyes for a second, evidently deciding on how to respond. The one he finally produced came out as such: “Let’s talk in the car.”

“Can I do something else real quick?”

“Yeah. I’m in no rush.”

Maria smirked gratefully, picked up the recorder on the terrace table and pressed the Record button on it. Then she spoke into it the following words: “Maria Crahan, day one. Officer Nichols is a dick.” Pressed the Stop button and placed the device back in its usual place.

Devin snorted. Then Maria walked over to the car, and he opened the back door for her. *At least you’re a gentlemanly dick.* Maria stepped in, followed by Devin sitting in the driver’s seat, and they drove out of the walled garden.

Once they were on the other side of the gate, Devin inquired: “So why do you want to see your father’s body?”

“To see who killed him.”

Devin’s eyebrows shot up in the rearview mirror. Now he looked shocked. “See who killed him?” he repeated.

“Yeah.”

“How do you suppose we can help with that?”

“By digging into his neural link. Reproducing a photographic snapshot of his last few seconds alive. I know you have

the tech for it.”

“I mean we do, but that’s not guaranteed to produce anything useful. The data in his neural link has had two weeks to decay. It’s probably corrupted beyond repair at this point.”

“Even if it’s corrupted, it’s worth a shot, right?” Maria’s voice was burning with determination.

Devin stared at her through the rearview mirror for a few seconds, then sighed and commented: “You’re not gonna give up, are you?”

“Nope,” Maria replied. “Not until I get something that’ll tell me who killed him.”

Then her stomach growled. She was so determined to hunt down her father’s murderer that she didn’t realize how hungry she was until now. “There a hot dog stand nearby?” she asked Devin.

“Don’t know about a hot dog stand, but we’re not far from a burger joint. If you’re fine with that.”

“Sure. Sounds good.”

With a cheeseburger in one hand and a ginger smoothie in the other, Maria walked back over to the police car, making sure to put a little extra sway to her step that’d catch Devin’s attention. To her delight, his eyes were glued to her as she approached. *Good to know I still got it.* Although Devin didn’t seem to look at her with much resembling lust – a true police officer, profess-

ional to a fault, work before fun. Or maybe he simply wanted to respect her boundaries after the conversation about her dead husband from the night before. In a way, Maria didn't blame him.

"Is that a ginger smoothie?" Devin hollered a question, taking note of the color of the liquid in the translucent cup when Maria had strolled close enough for him to do so.

"Yep," Maria said bluntly. "Why? Is it bad here?"

"Never tried it, so can't comment. Just an interesting choice of beverage with a cheeseburger."

"It's called balancing your diet. A girl's gotta get her vitamins somehow." Maria locked her lips around the straw sticking out of the cup and took a sip of the smoothie.

Devin shrugged in response.

Maria swallowed the dose of smoothie – Devin should absolutely try it, she thought – and then said to him: "Mind opening the door for me? My hands are a little full here."

"Not at all." With that, Devin climbed out of the driver's seat and opened the backdoor for Maria, even going as far as to close it for her when she got in.

Maria unwrapped the burger and took a ravenous first bite of it, not even slowing down to appreciate every nuance of the flavor. It did taste like a cheeseburger, but that was all the detail she was able and willing to make out in her hunger.

"How is it?" Devin asked while starting the car back up.

"Not bad," Maria replied between bites. "Don't know if it's quite worth 300 credits, though."

“Three hundred?” Devin hollered and turned his head back, putting particular emphasis on the “three”. “Huh. Price has gone up since the last time I dropped by.”

“Really? Was it like 250 before?”

“270.”

“Well, it’s more worth that. Barely.” While Maria was providing her comment on what she might be willing to pay for a burger of this quality, Devin curved onto the highway.

They drove in relative silence for a few minutes, the only sounds beside the car engine coming from Maria’s food and drink as she gobbled them down. When she was finished, she asked: “Don’t suppose you have a trash can in here?”

“Nah. You can just leave ‘em on the floor. Long as you clean up after yourself.”

“Alright.” Maria popped off the lid of the cup, shoved the empty burger wrapper in it, put the lid back on and placed the cup on the floor between her feet.

“Are you sure perusing your dad’s neural link is gonna help?” Devin asked at that point, as if he’d been waiting for Maria to finish her breakfast before starting this conversation.

“Yes and no,” Maria confessed. “Honestly, I’m just improvising. The cabin was the first real lead I had and I don’t even know how I stumbled upon it. But of course, that was a dead end.”

“But you still knew to go to the cabin.”

“Only because I remembered him mentioning it.” Maria paused in thought for a moment. “And I guess because cabins as

resorts or residential buildings is a dead concept in Neo-Tokyo. No joke, I tried to look for cabins on the Net when I was doing my initial research and not a single one turned up. Makes you think, doesn't it?"

Devin shot an intrigued gaze at Maria through the rear-view mirror. "Think about what?"

"Put it this way: you're born in this concrete jungle of a megacity. Skyscrapers tall enough to cover any and all views of nature unless you're on the top floor. But who has the money to get that high? The power? How many others are given the luxury of making it halfway up? What can the average person realistically do to see the world outside the city walls? 98% of the country is covered in this shit. And the few spots with real trees, real flowers, smells of real nature, have been turned into either prison ground or vacation resorts that are priced out the ass. What that tells me is that the bastards running the country *want* us to live in depression. Suck in the fumes of industry and desperation until we suffocate. And the remedy is locked behind a gate that only opens to the ones at the extreme ends of the scale. Crime is just another way of keeping society running and nature is treated like a threat to your sanity. It's a little bit backwards if you ask me."

Devin stayed quiet, evidently lost in thought, merely nodding subtly. Maria felt a sense of pride over having given him something to chew on.

23

Devin drove into the garage of the Office of Legal and Military Operations and parked the car in the free spot closest to the main elevator. He and Maria climbed out and set foot towards the morgue. As they did, Maria ran through every potential scenario in her head, hoping for the best and preparing for the worst. If this didn't produce any leads either – if her father's neural logs really were so corrupted that she couldn't identify the murderer – she didn't know what else she could possibly come up with. She might just need to abandon her investigation altogether. Of course, she hoped it wouldn't come to that.

“We'll have to drop by the police department floor first,” Devin informed her as they strolled down the corridor towards the main elevator. “Civilians aren't normally allowed to enter the morgue, so I need to sort out clearance for you.”

Maria shot a death glare at him. “Didn't occur to you to tell me that detail *any* sooner? Or did you deliberately leave that part out?”

“I will neither confirm nor deny.”

Maria let out a sharp nose exhale, half frustrated, half amused.

Then they reached the elevator door. The two of them

rode it up to the police department floor and walked up to an office door. Maria didn't take note of the name printed on the plaque next to it.

Devin rang the doorbell, and a voice echoed from the speaker attached to it. "Who is it and what's your business?" it asked, sounding quite agitated, as if Devin and Maria were interrupting something.

"It's Devin," said the officer acting as Maria's escort. "Got a civilian with me, wants to see her father's body in the morgue."

"Come on in," the other officer replied, and the door to the office slid open.

Maria followed Devin into the office, keeping her gaze glued to the officer sitting behind the desk. A native Japanese-looking man, middle-aged, black hair that shone like it'd been polished with turtle wax, combed back into a sleek helmet around his scalp. And equally shiny sunglasses with lenses that acted like mirrors. She didn't see the point of wearing them indoors.

"So who are you?" the man asked Maria.

"Maria Crahan," she introduced herself. "I'm the daughter of Yoshiro Busujima. He was killed in prison the day he—"

"Yeah, yeah, I don't need to know how he died," the officer interrupted her, waving a dismissive hand. Then he spun his chair to face her directly. Although his eyes were hidden behind the mirror sheen of his sunglasses, Maria didn't like the way his gaze seemed to intensify. After a moment of silence, he

said: “Don’t see a neural interface on you.”

“Do I need one for clearance?”

“No, just means setting it up will take a little longer.”

Then he tapped on a wrist-mounted device of some sort for a few seconds, producing a holographic projection of a personal information form and saying to Maria: “If you’d be so kind as to fill that out.”

“Absolutely.” Maria took her time filling out the form and hovered a finger over the Submit button when she was done.

The officer grabbed the holographic form like a sheet of paper, pasted it on the screen of his holocomp and pressed a few more buttons. For a moment, the only noises in the office were those that the holocomp emitted.

The officer broke the silence some time later. “Alright, the morgue has your clearance. Just give them your name at the door and they’ll let you in.”

“Thanks, Koji,” Devin said and escorted Maria out of the office. Koji hollered “Anytime” after them. Then they headed back to the elevators and rode one of them a few floors down to where the morgue was. When they came up to what looked like a reception desk, Maria said her name as the other officer had instructed, and a few seconds later, she was in a corridor-like room that was lined with cryo-chambers on both sides.

“Who are you looking for?” asked one of the morgue employees in Jangl. Addressed more so to Devin than Maria,

she figured.

“Yoshiro Busujima,” Devin replied. The morgue guard found the chamber in which his body was held in no time flat, as if they had memorized whose body was held in which chamber. Devin and Maria thanked them for the assistance, and then they left them to their own devices.

Devin pulled a cable out of his own wrist-worn thingamajig, with a connector like a three-pronged fork but with nails for the prongs, the kind that would slot into the jack of a neural interface. Then he instructed Maria: “Find the neural jack for me, then plug this in there. I’ll do some setting up in the meantime.”

Maria obeyed wordlessly, grief and disgust bubbling in her core, but she maintained her composure. She brushed the part of Yoshiro’s hair aside under which the neural interface was concealed, scanned it with her eyes in search of the neural jack and plugged the cord in when she found it. When she did, holographic text popped up in the air from Devin’s wrist apparatus. Maria looked at it curiously and tried to read it, but it was essentially a block of random letters and numbers. Devin kept tapping on the device for a few minutes. He looked so entranced in his work that Maria didn’t dare say anything, lest she disturb him.

Eventually, she heard him say: “Okay, I reached the memory layer. Now to figure out which one of these blocks is the last one.”

“Wouldn’t it be the one at the top?” Maria inquired.

“You’d think so, but it’s not as logical as that in practice,” Devin replied while he kept tapping away. “The memories are stored on a deeper level than diagnostic info, and the deeper you go, the more scrambled the data gets.”

“Right.” Maria pointed to a random block on the holographic projection as Devin scrolled. “So what’s in that one for instance?”

“Let’s see.” Devin opened the block Maria pointed to, and a video of one of Yoshiro’s memories started playing. One from about 34 years ago, Maria figured – the moment of her conception. She recognized her mother from the video, naked on top of Yoshiro, riding him passionately and moaning with equal fervor. In that moment, Maria wondered how her mother was doing – the woman had divorced Yoshiro and moved out of Japan when Maria was young, and she had no desire to stay in touch with anyone she knew here. Not even her own children.

Devin closed the video with a swift motion, as if he’d been caught watching porn at work. Which, in a way, he had. His face didn’t show any signs of embarrassment, but Maria still chuckled.

He kept scrolling through the memory banks, eyeing the information he could decipher – must be a skill they teach the police here, because Maria couldn’t make sense of any of it – and ignoring most of the entries. Then, a few minutes later, he finally stopped at one.

“Think this is the one,” he said. Maria scrambled over to Devin’s side, leaning against him like they were a couple at a

movie theater, and Devin opened the file.

Please be usable, please be usable, please be usable...

The video was an ocean of static. Maria groaned in frustration, hunching over and hiding her head between her knees.

She felt Devin's eyes on the back of her neck. "Won't lie, I was hoping there'd be something here too," he muttered.

"It's just dead end after dead end, isn't it?" Maria croaked in defeat while she lifted her head. "I'm never gonna find out who killed him at this rate."

Devin was quiet. When Maria turned her gaze to him, his expression was conflicted. He looked like he had an idea that would help Maria on her investigation but also compromise whatever the police were looking into. "What's on your mind?" Maria asked him at the risk of not getting a straight answer.

Devin shook his head and replied: "Nothing."

Maria wasn't convinced but decided not to push the subject.

While Devin unplugged the cable from Yoshiro's neural interface, Maria got up to her feet and sighed to him: "Thanks for your help. I'm going home."

"Need a ride?"

"I live close enough that I can walk. Besides, aren't you on the clock?"

Devin shrugged in response, the motion accompanied by a smirk of admittance. "And what about you? Don't need to be at work?"

"It's my day off. Something you don't get very often, I

know.” Maria’s tone turned sarcastic halfway into the statement.

Devin snorted. “Well, enjoy. And sorry you didn’t get to see your dad’s murderer.”

“It’s okay,” Maria sighed in response. “Not your fault.”

With that, she exited the morgue, rode one of the elevators back to the ground floor and made towards her home, coming up with no ideas as to how she was going to continue her quest to find out who had killed her father. But she also didn’t want to drop it just yet.

24

Josh entered his office and sat down at his desk with a cardboard mug filled to the brim with coffee in hand, producing a grunt of unprecedented frustration as he did so. He hadn't felt this disappointed in ages. Disappointed in himself, in his team, in how the investigation was going. The better part of a week had passed since the last crucial turn of events in the case – the encounter with the murderer and the deal Josh struck with her – and it felt like progress on the investigation had only been stalling since.

Which, Josh had to admit, was partially his own fault. He'd made the call to cancel team meetings indefinitely a few days ago, taken it upon himself to tell his team about it this time, without Jenn as the messenger. But to what end had he really made that decision? He told himself it was in the interest of protecting the integrity of the investigation, but was that now starting to cost him his team's trust? His trust in himself had been starting to waver, that much he could say with confidence.

He opened up a copy of the case file on his holocomp and eyed it absent-mindedly, mumbling recitals of key names and events without attempting to draw any new mental lines, taking the occasional sip of his coffee.

After some time, maybe fifteen minutes, his office door whined, sliding open. He kept his eyes glued to the screen of the holocomp. He could guess the offender.

“There’s a doorbell to the right, y’know,” he mumbled, using a tone of voice that was exclusively reserved for Jenn whenever she barged in unannounced. The one person in the entire building with a nasty habit of forgetting to ring it.

The voice that echoed back from the open door confirmed his suspicion. “Sorry,” Jenn replied with a chuckle. “I just... wanna talk. Subordinate to team leader.”

Josh turned his gaze to Jenn. Her eyes twinkled with worry. He almost turned her away with the excuse of being busy but eventually welcomed her in with a wag of his fingers.

Jenn walked over to his desk while the door slid shut behind her, took a seat and sighed lightly before airing her concern. “I’ll be blunt.” Somehow, Josh immediately knew this was going to be bad. So did Jenn, judging by how she visibly steeled herself before continuing. “We’ve been talking within the team about getting a new leader assigned to the case. The guys think your performance this past week has been substandard. That you’re not fulfilling your duties to us as a team leader.”

Yep. Was afraid of that. Another sigh escaped Josh. He stayed quiet for a moment, pondering how he should formulate the response he wanted to give. Struggling to find the words he wanted to use. To put up a strong enough defense. When he did eventually speak, he simply said: “No. This is my case. I can’t just hand it over to someone else.”

“You’re gonna have to come up with a stronger defense if you wanna keep it in your hands,” Jenn threatened. She was only half-joking, Josh could tell.

“Jenn, please,” Josh muttered, hunching over and crossing his arms over the desk. “The case *has* to stay under my lead. There’s something very important related to it that’s best kept off-record.”

“Couldn’t you just brief the new team lead about it?”

“No.”

“Why? What do you know that’s so sensitive?”

See, that’s the part I can’t tell you about, else I’ll be fired. Josh wanted to be honest and say that, but he knew better than to throw his 30-year career away in an instant. “I wish I could tell you. Just trust me when I say the case is better off staying with me.”

“Bold of you to ask me to trust you when you don’t seem to trust yourself. That’s why you put the team meetings on ice, ain’t it?”

Josh’s breathing hitched briefly. *Yeah, there you go underestimating my perceptiveness again,* Jenn’s eyes seemed to say. He maintained his composure, though.

“Talk to me, Josh,” Jenn muttered. “What are you so afraid of? Is it compromising the investigation? Your career?”

“Don’t try to play psychologist with me,” Josh snapped.

Jenn leaned back with widened eyes. Josh didn’t fully realize what he’d said until she responded. “Sheesh, what’s with you?!”

Josh hung his head down and placed a fist of shame upon the bridge of his nose. “Sorry. Didn’t mean that.” Then he lifted his gaze again. “I just... I’ve just been frustrated with the lack of progress on the case. Feels like we’ve gotten nowhere.” Partly because his inside informant hadn’t made contact since their initial run-in. That, of course, was the part he couldn’t let Jenn in on.

“Know what would help?”

He did. But he didn’t trust himself to not crack under pressure. If team meetings were to be continued, he *knew* the others would needle him about what he knew that they didn’t. And he’d spill the secret he was guarding. “Team meetings will have to stay in ice, I’m afraid. To protect the investigation.”

“So you *are* afraid of compromising it.”

Josh nodded heavily. “But I’m also willing to fight to keep it under my own supervision.”

“Fear and determination is a hell of a mix,” Jenn commented, turning her gaze to the ceiling. “I just hope you’ll come up with a better defense before the guys take it to legal.”

The mention of the internal legal team caught Josh off guard. “Why does legal need to be involved?” he asked. “Not enough to just go straight to Takeshi?” The CEO.

“Fellas think you’re breaching code of conduct, so no. I tried to talk ‘em out of it, trust me, but they’re sticking to it.”

“Well, I appreciate the effort.” As much as Jenn was needling Josh at the moment, he was at least grateful that she was on his side in some respect.

“Anytime,” Jenn sighed in response. “Just, you know... Treat this as a warning about what to expect. I don’t think the guys are—”

“Screw the guys for a moment. What do *you* think?”

“I don’t fucking know, Josh,” Jenn almost yelled. Then she just stared at Josh for what felt like an eternity, a painful silence filling the office. The longer it lasted, the more compromised Josh felt.

Jenn eventually broke the silence with a sigh and a plan. “I’ll talk to the guys about calling off the whole thing. Not expecting it to work, though.”

“Thanks in advance either way,” Josh replied. Jenn produced a subtle nod, got up and walked out of his office.

In that same moment, Josh realized he hadn’t asked Jenn about when they were intending to commence the proceedings. He started drafting a defense speech in his head immediately, in case he’d need to be giving it by tomorrow.

25

Jenn wasn't quite sure how to feel about Josh. About his ability to keep handling the Harashima case. She'd spent the majority of the workday wrestling with what Josh had told her between other duties she'd been assigned to handle – or rather, the duties she'd volunteered to handle, seeing as Josh hadn't bothered to even assign tasks between the members of the Harashima team for nearly a week. “Pick and choose among yourselves” had been his order as to who was doing what. Not that it was much of a problem – the team was more than capable of self-assigning investigative tasks, her included – it was just different from how Josh usually operated.

Then there was the question of whatever information he held that was so sensitive he couldn't let anyone else know about it. Josh wasn't the type to withhold intel, let alone at the expense of progress. Jenn had been working with Josh on many a case for close to a decade, and in that time, he had *never* acted like this.

Maybe the case really was getting to him on a level even Jenn didn't fully understand. But if it was, why wouldn't he step down and hand the case over to someone better-equipped to lead it? Obviously it had something to do with whatever had

happened the week before, the night the Office's main elevator broke down. What *had* happened that night, though? And why was Josh so secretive about it?

The number of questions running through her mind was so overwhelming that she had trouble focusing on what she was currently supposed to be doing. Enez's files were open on her holocomp, ready to be scanned for any inconsistencies, but Jenn's attempts at doing so in the past two hours had amounted to merely eyeing the text on the screen, her brain in a mode that wasn't conducive to being a productive investigator.

Jenn didn't usually decide to stay at the office this late into the night – she valued a healthy work-life balance – but an undetermined impulse had guided her to do so today. Maybe she'd felt the need to make up for her lack of productivity earlier in the day by working overtime. But clearly it wasn't working.

She sighed in resignation and turned off the holocomp.

Then she got up and walked up to Josh's office door – poor man had also decided to stay in late – this time remembering to ring the doorbell. “State your name and business,” sounded his voice from the speaker attached to it.

“It's Jenn,” she responded. “Just letting you know I'm calling it a day.”

“Right. Was thinking the same.”

“Uh-huh. Want a ride home?” Jenn offered. She'd always found it a little odd that Josh had a driver's license but not his own car. With how far he lived from the Office of Legal and

Military Operations, she would have thought he'd prefer to have his own ride instead of relying on public transport to get to and from work. Or maybe he liked using public transit.

"Nah, I'll hop on a bus."

"Suit yourself. Good night."

"Night."

With that, Jenn strolled over to the main elevator and rode it down to ground floor, then turned a few corners to get to the parking lot. The colorful night lights of Neo-Tokyo greeted her as ceilings stopped blocking the view. She wasn't much of a nocturnal creature, but something about the visuals of the city at this hour spoke to her on a spiritual level.

Jenn thought she caught the shadow of something behind her as she walked up to her car and reached for the lever of its door.

She threw her gaze backwards in an attempt to determine what it was. Nothing. Not even the faintest hint of anyone or anything having been behind her a second ago, even though she could swear she wasn't alone. And she knew it wasn't Josh.

Her neck remained craned in 'look behind' position for an unusually long time by her standards. But she had to make sure she hadn't hallucinated the shadow. She wasn't usually the paranoid type, but in this moment, she felt like she was. And that feeling only grew by the second, as the shadow didn't appear again.

Something struck her in the back of her head. She fell to her knees and bent over, doing her best to maintain conscious-

ness. Her breathing became heavier. She tried to turn her head and look behind her again, see who had attacked her, but a hand clasped around her scalp with a firm grip, preventing it from moving. She struggled against the force, concluding it was no use as her muscles began to weaken gradually.

An oddly gentle female voice said to her in a half-whisper: "Sorry, honey. You'll be fine."

Then she felt something akin to a needle embedding to the side of her head, and her vision and mind went blank.

Josh's wrist comm chirped just as he was about to walk out of his office. He looked at it and felt a slight sense of concern looking at the name on the screen. Jenn never called him outside office hours unless it was an emergency, let alone on the police force's internal frequencies.

He answered the call. Something felt off as soon as Jenn's holographic projection came up in the air. Her expression felt... empty. Devoid of any emotion. Josh simply stared at the projection in shock, unable to utter so much as a grunt of concern.

"Don't fret," the holographic "Jenn" spoke. Quotes very much warranted, as even her inflection didn't carry Jenn's usual mannerisms. No, this was someone else speaking *through* Jenn. How and why? Josh was determined to find out.

"Who is this and what have you done with Jenn?" he

growled.

“It’s your inside person. As for your coworker, you don’t need to worry. I just hijacked her brain momentarily.”

Josh felt a sensation that was wholly unfamiliar to him, like his heart was sinking. His breathing paused for a second. This merc was resourceful, he had to hand it to her. But above every other emotion he felt in the moment, concern for Jenn’s safety was at the top of the pyramid. “Why would you do that?!” he demanded.

“Safest way to get in touch with you. I have something you’ll want to know.”

“Hacking my colleague’s neural link is the safest way to get in touch with me?” Josh couldn’t believe what he was hearing. But at the same time, he was sure the killer had her reasons for having to resort to such an extreme measure.

Evidently she did. “Yes, if I want to stay untraceable. I’m doing this out of necessity, not malice.” Her tone – for what Josh could decipher of it, with her speaking through Jenn – was colored with slight agitation but mostly calm.

Josh sighed. Then he proceeded to ask: “Well, what did you wanna tell me? I’m assuming something related to the investigation.”

“Yes and no.”

“Care to elaborate?”

“A group of my colleagues is set to walk into DanariTek and kidnap the boss tomorrow. Guy by the name of Martin Stokes. Operation’s scheduled for noon. There’ll probably be

bodies. Unless you feel like making an appearance. I know you have a reputation in the force for an itchy trigger finger. Here's an opportunity to actually put it into good use."

Josh was quiet for a moment. He hadn't been aware his reputation preceded him beyond the police force. But the offer was tempting. "So you want me to eliminate the goons and prevent the kidnapping? Is that it?"

"Wow, you *are* as sharp as you look," the woman commented sarcastically.

Josh was thoroughly unamused by the "compliment". A follow-up question came to his mind. "You want me to go there alone or should I bring backup?"

"Bring at least three bodies with you. One group to lead evacuation efforts, the other to gun down the infiltrators."

Josh nodded. "Can I expect to see you there?"

"No. I'll be busy elsewhere. Besides, I said you needed me out in the field."

"I know. Was just curious."

The woman snorted, as if she wasn't entirely convinced. "Anyway, *sayonara*."

"Wait," Josh hollered, hoping he wasn't too late. To his delight, the woman didn't end the call just as he said the word. "Jenn's gonna need medical attention. Where can I send some?"

"Parking lot. Propped up against what I assume to be her car."

"Great. Thanks." The holographic "Jenn" nodded, then disintegrated. Josh immediately dialed in another number – one

of the head nurses – and had to wait no more than a few seconds for Rina Matsumoto to pick up. “Ah, Officer Heynes, how can I help you?” she chirped.

“Send a team to the parking lot. Jenn’s passed out by her car in there.”

“Right away, sir,” Rina replied and promptly ended the call.

“Hang on, Jenn,” Josh muttered to himself while heading for the main elevator. “Help’s on the way.” He almost wanted to head to the parking lot and look over Jenn himself, but he was so spent from everything that had happened today that he simply wanted to go home.

26

The first thing Josh did the next morning was drop by Jenn's room on the infirmary floor. An odd sense of guilt gnawed at him as he looked at her sleeping peacefully, as if she had no memory of what'd happened to her the night before, while a nurse was typing away at a holocomp on the other side of the bed. But he knew it wasn't his fault that the assassin had decided to contact him by such extreme means. He understood she wanted to stay untrackable, but he wasn't convinced it necessitated hacking people's neural links just to give him a call.

Or maybe she truly did have no other way to contact him. Maybe she didn't have a phone. Maybe that was why she'd felt the need to meet him face-to-face first.

A fragment of the memory of their elevator encounter crept into Josh's mind. The way she stood ominously above him in the elevator shaft. The way the lighting cast her as nothing more than a silhouette until she leaned in close enough to reveal her identity. He still wasn't sure whether she'd done so accidentally or deliberately. Though the way she'd asked him "What's wrong?" gave him the impression of the latter.

Shortly, Josh snapped back into reality as he heard a hum of intrigue escape the nurse.

“Found something?” he asked while shifting his gaze from Jenn over to the nurse.

“Yeah, and it’s something I haven’t seen before,” the nurse replied, gesturing for Josh to come closer and take a look himself. He wasted no time obliging.

As he looked at what the nurse had come across in Jenn’s neural logs, he produced a hum of intrigue of his own, almost identical to the one the nurse had let out. The latest diagnostic message, timestamped around the exact time Jenn had been attacked, showed but a long string of zeroes where it should normally display a clear error message. Just as what had been found in Miss Harady’s neural logs back when she had her “neural glitch”.

“This doesn’t make sense,” the nurse commented. “I mean corruption like this does happen sometimes, but it’s usually random. This feels deliberate.”

“Yeah,” Josh muttered in response. “I’ve seen this once before.”

“Have you now?”

Josh nodded. “And I fear it’s gonna do something bad if we let it stick around. Can you delete it?”

“Yeah. Just need to find the ID. Easier said than done with the entry being corrupted, though.”

“I trust you’ll do your best either way.” The nurse had three hours – Josh hoped it’d be enough. Then he turned on his heels, preparing to leave and head for his next objective. “I have some other business to take care of. Give me a call if something

comes up.”

“Will do,” the nurse hollered to Josh as he exited the infirmary room.

Just under two hours later, Josh parked the police car he had taken with Shinji in front of the DanariTek headquarters. The other car, with Devin and Goro in it, stopped in an almost parallel angle to theirs. They had about ten minutes to prepare for the arrival of the kidnappers, if the intel the assassin had given Josh was to be believed. But in a way, he had no reason to doubt her.

“How have you figured we’re going to handle this?” Shinji asked Josh as they exited the vehicle. Goro and Devin joined the two of them shortly.

“Goro and Devin will go in first to lead the evacuation,” Josh explained. “Get everyone *except* Martin Stokes out before the goons arrive. He’ll stay in as the bait. Then when they show up and storm the facility, we go in after them to take them down.”

“And you’re sure Stokes staying inside is crucial to the success of the plan?”

“Yeah. Use force if needed to keep him from sneaking out.” Addressed to Devin and Goro in particular, to which the two nodded affirmatively.

“So how did you know there’d be a kidnapping happen-

ing here today?” asked Goro.

“An anonymous informant dropped me the intel,” Josh replied nonchalantly. A statement that wasn’t entirely false, but he did his best to sound like he was telling nothing but the truth. His colleagues seemed convinced, merely nodding in response.

Then he straightened his posture, a sign to the rest of the team that it was time to get busy. “Alright, crew. Let’s get to work,” he ordered, giving Goro and Devin the signal to enter the building. He and Shinji climbed back into one of the cars in the meantime.

“I hope your informant didn’t feed you a false lead,” Shinji commented while fiddling with a series of buttons on the car’s dashboard.

“They’ll be here. You’ll see.”

“How are you so confident?”

“I just see no reason to doubt the legitimacy of the leak.”

“Sounds awfully naive coming from the lead investigator,” Shinji replied with a hint of sarcasm to his tone, leaning back in his seat and pressing one more button. “We’re in the PA system. Ready when you are.”

Josh nodded and grabbed a microphone from the dashboard, then pressed a button on it to speak to the people in the facility through the PA system that Shinji had remotely taken over: “People of DanariTek, this is Officer Josh Heynes. There’s an incoming terrorist attack. We’ve sent two police officers into the building to lead evacuation efforts. Please follow their instructions. Proceed calmly to the nearest emergency exit. I re-

peat: there's an incoming terrorist attack. Proceed to the nearest emergency exit and follow instructions given by the officers in the building." Then he released his finger from the button on the microphone and placed it back in its spot on the dashboard.

As they settled to wait for the arrival of the criminal gang, Shinji asked in a wish of confirmation: "So how do we handle the kidnappers? Shoot to kill?"

"Shoot to kill," Josh reaffirmed.

"Did the informant say how many of them we can expect to show up?"

"No. But I'll be surprised if there are more than five."

Shinji nodded. "Five is a reasonable estimate for an operation of this kind."

Maria listened to the emergency announcement from her office, already on her feet and in full-blown panic mode before it got to the part where it said to proceed *calmly* to an emergency exit. If there really were terrorists on the way, she preferred to be out of the building as soon as possible. Proceeding calmly was not an option. She wasted no time exiting her office and half-running towards where the nearest emergency exit would be – good thing she didn't need to stop and look for the signs. Her photographic memory guided her to it.

Eventually she turned to the hallway with the emergency exit door at the end of it, greeted by the sight of some of her

colleagues – ones she didn't know by name – already on the other side. “Hold the door for me!” she hollered to them, and they turned their gazes to her and obliged. Maria stopped to catch her breath once she was beyond the threshold.

While she was doing so, she heard the click of something to her left. She looked to said direction and was greeted by the sight of a gun pointed at her. Or the entire group. Holding the gun was a figure wearing a mask in the vague shape of a skull, with a thin, cross-shaped window where the eyes would be. And it looked ready to shoot.

Another figure that appeared right then, also wearing a mask of the same description, clasped a cybernetic hand around the barrel of the gun and said in a robotic voice: “Hold your fire. We're only here for Stokes.” A voice changer, had to be, in order to hide the identities of the attackers. The other figure put the gun down, a certain stiffness to the motion that looked like reluctance to Maria.

Then the masked men walked through the door Maria herself had gone through only a few seconds prior. No doubt to look for Martin. Her only hope was that they wouldn't hurt him, as much as she resented the man herself. But she didn't resent him enough to wish death upon him. She almost wanted to rush back in to find Martin and warn him about the goons, but she knew she'd be risking her own life if she did.

“What do they want with Martin?” asked one of her co-workers, a native Japanese woman that Maria estimated to be in her late 20s, in Jangl.

“No idea,” Maria replied.

“We should warn him,” suggested another coworker, this one a middle-aged black man, already digging his phone out.

“Yeah. We should,” Maria agreed.

Goro and Devin were making their way across the facility's oddly empty lounge towards the backdoor. One would have thought there'd be at least a few employees lingering here, but evidently everyone had taken Josh's word and deserted it as soon as the announcement had echoed. Which was a good sign, thought Devin. He hadn't seen Maria so far, but he hoped she was safe.

Was it professional to be concerned over the wellbeing of a single individual as opposed to everyone in the building? Why was Devin so concerned over her wellbeing? What was happening to him?

"Do you think we can trust Josh?" he aired a thought to Goro, snapping himself out of his whirlwind of obsession.

"What do you mean?" sounded Goro's counterinquiry.

"I mean who was the informant? Has to have been someone in the gang, right? I can't imagine an outsider would have enough intel for us to be here before the goons."

Goro nodded contemplatively. "That is a good point. But how does that weigh into whether we can trust Josh or not?"

"Well, he did cancel team meetings indefinitely. Then there was the night the main elevator broke down... What if he

was contacted by someone in the gang that night? Think about it, Goro. The evidence lines up a little too well if you ask me.”

Goro’s brow furrowed. He had to admit Devin was onto something. “That makes more sense than I care to admit.” Then he turned an intent gaze to Devin and said: “Even so, we’re preventing a bigger crime here. I’m less concerned with how Josh got the intel and more with actually saving lives.”

“Of course you would be,” Devin commented. “All I’m saying is we can’t be sure whose side the informant is ultimately on. And the more I think about it, the more this whole operation feels like a trap.”

Goro stopped in his tracks. “Fuck. Now that you mention it...”

Devin followed suit and turned on his heels to Goro’s direction. “Now you’re starting to have doubts too?”

Their conversation was interrupted by the sound of a gunshot and the breeze of a bullet flying between the two of them.

Devin and Goro unholstered their pistols and turned to the direction the bullet had come from. A figure, clad in an all-black suit and a skull-like mask, greeted them. It pressed a finger against the side of its head and spoke in a robotic voice: “The cops are here.” No doubt a radio call warning the rest of the infiltrators.

Then it shot again. Devin dove in one direction to dodge, Goro in the other. The two fired their guns simultaneously, a bullet from each connecting with the bastard’s kneecaps. The

figure dropped to its knees, screaming in pain, trying and failing to get back to its feet.

Devin dialed in Josh's number on his wrist comm. Josh picked up within the second, and Devin hollered to him: "We've got contact with the infiltrators."

"Shit," Josh muttered. "They must've taken the back entrance. How many of them?"

"One that we've run into so far. No knowing how many more there are."

Josh's hologram nodded. "Alright, change of plans. Everyone into hunting mode. Shoot to kill. If you run into any civilians, guide them to the rendezvous point. Shinji and I will be there shortly."

"Roger," Devin replied and hit the End Call button. Then he turned his attention to Goro and asked him: "Wanna draw first blood?"

"Don't mind if I do," Goro replied enthusiastically, raising his gun and firing a bullet into the goon's chest. He fell backward from the impact.

Another robotic voice echoed from behind in the same moment, shouting something in Japanese that Devin figured translated roughly to "Die, motherfuckers", punctuated by a bullet that missed his head by an inch. Devin spun around as quickly as he could and fired at the attacker's chest. The figure staggered and fell forward, rolling down the stairs it happened to be climbing down.

"Some criminals," Goro commented. "Didn't even in-

vest in bulletproof vests.”

“Safe to assume the masks are armored, though,” Devin replied in a tone that was the total opposite of Goro’s sarcasm. “So don’t aim for the head.”

“Yeah. I figured as much.”

“Your informant didn’t tell you they’d be taking the back entrance?” Shinji aired a surprised-sounding inquiry to Josh as the two of them got out of their car and started running towards the building’s main entrance.

“Nope,” Josh replied, unholstering his gun. He was quite impressed with himself over how swift and coordinated he’d managed to stay without any cybernetic enhancements at his age. “Not sure how it didn’t occur to me to ask either.”

Shinji produced an expression that Josh figured to mean something between understanding and disappointment. “Don’t take this the wrong way, but I think you need a vacation.”

“What could possibly make you think that?”

“Where do you want me to start?”

From that question, Josh understood immediately what Shinji meant. The list of code violations he had made over the past few years was long, but he wasn’t sure if he bought the idea that they could simply be chalked up to lack of rest. Then again, he’d always been a bit of a workaholic – a trait that had been the root cause of the bulk of the arguments between him

and Momoko. And he also realized that he *had* been neglecting his wife lately. Maybe taking some time off wouldn't be the worst idea.

"Point taken," Josh mumbled in response. "I'll think about it. After we wrap up this case."

"Don't just think about it," Shinji pleaded. "You deserve to live a life outside the force. And besides, it won't make just me happy."

"Fine, I'll *take* the vacation."

In response, Shinji produced a nod of trust. In that same moment, he and Josh ran through the double doors that constituted the main entrance of the DanariTek facility, the barrels of their guns acting as their eyes. No one in the reception area.

Josh's wrist comm chirped. It was Devin. Josh picked up, muttering a "Yeah?" as a greeting.

"Forgot to mention," Devin began, "they're wearing masks. Probably armored. So don't try to shoot them in the head."

"Understood. What's your status?"

"We're scanning the production wing on the first floor. Ran into a couple more goons and took 'em down."

"Keep going through the first floor. We'll take the second."

"Roger." And with that, the holographic projection of Devin disappeared. Josh grabbed his gun with both hands, aiming it at nothing in particular through the open doorway that led into the lounge and walking through with Shinji right behind

him. He looked straight ahead. He looked to his left. He looked to his right. No immediate threats anywhere, but he did notice two bodies in black suits and masks – one at the foot of the staircase to the left, the other at the doorway ahead. Infiltrators that Devin and Goro had already taken out, no doubt.

He looked to Shinji and issued an order: “Stairs to the left. Let’s go.”

The two wasted no time ascending the stairs to the second floor, the one with all of the offices. Josh kept his gun pointed ahead, ready to shoot at the first sign of movement. He almost did shoot as soon as he turned a corner and noticed a figure right up in his face, but he managed to hold his fire when he realized it was a civilian.

“Don’t shoot!” the poor man shouted in panic, throwing his hands in the air. Josh spent a moment taking in his facial features and attire. He certainly looked like someone who’d be employed at the facility.

Then he looked at his nametag. Martin Stokes. The boss. The kidnap target.

Despite who he was looking at, Josh didn’t lower his gun. He kept it pointed at Stokes, though only to reinforce the command he issued to the man: “Back to your office. You’ll be safer there. We’ll escort you.”

Stokes looked like he wanted to respond for a moment, but his train of thought was interrupted by a jingle emanating from his pocket. His phone. He dug it out, glanced at the screen, raised a finger so as to say “hold on” to Josh and picked up. To

his dismay, Josh only heard Stokes's side of the conversation, but the nature of it told him whoever was on the other end was merely an employee trying to warn him. Stokes spun around a fair amount as he spoke, agitation clearly growing by the second. "Yeah? You think I'm not fucking aware?! What do you mean where am I? I'm headed for the main entrance. I know that's not... Okay, look, I'm not expendable. The fuckers are sure to be where they're likely to score the most casualties. I'm not about to—"

A sudden gunshot startled Stokes enough to interrupt him and cause him to hang up. Josh had caught one of the attackers rounding a corner, evidently alerted to Stokes's location by his shouting, and eliminated the threat. When he was sure no one else was coming, he turned his attention back to Stokes and muttered to him: "Listen here, you corporate asshat. These goons aren't interested in how many innocent lives they can take. *You* alone are their target. And if you care about staying alive, you'll start moving towards your office *now*. Quietly."

If fear was a measurable unit, the expression on Stokes's face said that his fear levels had doubled upon Josh setting the record straight. He threw his hands up and half-whispered: "Okay. You're the professionals. This way."

With that, Stokes turned on his heels and started guiding the officers towards their destination. "You watch our six," Josh muttered an order to Shinji as they started moving, and Shinji obeyed wordlessly. He did a swift 180 and pointed the barrel of his gun to what equated to the group's flank, ready to shoot any-

one that might try to attack them from behind.

To Josh's surprise, they made it to Stokes's office without running into a single other attacker. Had they already run out of people? Had his crew already eliminated all of them? Had his estimate about the size of the kidnapping crew been correct?

Not quite, turned out to be the answer to all of those questions as Stokes fumbled with the keycard scanner of his office door. One more gunshot echoed from the far end of the hallway, startling the poor bastard and making him drop his keycard. While he crouched down to pick it back up, Josh took down the attacker with a well-placed shot to the chest.

He was surprised but oddly pleased to find out that the criminals hadn't realized to invest in protective gear beyond the masks. *For such a highly coordinated operation, you'd think the bastards wouldn't be this willing to die.*

With a beep and a whirr, the door to Stokes's office slid open, and the three of them entered it without making any more noise. The sound of gunfire was sure to attract the remaining goons here, provided any were still alive.

"What do these bastards want with me?" Stokes inquired while seating himself at his desk, the subtle whine of the hydraulic suspension in his chair giving in under his weight acting as a replacement for the sigh of relief he didn't produce.

"They were gonna kidnap you," Josh replied. "For what purpose, I don't know."

"Kidnap me?!" The tone of Stokes's exclamation con-

veyed concern over his own ability to coordinate employees over anything else, should the operation have been successful.

“Be glad we got to you before they did. Your fate could have been a lot worse.”

“Yeah. Of course. I appreciate you for saving me.” Then Stokes became a lot more contemplative. “Factory’s gonna have to be closed for some time, though. Can’t have my employees walking around in here as long as there are bodies lying around.”

“Then you should know what to do. We’ll call in our morgue team and start the cleanup ASAP.”

“Sure. Thanks again.”

Josh nodded in response, then started fiddling with his wrist comm in order to call Devin and Goro. He decided to call the latter, if only for a slight change of pace. Goro was as quick to pick up as he’d expected him to be. “Status?” Josh inquired.

“We’ve just about cleared the entire first floor,” Goro replied. “No notable encounters. Looks like most of the crew has already been taken out.”

“Alright. Great work. Head to the rendezvous point to make sure all the civilians are safe. We’ll wait for you back at the main entrance.”

“Roger. See you.” And Josh hit the End Call button.

“Shouldn’t we go see if they parked any vehicles in the back?” Shinji inquired. Josh’s breathing hitched for a moment. How had he not considered the possibility that the attackers didn’t come by foot? He was starting to lose his grip. Shinji was

right to be concerned about his professional ability. The more Josh thought about it, the more he had to admit to himself that he needed a vacation.

“Yeah. We should,” he muttered.

Then his phone rang. Not his wrist comm, his *phone*.

Looking out to the factory backyard through a window in the stairway that constituted the emergency exit, Maria had caught a glance of a truck parked there. It'd come crashing through the gate and no one had apparently taken notice of it in the midst of the chaos. The panicked screams of the employees following the announcement from the police had evidently drowned it out. Maria figured it to be the masked men's entrance vehicle. And she wanted a closer look at it. She knew venturing outdoors towards an unknown transport vessel was a bad idea, but curiosity got the better of her.

She slipped out through the emergency exit door, ducking behind a corner just in case there were more of the goons keeping watch outside. Taking a careful peek beyond it, she counted a grand total of zero of them. Had they really sent in the entire crew just to get one man? Or had there been some men outside earlier but they'd ditched? Maybe someone inside called for backup and everyone on truck guard duty just rushed in?

Well, whatever the case, the absence of guards made it easy to approach the truck. But even when she did, Maria kept her stance half-crouched, staying close to whatever cars she fi-

gured she could use as cover. As unmanned as the parking lot looked, Maria preferred to play it safe. She didn't want to risk getting spotted and shot at, just in case there was a masked man or two keeping watch near the truck.

But the closer she got, the more convinced she became that every single one of the attackers had indeed gone inside. She made it to the truck undetected and unharmed. Concluding that she was safe, she straightened her posture and tried to peek into the truck through whatever windows she could find. To her dismay, the only thing she saw was her own reflection. The windows of the truck seemed to act like one-way mirrors – one can see outside but not inside.

Her attempt at surveying the vehicle was interrupted by a tap on her shoulder.

She turned around in a hasty motion, driven by the fear of having been spotted by one of the goons, expecting to be greeted by the sight of a gun barrel staring her down. Instead, she saw a woman. A young Japanese-looking lady with a cybernetic eye, dressed in elegant attire that somewhat conveyed a sense of oriental traditionalism combined with modern sleekness. "Sorry to bother," she spoke. "Can I borrow your phone?"

Maria raised an eyebrow, still in alert mode. "Why do you need to borrow my phone?" she asked in response.

"Need to make an urgent phone call. And I lost my own."

She seemed earnest. With a slightly reluctant motion, Maria produced her phone, unlocked it and handed it over, a cy-

bernetic hand extending to retrieve it. The woman nodded gratefully and started tapping, turning around and taking two steps forward when she pressed the phone against her ear.

Josh stared at the screen of his phone for longer than he usually did. An unknown number. He was almost afraid to pick up. It wasn't common for him to receive calls from unknown numbers, save for the occasional telemarketer trying to sell him something he had no interest in and trying to meet their sales quota for the month.

Eventually, though, he picked up. "Josh Heynes, Neo-Tokyo police."

"Great work, officer," echoed an oddly familiar voice at the other end of the line.

The merc woman. "You," Josh muttered. "I thought you said you were busy elsewhere."

"I was. Up until now. Seems you managed to take out the entire crew."

"No thanks to you. Did you deliberately leave out the part about the back entrance?"

"Trust me, if I knew about a back entrance, I *would* have let you know. It's not my fault the intel was inadequate."

Josh wasn't entirely convinced the woman was telling the truth this time. If she knew about the operation, how could she not have known about a back entrance? Or was it part of her

strategy to keep Josh in the dark about some details?

“Anyway, that’s a sizable portion of the gang out of the equation,” the woman said after a moment of silence. “I appreciate the work you’ve done here today. Till next time.”

Josh’s phone beeped in his ear, signifying that she hung up. He shoved it back into his pocket with a particularly slow motion, the realization that Shinji had heard his side of the conversation eating at him. He turned his gaze to him.

In ten years of working with Shinji, Josh had never seen him as shocked as he did now. “You’ve got a fuckton of explaining to do, man,” he mumbled.

“I will in due time,” Josh replied in a conspiratorial tone. “But for now, keep this a secret from the rest of the team. Okay?”

Shinji sighed, clearly wanting to defy Josh’s request and rat him out, but ultimately nodded in agreement.

Martin Stokes’s reaction wasn’t quite as lenient. With a heavy sigh and both of his hands covering his face, he muttered: “Nothing is safe from corruption these days, is it?”

A lot was going through Maria’s head as the mystery woman hung up and handed the phone back to her. She stared at her with a mix of emotions – shock, anger, disgust, a sense of trust betrayed underneath all of it. In that moment, she wished she could turn back time. Say “no” to her request with the foresight

of knowledge as to what this woman was. But what was the exact role she played? At the risk of not receiving any satisfactory answers, she decided she had to try to extract what she could.

“Who the hell *are* you?” she asked the woman.

The grateful smile on her face faded into something more serious, more sinister. “What do you hope to gain by knowing?” came a counterinquiry from her.

Maria had to admit she wasn’t quite sure. But she had to know something specific. “I just wanna know one thing.” She looked into the woman’s eyes with considerably more intensity, hoping not to miss whatever answer lay beneath the cold gaze. “Did you kill Yoshiro Busujima?”

Something flickered in there. A memory. A wordless confession. The two simply stared at each other for a moment, Maria’s slowly drifting elsewhere as the pain of knowledge took over. Now she finally knew, but at what cost? “So you did,” she mumbled.

“You were close to him,” the woman guessed.

“Yeah. He was my father.”

“Sorry for your loss.”

“Are you?” Maria turned her gaze back to the woman, a sense of anger starting to creep back to the surface. But she did her best to keep her composure. “Why did you do it?”

“I just followed orders. It was nothing personal.”

“Whose orders?”

“That’s information you’re better off not knowing. I’d

only be making things worse for you if I told you.”

“You made things bad enough for me when you killed my father.” The facade of calmness Maria was putting on was starting to crack.

“What do you want me to do? Hop into a time machine and kill my boss instead? I didn’t know who I was killing that day. And you’re not the first or last person to lose a family member in such a way.”

Wow. Way to trivialize my pain, bitch. Maria was red with rage. She screamed and raised an arm, beginning to swing it towards the woman in order to slap her, but she was quicker. Her cybernetic hand came up and grabbed Maria’s wrist an inch short of her cheek.

They simply stood in that position for a moment. Maria was breathing heavily, tears rolling down her cheeks. “Look...” the murderer began. “I truly am sorry about your father. I have my fair share of regrets. But your anger would be better directed at the man who actually ordered the hit on him.”

“Then why won’t you give me a name?”

“For your safety. Besides, this isn’t your fight. This is as much closure as you’re going to get.”

“I think I have the right to decide when I’ve gotten my closure. And it won’t be until I get my revenge.”

The woman laughed softly. “Sweetheart, my fate is already sealed. If you want revenge, you can consider it received when I’m behind bars. Either that or just accept that you’ll never get it in the first place. Those are your two options.” Then

the woman released her grip from Maria's wrist and dashed off, nowhere to be seen a mere two seconds later.

Maria dropped her arm and let herself fall backward, her back slamming against the side of the truck, left to ponder the words that the woman who killed her father had spoken. Maybe this *was* as much closure as she was going to get.

In lieu of Jenn being able to do her part for the investigation on account of her being hospitalized, Josh had elected to take over her assignments, chief among which was the background check on Miss Harady. Back at DanariTek, while the rest of his team was ensuring the safety of the facility's employees, Josh had taken it upon himself to talk to Stokes about how Miss Harady, a former prostitute who'd stabbed Harashima twice, had ended up working at one of the latter's companies. According to Stokes, Miss Harady had simply walked into the building about six months ago, asking to talk to the head of HR – in other words, Stokes himself – and practically waving her CV in his face in a plea for him to hire her. Which, given how impressive her credentials had seemed at the time, he did without the smallest shred of hesitation.

Josh, of course, asked Stokes for a copy of her CV, and the man obliged. He may have been a corporate asshole, but at least he knew better than to fight the law when it came to investigative matters. And immediately upon first glance, Josh noted several inconsistencies that set his alarm bells ringing. For one thing, the CV Miss Harady had submitted to Stokes made no mention whatsoever of her prostitution stint. Nor did the time-

line of her “cybernetics studies” seem fully believable. That alone was enough to tell Josh that her credentials were falsified. He pointed the inconsistencies out to Stokes and cursed him for not having been more vigilant, and the only defense Stokes was able to produce was that her credentials seemed so impressive he couldn’t not hire her. Josh seemed to recall that the phrase Stokes had used to describe Miss Harady’s CV was “too good to be true” – only that had apparently been the case in a purely figurative sense.

And now, back at the Office of Legal and Military Operations, he felt reinvigorated following the discovery. *This* was the puzzle piece that had been missing for so long, and thanks to it having been found, the case felt like it was finally progressing again. In a way, he was thankful to the murderer for having given him the hint about the kidnapping op at DanariTek – he wasn’t sure if he would ever have realized to return to the facility and question the head of HR about Miss Harady himself had the murderer not led him back there.

And he knew what to do about Miss Harady. He’d called her nurse to let her know that he wanted to have a word with her. It was kind of a good thing that Jenn was presently incapacitated, as much as Josh hated to think of it that way. But had she been in Josh’s shoes right now, the foundation of empathy Jenn had previously established with Miss Harady might have interfered with what was coming up. What needed to be done.

You’re in a world of trouble, kid, Josh thought to himself as if he was already having the conversation with Miss

Harady as he strolled down the corridor where room 265 of the infirmary was located.

“Alright, Miss Harady,” the nurse’s soothing voice sounded. Enez had just had a change of bandages, and the wound in her stomach had healed enough that it no longer looked like it’d reopen and her guts would spill out if she tried to walk. Her smile was the widest it had been in quite a while. Anticipation permeated the air in her “hotel” room. Would they finally let her out or insist on keeping her in the infirmary for longer still? She hoped for the former.

The nurse pulled the mask off her mouth and continued: “The wound looks to have healed enough to exhibit no risk of reopening. I’m thinking you can be discharged.”

Enez brought a triumphant fist in the air and squealed in excitement. Finally, she’d be able to go home. “Best news I’ve heard all week.”

The nurse chuckled. “Glad you’re excited. That said, I do want to advise you to keep the bandages on for at least two more days. Just as a safety measure.”

“Understood. Thank you, nurse.”

“Anytime.” The nurse spun her chair around and started tapping at her holocomp. “Give me just a couple of minutes to fill out the paperwork. There’s somebody here who wants to talk to you in the meantime.”

“If it’s that bitch Officer Walters again, tell her—”

“Not her. Not this time.”

A look of confusion spread across Enez’s face. Then the sound of the door sliding open echoed. She stared at the face that entered intently, feeling more intimidated the closer it got.

Officer Heynes. This couldn’t be good.

“Sorry to ruin your excitement,” he said in a tone that didn’t sound apologetic at all to Enez’s ear. “But you won’t be going home from here. We’re moving you into prison.”

Enez laid a hand of disappointment over her face. “Oh, fuck me,” she muttered. She slid her hand across her face, stretching the skin with her fingers, then turned a gaze of frustration to Officer Heynes. “Well, what are you charging me with?”

“Forgery, sabotage and assisting in a murder.”

Enez chuckled, half amused, half frustrated. “So you finally figured it out, huh?”

“This is serious, Miss Harady. You went into DanariTek with faked credentials, produced a faulty prosthetic and sabotaged its installation. Didn’t you?”

“That’s only one part of the truth.” Enez sat up on the bed, growing more agitated by the second. “I didn’t work on my own. Somebody planted me in there. And you’re not gonna like who it was.”

“Who was it then?”

“One of your own. The middle-aged Japanese-looking guy. Likes to wear sunglasses indoors.”

Officer Heynes’s expression changed. Softened. “You

mean Koji?”

“If that’s his name, then yeah.”

The officer’s gaze drifted off to the side. He looked vindicated. He was quiet for what felt like an eternity, evidently pondering Enez’s revelation. When he turned his attention back to her, his expression was considerably less authoritative. But the next time he talked, he still did so from a procedural perspective. “You do realize that still makes you an accomplice?”

“Yeah, I understand as much. I’m just saying you have a black sheep in your ranks. Go ahead and arrest me, but you owe me thanks at the very least.”

Officer Heynes brought a finger up to his chin. Contemplated something. Maybe a plan. Enez thought she could see the exact moment a lightbulb went off in his head from the way his eyes twinkled. “Okay,” he muttered. “You’re lucky I’ve been harboring my own suspicions about Koji for a while.”

“Uh-huh,” Enez muttered conspiratorially, adjusting herself to the officer’s wavelength. “So what are you thinking?”

A throat clear pierced through the rising tension. Enez looked to her left, greeted by the sight of the nurse looking at the two of them with trepidation. As if she knew she shouldn’t be listening to the exchange. “Paperwork’s done. You’re free to go,” she spoke, then continued as she stood up and prepared to exit the room, as if she was in on the conspiracy: “Also, I won’t tell anyone about this.”

“Thank you,” Enez and Officer Heynes whispered in unison, staying quiet until the nurse was out of the room and the

door was firmly closed.

Officer Heynes stared at the door for a moment, as if attempting to lock it by means of telepathy, then turned his attention back to Enez and asked: “Know how to pick a lock?”

Enez raised an eyebrow. “Depends on the type of lock.”

“Electronic. Keycode-protected.”

Enez hunched over and placed a finger on her chin. “Two ways to crack one of those. Break the encryption and force a keycode change or short-circuit the main PCB.” She turned an inquisitive gaze to Heynes. “But I don’t suppose you can sneak in a screwdriver.”

“’Fraid not. So you’d have to improvise.”

Enez nodded. “I can figure something out.” The look she gave Heynes grew more intense by the second. “Question is, how do you intend to expose him while I’m breaking out of prison?”

“That’s gonna be the tricky part. Need to figure out some way to rat him out in his immediate vicinity.”

“And make sure he comes after me?”

Heynes nodded. Now his motions looked a lot more apologetic. “Sorry to put you in harm’s way like that. But that’s the best plan I can come up with.”

“Better than anything I could come up with.”

A chuckle escaped Officer Heynes. Enez never thought she’d hear anything akin to one coming out of him. She looked at him with a hint of surprise. “What?” he inquired.

“Just didn’t think I’d ever hear you chuckle.”

“I may be a police officer, but I’m not humorless.”

“Right, sorry,” Enez said, throwing her arms up in mock surrender. “Clearly I had the wrong impression of you.”

“Feeling’s mutual,” he replied with the subtlest hint of humor in his tone, then brought out the handcuffs Enez was half-expecting to already be around her wrists. “Ready to work your magic?”

Enez hopped off the bed onto her feet, turned around and crossed her wrists behind her back. “I am if you are.”

“Alright. I just hope this works,” Officer Heynes mumbled as he clasped the handcuffs around Enez’s wrists.

30

Within only a few minutes, Officer Heynes and Enez were on the prison floor of the building, with Enez being escorted to what would be her prison cell for maybe half an hour at most. Now that it occurred to her, she hadn't realized to ask the officer how long her prison sentence was supposed to be. Six months? Six years? Could have been anywhere between. And now would be an awkward time to ask for that clarification.

The two of them came up to what amounted to a reception desk, with a thoroughly bored-looking guard sitting behind it. But he seemed to light up considerably upon laying his eyes on Enez. "Quite a catch you're bringing in today, Mister Heynes," he blurted out.

Enez's eyes widened. "Excuse you," she hollered. "That is very inappropriate coming from a prison guard."

The guard didn't seem interested in acknowledging her comment or apologizing. "Welcome to the real world, honey," he muttered in response.

"Who's your boss? I wanna have a chat with him before I get locked in."

"'Fraid you're out of luck. He's on vacation."

"Then give me his phone number."

“Alright, let’s calm down,” Officer Heynes butted in. As much as she hated it, Enez had to admit he had a point. No use causing a scene here. She let her gaze drift to the floor and sighed in frustration.

The guard was more composed in his reaction, as if he was used to getting away with being a sexist pig. He continued in an official-sounding tone: “Well, anyway, case number?”

Officer Heynes recited it like a machine. “JH-912893.”

The guard tapped on a holographic keyboard for a moment, evidently looking for the information in question, then spoke when he found it. “Ah, yep, there it is. Enez Harady, 23 years old, charged with forgery, sabotage and playing assistant in a murder. Warranted for arrest.” He looked Enez over, as if appraising her, then asked Officer Heynes: “You good with letting me escort her to her cell?”

Yeah, right. I’m not going anywhere with you, asshole.

“Probably best if I take her.” A point that Enez could not argue against.

Neither could the guard, judging by how he simply put his hands up in the air and then motioned for Officer Heynes to go ahead and escort Enez into her cell. The handcuffs fell off Enez’s wrist as she stepped into her cubicle.

Before locking Enez in her cell, he muttered a set of instructions to her: “Don’t start moving as soon as I lock the door. Give me at least ten minutes to get my own gears turning. Once you’re out, head for the emergency exit and take the stairs down to ground floor.”

Enez nodded and recited: “Ten minutes, emergency exit, ground floor. Got it.”

Producing a confirmatory nod of his own, Officer Heynes – or Josh, now that Enez remembered his first name – locked the cell door and said: “Good luck.”

“Likewise,” she replied as the officer took his leave.

She scanned every inch of the prison cell with her eyes, taking account of the furniture and tiniest details therein, anything that would help her break out and put her part of the plan in motion. She had plenty of time to figure it out.

Her eyes happened upon a security camera in the corner. She smiled and waved to it. For a second, she wondered if she could climb up and rip it off the wall, but the thing was too high for her to reach it even if she jumped. And the dull, white walls had no convenient crevices to use as handholds.

She studied the lock for a moment, then moved on to study the bed. It looked old-fashioned with its metallic tube framing, but that was where the impression of antiquity stopped – it had no rust on it. She crouched down and looked at the legs, gripping one with her hand and jiggling it ever so slightly to find out if the bed was bolted down to the floor. The way the bed moved and creaked with her hand movements told her it wasn’t. She was starting to come up with an idea.

She looked at her other hand – her cybernetic hand. *Yeah. That’s going to work. Just need to wait for Josh. Is it okay to call him by his first name?*

She heard footsteps in the corridor. She quickly stood

back up and put her hands behind her back, doing her best to look inconspicuous as a guard – a different one – came up to her cell. The guard stared at her for a moment, grunting and returning to his position shortly.

Enez sat down on the bed for what she figured was about ten minutes, then stood up again and steeled her nerves. It was time to work her magic. She crouched down by the bed and grabbed one of its legs, hoping that whoever was in charge of keeping an eye on the camera feeds had fallen asleep.

She lifted the bed leg and placed her other hand under it. *Can't believe I'm doing this. It's okay, though. It's a cybernetic finger. Breaking it off isn't going to hurt.*

Convincing herself so didn't ease the pain as she slammed the bed leg down and broke one of her cybernetic fingers off. But she managed to keep herself from screaming.

Then she moved over to the lock, peeling off a piece of the shielding of the detached finger and using it as an improvised screwdriver with which she unscrewed the PCB cover. *For what's supposed to be a highly guarded, high-tech prison, these locks sure are easy to fiddle with.*

She heard footsteps again. Guards coming over to check on her, no doubt. If she wanted to get out, she needed to do it fast. Panic slowly took over as she did her best to peel off some of the wiring in the broken-off finger. She quickly concluded she didn't have enough time.

With a hasty motion, she smacked the exposed ends of the electrical cables in her severed finger into the main PCB of

the lock. To her surprise, it worked. The lock shut down with a hiss, emitting a puff of smoke from the short-circuited PCB and letting the prison cell door swing open.

Enez dashed out of the cell and scanned her surroundings quickly, trying to find a sign that'd tell her which way the emergency exit was. When she did, she wasted no time setting foot towards her next objective.

“Freeze!” echoed the shouts of the guards behind her.

31

Jenn and Devin were standing in a hallway, one side of which was lined with office doors. Devin held a cardboard cup filled to the brim with coffee in his hand, while Jenn had elected to keep her hands free of anything to hold. Devin took a sip of the poison and then asked Jenn: “How are you holding up?”

“Surprisingly well,” Jenn replied. She struggled to remember anything about what had happened to her that one day. The day her neural link was hacked, if what the doctors had told her was to be believed. Who had done so and why? She’d never know, in all likelihood. All she remembered was waking up in the infirmary and the headache that had been hammering her skull. And the smell of vomit as she spilled out whatever she could to get better.

“No nausea anymore?”

“Not notably. Just the occasional minor headache still.”

“Glad you’re getting better.”

“So am I.” But something was still gnawing on Jenn’s mind. A peculiar error that the nurse found in her neural logs. Normally, an error message would show diagnostic data to determine what exactly had happened to cause a neural shutdown. But the one the nurse had found – logged on the day of the

incident – had displayed nothing. Nothing usable at any rate. Apparently the error data had been scrambled, and even trying to decrypt it had turned out to be a useless endeavor. As if the error message had been corrupted, which did happen sometimes, albeit rarely. But something about that specific error message gave the nurse the impression the corruption in that case was intentional, not random. That might have also explained why Jenn couldn't remember anything about that day.

Evidently Devin could see all of those thoughts running through her head. "Scary, isn't it?" he commented. "The idea of a self-corrupting error message in the neural logs."

"Yeah. I didn't even think that was possible."

"Me neither. Whoever hacked your neural link must've been using some really advanced tech. The kind I don't think even we have access to."

"Definitely not something a civilian should be able to get their hands on. Whoever's responsible has connections to the big leagues." And that thought was exactly what scared Jenn the most.

"That much is evident." Then Devin took another sip of his coffee and continued: "Anyway, I'm off to work. Got some paperwork needs filing." He gave Jenn a quick pat on the shoulder and said to her as he turned on his heels: "Stay on your feet."

"I'll do my best," Jenn hollered to him as she watched him disappear behind a corner. An odd sense of emptiness, lack of direction, filled her for a moment.

Until she heard a voice calling her. Josh's voice. She turned her gaze to his general direction, where he was motioning for her to come over. She obliged.

"What's up?" Jenn inquired when she was an arm's length away from him.

"Update to Miss Harady's testimony," Josh replied. "She did confess, but she also said she didn't work alone in infiltrating DanariTek. That she was a plant."

Jenn nodded. "I did suspect as much myself. She doesn't seem the type to perform intentional malpractice."

"Intentional or not, it's a crime with a prison sentence as standard punishment."

Jenn chuckled in response. "Ever the enforcer, aren't you?" Then she turned slightly more serious. "Did she ID the planter?"

"Yeah. Apparently it was Koji."

A look of shock wrote itself onto Jenn's face. Then she looked around herself. It wasn't until doing so that she realized where exactly in the hallway they were standing. "And you really thought it was a good idea to say that right in front of Koji's office door?!" she hollered.

Josh looked to his side, as if only now taking account of his surroundings, and muttered the simplest, most shocking response of all: "Oops."

"You're making a serious accusation about a fellow officer and all you can think to say is 'oops'?!" Jenn tried and failed to keep her voice at a reasonable level. She hoped Koji

was anywhere else than in his office – the walls in this part of the police department floor weren't exactly soundproof.

“Just didn't realize where I was standing.”

“Yes, you did. Don't try to pretend otherwise.” Jenn was trying her damndest to figure out what Josh was trying to do but came up with no idea. She sighed. “But if Miss Harady says it was Koji, then that means another internal investigation.” A thought occurred to her. Maybe if she suggested a meeting, Josh would gain back some of his pragmatism. So she did. “Should we have a meeting to discuss this with the team?”

“No. Keep it a secret from the team.”

Now *that* if anything was a shock to Jenn's system. Josh never requested her to keep secrets.

“What's going on, Josh?” Jenn asked with an air of impatience. “You haven't been like yourself at all lately. First you forget to call Momoko – which I don't buy in the slightest, by the way – then you cancel team meetings indefinitely, and now you want me to keep a *secret*? What happened to make you act like this?”

Josh stared at Jenn like she had sniffed him out. Something in the way his gaze shifted told her she was right. That there was something Josh had been hiding for the past week or so. And Jenn was going to find out what it was, collegial trust be damned.

After a moment of silence, Josh sighed in a manner that suggested he was about to drop a considerable weight off his shoulders. “Alright, you caught me,” he began. “Remember the

night the main elevator broke down?”

“Yeah. What about it?”

“I didn’t tell you the full story. I—”

An announcement from the loudspeaker above interrupted Josh. “Attention, all units, we have a prisoner escaping,” it sounded. “I repeat, we have a prisoner escaping. ID: Enez Harady. Last seen heading for the emergency exit on floor 19. Orders are to retrieve and redetain.”

Josh groaned. “Can nothing about this case be simple?”

Jenn looked at him intently. She thought she recognized a hint of pride in his expression. As if he had planned something with Enez. But she chose to ignore it for now. “You’ll have time to complain later,” she hollered, already taking a tentative first step. “Let’s go get her.”

Without another word, Josh set off running behind Jenn, who was already halfway down the corridor.

“Out the way,” sounded the agitated voice of another officer behind the two of them, and in the next moment, Koji breezed past them, looking particularly angry... and with his gun out.

That alone told Jenn a lot. Maybe too much. The orders were simply to recapture Enez. Use of force hadn’t been permitted, let alone firearms. The pieces were starting to fall into place in Jenn’s head. Josh had been right to be suspicious of him.

She stopped running and turned on her heels, making Josh almost bump into her. He managed to stop a step short. The two of them exchanged a look of acknowledgement, then

Josh signaled the next destination: the main elevator. Jenn nodded, and they started running again.

They ran past Shinji, who tried to interrupt them: “Emergency exit isn’t that—”

“We know,” Jenn and Josh hollered back in unison. In the next few moments, they were in the main elevator, then in the garage, then in a hovercar.

“I told you Koji was up to no good,” Josh growled to Jenn as he drove out of the garage. “Were you not listening?”

“Okay, okay!” Jenn yelled back, her arms up in the air. “Sorry I doubted you.”

“You’ll have time to apologize later.” Josh almost sounded apologetic himself for no discernible reason. “Right now, we gotta catch him before he catches Miss Harady.”

“Yeah.” The tone of Jenn’s voice still carried shreds of regret for having broken Enez’s trust. “And we gotta be quick. He’s already—”

A thud on the roof of the hovercar interrupted Jenn.

“The fuck was that?” she hollered while glancing at the ceiling. Her inquiry was followed by a knock on the driver’s side window.

The face of the murderer greeted them both beyond it. But her smile didn’t look sinister. Quite the opposite, in fact, almost warm. Jenn wasn’t quite sure what to make of it. The woman brought a hand up and motioned it so as to tell Josh to roll the window down.

He did.

“Howdy, partner,” she hollered primarily to Josh. *I’m sorry, what?!* Jenn screamed internally. She couldn’t tell what was going on anymore. It felt like everything she knew had been a carefully curated lie. Like even Josh’s honesty had become a currency she was short on. *You’d better have a damn good explanation for this, Josh.*

Jenn shot the deadliest glare she felt capable of producing at him. “What’s our main suspect doing hanging off the side of our car, Josh?”

“Let the lady explain herself,” he replied with conviction. Then he addressed said lady: “This better be important.”

“It is important,” she replied. “I’m going to need you to stay back.”

“Stay back?!” Jenn could tell Josh didn’t like the implications of the woman’s request. “For what reason?”

“Look, there’s only one way to finish this. And it’s *my* way. Koji’s too dangerous to be kept alive. You won’t fix him by having him brought to justice.”

“You saying you’re gonna kill him?!”

“Unfortunately, yes. I *have* to.”

“That wasn’t what you said to me in the elevator.” *The elevator?* A lightbulb went off in Jenn’s head.

“I said to leave taking care of the boss to me, didn’t I?” The woman’s expression was riddled with growing annoyance. “Your part is handling the cleanup. Those were the terms I laid out.”

Jenn felt the need to pipe in at that point. “So *that’s* what

you weren't telling us," she hollered to Josh in shock.

"Not like me. I know," Josh replied defensively. "But my hand was forced."

"Nah, I get it. I just didn't think you'd strike a deal with our *main suspect*."

"Didn't know who she was until it'd already been made. And you know I don't back down on deals."

"Yeah," Jenn sighed, half amused, half annoyed.

Josh turned his attention back to the murderer and said to her: "Alright, we'll hold off. You deal with Koji, I arrest you afterwards. That was the deal, right?"

"That it was." Then the woman climbed back onto the roof of the car.

A chuckle escaped Jenn as Josh rolled the window back up. "Working this case has really brought out new sides in you," she commented.

"Surprised?"

"I am, can't lie." She looked at Josh with an expression that was in the perfect middle ground between humor and seriousness and continued: "Just don't be surprised if I report you to the CEO after we're done."

"You won't."

"Try me."

32

The emergency exit door was straight ahead. Enez ran a quick calculation through her head, trying to determine how long it would take the guards chasing her down to catch her. How long she had to open doors in case they weren't automatic. The sounds of footsteps behind her weren't getting any quieter. And the door ahead looked like it wasn't automatic.

No time to stop and open the door normally. She hugged her torso with one arm, locked it in place with the other and braced for impact. *This is going to hurt.*

She almost thought she dislocated her shoulder as she collided with the door. She almost staggered, but she knew she couldn't slow down no matter how much it hurt. The door swung open, granting her entrance into the emergency staircase. She didn't even stop to take account of which direction would take her downwards – intuition alone guided her. Would she trip on a stair or miss a step and fall over? The answer to that question was how she'd know where she was going.

It didn't take her long to get a tingling sensation in her abdomen. To feel like she was about to fall over, as if the ground was failing beneath her feet. But she adjusted quickly and regained her footing. Managed to keep herself from plant-

ing face-first onto the floor.

She didn't stop to take account of any new threats that might be lurking in the stairway. She simply ran for her life.

The first major obstacle didn't present itself until she was about halfway down. A pair of security guards with what looked like taser guns at a quick glance, primed to fire. "Freeze!" they growled, but Enez had no interest in stopping to listen. What kind of plan could she come up with to get past them in about half a second?

The one she came up with was dangerous, possibly fatal, but it was also the only one she figured wouldn't thwart her escape. She grabbed the railing and jumped over it, hearing the sounds of the guards' taser guns just missing her as she let go and started falling.

While she was accelerating downwards with more speed than simply running down the stairs could have afforded her, she realized that the impact would break her legs unless she figured out a way to slow herself down.

She flailed with her four-fingered cybernetic hand at the railings passing her by at the relative speed of a bullet train. But she was falling too fast. She failed to get a firm enough grip... until the very last chance, one floor off the ground.

She screamed as she came to a sudden stop, looking down as she dangled from the railing no more than fifteen feet above the ground. She couldn't believe how close she was to becoming a wheelchair patient or, worse yet, a puddle of blood and guts. She sighed in relief and released her grip, falling down

the rest of the way onto her feet, relatively unharmed. A grunt escaped her as she came into contact with the floor.

She did a quick scan of her surroundings. Two doors on either side of her. One promised salvation, the other re-detainment. She looked up in an attempt to determine which was which based on the orientation of the stairway.

More footsteps echoed up above. She needed to make a choice quickly if she wanted to escape being imprisoned again.

She made a dash towards one door, bracing for impact again and hoping her intuition was right.

It turned out it was. Fresh air and sunlight greeted her as she rammed her way through the final door. She came out to what looked like a parking lot. She would have liked to stop and catch her breath, but she was almost certainly still being pursued. She had to get to safety. So she kept running.

Enez barely made it halfway across when a sudden, sharp pain shot up the back of her leg. Something hit her there. A bullet, judging by the sensation. She began to fall face-first toward the ground, almost breaking her wrist in an attempt to break the fall.

Carefully, she turned her head back, curious to see who had shot her. She saw a masculine figure approaching, clad in attire that immediately told Enez it was a police officer, even from this distance. But why would the police prevent her from escaping, let alone by shooting her in the leg? Unless...

In only a few more seconds, the shooter had caught up to her, staring her down with the barrel of his gun. It was the bad

cop, the worst of them all. Solid black sunglasses covered his eyes, preventing Enez from fully deciphering his expression. But it was hostile. She was in panic mode, but she did her best to keep her breathing steady.

“You disappoint me, Miss Harady,” the man spoke. He looked ready to pull the trigger at any moment. “All you had to do was keep your mouth shut. But now, thanks to you, everything I’ve done is going to come to light. You’ve compromised my position.”

“You compromised your own position, asshole,” Enez grunted, feeling her defiance returning ever so slowly. “Your colleagues were gonna catch on to you eventually.”

The man turned his head to the side. “Hmm. Maybe you’re right.” Then he returned his gaze to Enez, glaring at her more intensely. He was getting ready to shoot. “Either way, I can’t afford any more risks. Didn’t want to have to do this myself, but I’m out of options.”

Enez closed her eyes.

But she didn’t hear the gunshot she expected. Instead, she heard a scream.

She opened her eyes to the sight of the man’s hand having been detached from his arm. She looked at the ground. His severed hand lay there, still gripping the gun. She looked back up. The vague shape of another figure caught her eye for a second, then it dashed behind him.

A blade punctured the man’s chest. A few drops of his blood fell on Enez’s face. She blinked in shock.

A feminine hand laid itself on his head, turned it sideways, then another face appeared next to his. Female. Elegant. Its lips landed on the man's neck.

"Nyx...?" the man mumbled in surprise while gurgling blood. "Why?"

"You know why," the woman muttered in response. "You wrote your own death sentence when you ordered a hit on a witness."

"But I trusted you. I—"

"Trust is a volatile currency, my love. And you lost mine ages ago." Then the woman released the blade, letting the man fall to the ground. He almost fell over Enez. She scrambled back instinctively. "Rest in peace," the woman said in an emotionless farewell.

Enez let her gaze wander over the full figure of her savior. The tatters in her dress let Enez get a full picture of it. The body was half cybernetics. Right arm. Both legs. Left eye. Her face felt familiar.

Then it hit Enez. She clasped a hand over her mouth when she realized who she was looking at. A tear escaped her eye. "...Nichiho?!"

"Not my name anymore," the woman replied with an odd warmth that confirmed Enez's suspicion. "Call me Nyx."

"I thought you were dead," Enez whimpered, wholly unable to contain her shock.

"So did I." Nichiho – no, Nyx – brought her cybernetic arm forward, turning her hand over several times while looking

at it, as if surprised she was alive. “Not sure how I’m still here. Harashima did a number on me.”

“I can tell.” Enez looked Nyx up and down again, half grateful to see an old friend, half admiring the craftsmanship of the mechanical parts of her body. “Glad you are, though.”

Nyx smiled compassionately and began to extend her arm, but it was quickly yanked behind her back. The other arm followed shortly.

A male figure appeared behind Nyx. He made no attempt to hide himself. Officer Heynes. Or Josh. He spoke in an oddly patient tone, as if he had been waiting for his turn: “You’re under arrest for multiple murders, including that of a police officer.”

“We’re having a sentimental reunion. Can this not wait?” Nyx asked humorously in response.

“No. I’ve waited long enough.” Josh laid a hand on Nyx’s shoulder, brought his face closer to hers and muttered: “I held up my end of the deal. Time for you to hold up yours.”

Enez’s eyebrows shot skyward. “You worked with them?!” she hollered to Nyx in shock.

“Long story,” she replied apologetically. “I’ll tell you some other time.”

Growing more impatient by the second, Josh yanked on Nyx’s shoulder and commanded her: “Alright, come on.” And with that, they started walking away, leaving Enez to ponder the final revelation.

So it *was* Koji. Josh felt vindicated that his suspicions had been confirmed. His only regret was that he wouldn't be able to deal his own version of justice. He would have preferred to keep Koji alive, report his crimes to the CEO, have him discharged from the police force. Then again, the CEO was Koji's father, so maybe Koji would have found a way to defend himself against him and avoid the repercussions. Maybe things were better this way. Maybe this mysterious assassin had done the police a favor by killing him.

But Josh still felt uneasy. This wasn't how he imagined things turning out. Not how he *wanted* them to turn out. There had been enough collateral damage, and Koji was little more than the latest addition to the roster. How would Josh break the news to Takeshi that his son had lied to them? Covered up an underground crime circle he ran so successfully for so long? And, most importantly, that he was now dead?

Those were the questions he pondered as he walked back to the police car with Harashima's murderer finally in handcuffs. The expression on Jenn's face was riddled with conflict as it came into view.

"So... We're finally finished, huh?" she asked.

"Finished in one way," Josh mumbled with uncertainty. "Only getting started in another."

"What about Enez?"

Josh turned his head and looked behind him. Miss

Harady was sitting on the ground a few hundred feet away, her head between her knees, shuddering. Clearly overwhelmed by everything that had happened to and around her. *Poor kid.*

Turning his gaze back to Jenn, Josh muttered with more compassion than he thought himself capable of: “Consider her free. She’s been through enough.”

Jenn cracked a half-smile and nodded, as if to say “I knew you could be kind”. Then Josh guided the assassin to the backseat and closed the door, taking one of the front seats himself and sighing heavily as he did so. This investigation had certainly worked him to the bone. And he still wasn’t sure if they were quite done with it.

But once they were, he was going to need a very long vacation.

33

So this is it. The cycle is finally broken. The killing has stopped. Koji is dead. Harashima's legacy stays untainted. For now, at least. And at the end of it all, I still end up in prison. Probably for the rest of my natural life. Was it worth it? Did justice ultimately prevail? Did I play smart by striking a deal with the police? Did I redeem myself?

A lot was running through Nyx's mind. She hadn't had a lot of time to ponder the consequences of her actions while she was still caught up in the whirlwind, and now that it was quiet, the uncertainty ate at her conscience. Much of what she had done ultimately amounted to playing along with Koji, but the price she'd end up paying by having done so was still being calculated. She wished she had definitive answers to the questions she was asking herself. But she knew they would likely be left unanswered.

They drove into the garage of the Office of Legal and Military Operations. *What is truth?*

They exited the vehicle. *What is justice?*

They started walking towards an elevator, keeping a hand per officer on each of Nyx's shoulders. *What is morality?*

They started ascending. *Who gets to define them?*

They guided her into an interrogation room and sat her down. *Who gets to decide what happens when truths collide?*

“Please state your name for the record,” echoed the voice of Officer Heynes. Nyx lifted her gaze, snapping back to reality. This was it.

“Nyx Hatara.” A fake name. A ghost. A zombie. A reconstruction of her old self under a new identity. There would be a match for her DNA, but the name they would find was...

“Nichiho Amano.” But that wasn’t her anymore. “Announced legally dead two years ago.” *Yet a part of her is still physically here.* He looked her over. “Some impressive cybernetics you’re sporting. Who gave you all that?”

“A private cybersurgeon. Anonymous, deceased. Contracted by one of your own, Koji Hodo.”

The officers tensed up. Koji’s threads ran deep. He had connections to a lot of underground operators – some legal, most not. But the interrogation had to continue. “And what was your relationship to Koji?”

“He was my boss. Ran an underground crime operation while masquerading as a police officer.”

“And what was your role in said operation?”

“I carried out the murders.”

“How many?”

“Five. Two of them connected to your case. Names of the victims are Yoshiro Busujima and Yosuke Harashima. More were supposed to follow, but I defected.”

“Why?”

“Koji gave me the impression the hits he ordered would be strictly political. And yet, it only took until the sixth one for a discrepancy to appear. It became clear to me right away that his strategy had shifted from political culling to silencing witnesses.”

“Why did he want Busujima and Harashima dead?”

“I won’t pretend to know exactly. He never gave me the details. I just had to follow his orders.”

“And yet you decided not to when he gave you the name of the sixth target.”

“Exactly.”

“Who was it supposed to be?”

Nyx shuddered and looked down. Doing her best to keep her voice steady, she croaked: “Enez Harady.” As soon as Koji had given her the name, she knew she couldn’t carry out the murder. That was when Nyx hit the fast-forward button on her own plans. Koji was too dangerous at that point.

“You say her name like you were close.”

Nyx hesitated to answer. But she forced one out. “We were. In a previous life.” *In a very literal sense.*

“And that was when you decided to defect?”

“Yes.”

“Do you know Koji’s current status?”

Of course she did. “Dead. Killed by me.”

Officer Heynes grabbed a portable apparatus of some kind and swung it in front of Nyx. A lie detector, if she had to guess. The machine pondered for a second, two, three, then it

chirped and produced a faint, green light. The officers nodded and exchanged a quick glance. Did that mean they had enough? Nyx hoped so. The weight on her shoulders wasn't getting any lighter. Not until Officer Heynes spoke again. "Thank you, Miss Amano."

"Hatara," she corrected instinctively.

He nodded apologetically. "Thank you, Miss Hatara. We'll call it here." Then he tapped the Record button on his wrist comm to stop recording. The interrogation was over.

A deafening silence permeated the space for a moment. Officer Walters broke it by asking Heynes: "You gonna send this to Takeshi?"

"Yeah," he replied. "He deserves to know what his son was doing behind our backs. Too bad Koji won't be there to suffer the consequences."

"What about me?" Nyx asked half-sarcastically, directing their attention back to herself.

"The repentance team will decide your fate. But prison for life is looking pretty likely."

Two weeks had passed since Nyx's sentence had been decided upon. Since she had been locked up in prison. For life, as Officer Heynes had predicted. As she herself had predicted. In lack of anything better to do, she had settled into pondering the questions that had been running through her mind when she was

being taken in, still looking for answers to them but not coming up with any. But a new one had also presented itself since then: *What am I?*

What *was* she? Where did she land morally? Could she justify what she had done? In some ways, yes – in others, no. Whichever the answer was on a case-by-case basis, the one thing she could convince herself she'd done right was killing Koji. Even if she was now rotting in prison for having done so. Among other things. *What is morality? Who gets to define it? Do I have the agency to decide for myself which side I'm on?*

"Miss Hatara," echoed the voice of a guard in Japanese. She lifted her gaze from the floor. "You have a visitor," the guard continued, stepping aside and allowing another figure to emerge from behind the corner.

It was Enez. No worse for the wear two weeks later, save for a bandage wrapped around her previously bullet-wounded leg. "Hi," she greeted Nyx in a cheerful half-whisper.

"Long time no see," Nyx replied with a hint of humor in her tone.

Enez's smile widened for a second. She let out a chuckle. Then her expression got more serious. "Sorry you had to end up in there."

"Don't be. I knew the price I'd be paying."

Enez nodded, the motion accompanied by a heavy sigh. "I just wish things could've turned out different. *Wished* they could have three years ago. That I'd done what I could to stop what happened to you from happening."

“What happened to me wasn’t your fault, Enez. It was Harashima’s.”

“I know. But still, I—”

“Hush.” Nyx brought a finger up and placed it in front of her lips. Then she stood up and walked up to Enez, slipping a hand through the bars and taking Enez’s. “I survived, didn’t I? That’s ultimately what matters. And I’m glad you did too.”

“Had you appeared a second later, I’m not so sure I would have.” Nyx could sense the fear Enez had felt in the moment. Was still feeling in some way. Her breathing was shaky. And yet, she smiled, thankful that Nyx had come to her rescue.

Something else was on Enez’s mind. Nyx could tell. But she stayed quiet. She didn’t want to push Enez into saying anything she didn’t feel comfortable saying. Though maybe Enez sensed as much, as she went on after a moment of silence: “The case is still open. They want me to bring in the evidence.”

“The cops?”

“Yeah.”

“Are you going to?”

Enez sighed again. “Still debating. There’s a lot on the line even without stacking it on top. I do feel like they *should* know the truth, but at the same time...” She paused, pondering the consequences. “I don’t know. What do you think?”

“Don’t ask me for my opinion. Do what feels right.”

“I don’t know *what* feels right, though. That’s the problem.”

“Listen to your heart. The answer will come to you.

Might take some time, but just trust yourself.”

Enez smiled subtly. That told Nyx enough. She trusted that whatever Enez decided to do with the evidence she had about Harashima’s secret activities, she’d do it because it felt like the right choice. Even if it meant collapsing an industry or two. Enez stared into Nyx’s eyes a little more intensely, as if she was trying to look directly into her soul, and said: “Thanks. Twice over.”

“Anytime, darling,” Nyx replied, brushing the back of Enez’s palm with her cybernetic thumb and then releasing her grip. Their arms fell in an almost synchronized motion.

“Now go,” Nyx commanded Enez playfully. “Do what must be done.”

“Yes, mum,” Enez replied sarcastically and walked away, leaving an invisible trail of guilt in her wake.

34

The Harashima case was finally closed. Miss Harady had decided to share the evidence she had condemning the dead CEO with the police. They had taken their time to process everything they'd seen therein. Decided to keep it confidential. To protect public interest. Throwing that particular wrench into the gears of society would have done irreparable damage on a global level. Caused walkouts. Riots. Maybe a few corporations going bankrupt. And to keep that from happening, Harashima's legacy needed to be protected.

At least Josh saw it that way. Most of his team did. Devin, of course, had been the dissenter, the moral contrarian, to the metaphorical final breath. In a way, Josh felt bad for him. It couldn't have been easy to be an advocate of truth at the risk of public fallout among protectors of public interest. *Four against one.*

It was time for one last meeting. One not related to the Harashima case. But Josh felt it necessary.

An odd sense of finality washed over him as he stood by the whiteboard, waiting for his team to enter. Even though this technically wasn't a final farewell on his part. He had been working tirelessly with these people for wildly varying lengths

of time – twenty years at best – and while he knew he’d see them again, he could still only partially believe that he was finally deciding to take some time off. Thirty years he had worked in the police force and never had a vacation... until now.

He stared at the whiteboard. It was empty. Clear. Like a perfect mirror of his own mental state in the moment.

Then he heard the office door sliding open.

There they were. His team. They took their seats. It was time. Josh turned around and cleared his throat.

“I’ll keep this brief,” he began. *Yeah, please do*, he told himself. The sentimentality of the upcoming announcement was oddly overwhelming. Suddenly he wasn’t sure if he could speak.

But he forced it out of himself. “I’m going to be out of the office for a while. Feeling the need for a good, long vacation. Officer Walters will be handling lead investigative duties in my absence.”

A mix of surprise and amusement permeated the room. *Yeah. The workaholic superior taking some time off? Shocking, I know.*

Out of everyone in the room, Jenn had the most surprised look on her face. “You’re naming *me* as your replacement?!” she hollered.

“Would you like me to name someone else?”

“I mean I am honored, but wouldn’t Shinji be more qualified? He’s been in the force longer than me.”

“You’re at least equally qualified based on personality

alone,” Shinji deflected, nonetheless appreciative of Jenn’s suggestion.

“I can’t honestly think of a better pick,” Devin agreed. “I trust Josh’s judgment.”

Then Goro asked arguably the most crucial question: “How long are you going to be out for?”

“Long,” Josh replied. “Three months at least.”

“After thirty years of working non-stop, I’d expect nothing less,” Shinji teased. But his next sentiment was a lot more serious. “Enjoy your time off.”

“Thanks.” Somehow, the way Josh spoke that word sounded hollow. Superficial. He pondered for a second. Then he cleared his throat again and continued: “You all did great. I couldn’t have solved this case without every single one of you.”

“Likewise, boss,” aired Goro.

“For what it’s worth...” came the beginning of a thought from Devin. Everyone else turned their heads to him, curious to hear what he was about to say. He almost never began a thought this way.

Then he continued. “I think you made the right call in the end. But on the other hand, so did Miss Harady. Her evidence just made everything feel that much more conclusive.”

The only thing Josh could think to produce in response to Devin’s sentiment was a nod.

“Wow,” Goro exclaimed teasingly. “Didn’t think I’d ever hear *you* saying anything like that.”

“Oh, screw you,” Devin jabbed back.

“We should get together for beers,” Jenn suggested at that point. “Celebrate Josh taking his first vacation in thirty years proper.”

“Can’t think of a more appropriate send-off,” Shinji replied. Neither could Josh. With a grateful warmth burning in his chest and a sentimental grin on his face, he ran his gaze across the room, across the faces of his beloved colleagues, and said the word he loved saying the most, though with a wholly different cadence this time: “Dismissed.”